

NOT A POTATO

THE LONG STRAIGHT

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Chapter 1 — The Overhead View

The man at the El Alto checkpoint had three languages in his mouth and Bashir gave him the wrong one first, on purpose, to watch which one he reached for to correct it. *Castellano* with the official's stiffness, then a slide of *Aymara* under it — *kamisaraki* — and the man's shoulders came down a centimetre, and the gate came up.

"You did that thing again," Naila said, from the back seat, not looking up from her tablet. "Where you make a friend out of a barrier."

"He was never a barrier. He was a man being paid to be one."

"That's what I said."

The road out of El Alto runs flat and brutal across the top of the world. La Paz had been a bowl of brick and breath below the airport, every street tilted, every breath short — Bashir had felt it the moment the plane doors opened, the way the air went thin and businesslike and declined to fully arrive in his chest. Four thousand metres and climbing. The cold here was not weather. It was a fact about the place that the place did not intend to argue.

Mara rode up front with the driver, camera off, which for Mara meant only that the camera was resting. She watched the *Altiplano* unspool the way she watched a room she didn't trust yet — corners first. The plain went on past anything Bashir's eye knew how to size. Pale ochre. Bone. Bunchgrass in tufts that the wind worked over like it was looking for something it had dropped.

"That's it," Naila said. "Top right of the windscreen. That's Sajama."

It stood alone. A white cone with a plume of cloud snagged on it, lifted up out of the plain like the plain had set one thing down very carefully and walked away. You could not look at it and not orient to it. Bashir found himself doing it without deciding to — the mountain went *there*, and so everything else went *not-there*, and the geography arranged itself around the choice.

“Bolivia’s highest,” Naila said. “Six thousand five hundred and forty-two. Dormant.” A pause. “It’s been politely dormant for a very long time and I would like it to continue.”

They reached Sajama village in the worst of the afternoon light, which here is the best — hard, clean, long, so the shadow of every adobe wall lay on the ground sharp enough to cut yourself on. Tin roofs. Woodsmoke going up straight in the still and then bending where the *surazo* found it. A herd of alpaca picking at the *paja brava* with the bored superiority of animals that have nothing to prove to anybody.

And on the flank of the mountain, where no tree had any business being, a forest. Low, gnarled, red-barked trees, the bark peeling in papery curls, the whole stand of them shorter than a man and older than the village. *Queñua*. The highest woodland on Earth, growing where the rules say woodland stops.

Niamh’s hands moved beside her, fast, to the interpreter, Bashir caught the shape of *that should not be there and but it is*.

It was the LIE that found the other thing first.

“There,” Frik said. “There-there-there.” His finger went out toward the plain north of the village, then jerked, then steadied. “White trucks. Generator. That’s — *kak* — that’s a base camp. That’s a funded base camp.”

Bashir followed the finger. Past the last estancia, where the plain ran flat to a low rise, there was a cluster of vehicles too clean for the road that had brought them, a marquee the colour of a corporate logo, and the unmistakable geometry of people working in a grid. A drone went up off the rise as he watched — a black asterisk lifting into the violet-deep sky, hung there, then sliding north along a heading.

“They started without us,” Mara said.

“They started without anybody,” Naila said. “Look at the spacing on those survey poles. They’ve gridded a square kilometre already. That’s days of work.”

Bashir read the marquee through the long lens of the air. He couldn’t make out the wordmark. He didn’t need to. He’d met its cousins on four continents — the outfit that arrives clean-handed and well-funded with a press release already written, that calls what it does *opening* and *protecting* and *bringing to the world*, and means, underneath all three, *taking*. Not villains. That was the thing he’d had to learn the hard way. Just people who were very sure the thing would be better off known the way *they* knew it.

A figure had stopped at the edge of the village to watch the drone go up. An older woman in a *pollera* and a bowler hat, a bundle of something herbed and dried in the crook of her arm, her face turned to the black asterisk in the sky with an expression Bashir could not read at this distance and Niamh, beside him, could.

Niamh’s hands went still. Then: *She isn’t surprised*, the interpreter said for her. *She’s seen it before. She’s deciding something.*

“Deciding what?”

Niamh watched the woman a moment longer. *Whether we’re more of them.*

The woman turned and went between two walls and was gone before Bashir had finished arranging the Aymara greeting he’d meant to offer her. He let it go unsaid. There would be a time. You did not walk up to a closed door and knock harder.

They set up in a room behind the village’s one guesthouse — adobe walls a half-metre thick, a single bulb, a paraffin heater that lost its argument with the cold by ten p.m. every night for the rest of their stay. Naila put the big screen up against the wall and the satellite tiles came down off the link slow, the high-altitude bandwidth wheezing.

And then the thing came up onto the wall, and the room went quiet in the specific way it does when six people are each separately failing to take it in.

From above, the plain was scribbled on.

Not scribbled — that was the wrong word, the first word, the word the eye reached for before the eye understood. There was nothing frantic in it. The lines ran straight. Dozens of them in the first tile, then Naila zoomed out and it was hundreds, then she zoomed out again and the screen could not hold it and she had to scroll, and scroll, and the lines kept coming — pale threads laid across the ochre, radiating from points, crossing, running to the horizon of the tile and off it and presumably on, dead straight, for as far as anyone had ever bothered to look.

“Okay,” said Frik, very quietly, which from Frik was the loudest thing in the room.

“Sixteen thousand kilometres,” Naila said. “That’s the working estimate. Of line.” She let it sit. “The continental United States is about four and a half thousand across. So this is —” her hand moved, doing it — “roughly three times the width of America. Drawn. By foot.”

“How many people drew Nazca’s reputation?” Mara said. “And nobody’s heard of this.”

“Twenty-two thousand square kilometres of patterned ground,” Naila went on. “Fifteen times the extent of Nazca. It’s very likely the largest single piece of artwork any human has ever made. Anywhere. Ever.” She turned from the screen. “And it is one of the least studied things on the planet.”

Bashir watched the lines and felt the awe come up cold and clean off the screen, and felt, underneath it, something that wasn’t awe at all and that he didn’t have a word for yet in any of his languages.

The official story was not a mystery. That was what he kept having to hold onto, looking at the impossible scribble. The story was *known*. A British filmmaker named Tony Morrison had brought it to the outside world in the 1970s — pilgrimage lines, scored across the plain by the Aymara, linking the *wak’as* and the *chullpas* and the villages and, later, the white colonial chapels that the practice had simply absorbed into itself the way it absorbed everything, without surrendering the older centres. The University of Pennsylvania had surveyed it. *Tierra Saja*. It was real, it was understood, it was alive, it was *theirs*. The lines stayed bright because the feet kept walking them and scraping the dark surface stones aside to the pale subsoil beneath. Stop walking and the plain would take them back inside a generation.

Three thousand years. The lines were ancient when the Inca arrived. Nazca fell silent and went to ruin and to legend. Sajama never fell silent. Sajama was being walked *this morning*, probably, by the woman with the bowler hat and the bundle of herbs.

Known. Reverently, thoroughly known.

And Bashir kept his eyes on the screen and could not, for the life of him, make the knowing fit the thing.

“Naila.” He didn’t look away from the wall. “Pick one. A long one.”

She did. She found a single thread and traced it, and zoomed, and the tile resolved, and the line ran across the screen straight as a ruled edge — and ahead of it, square in its path, a ridge.

It hit the ridge and it did not bend.

“That’s —” Frik started.

“It climbs it,” Naila said. “Watch.” She followed the line up the contour, the elevation shading darkening under it, the line going up and over the rise without so much as a degree of give. “It doesn’t go around. There’s flat ground forty metres to either side. It goes *over*.” She measured it with the tool, two clicks, the number coming up on the wall. “That segment’s nineteen-point-something kilometres. About a metre wide. And I cannot find —” she scrolled the line end to end, hunting, the way Naila hunted, refusing to be wrong about what she wasn’t finding — “I cannot find the bend. Anywhere. Over the hill, through the wash, out the other side. It holds the bearing.”

“So they sighted it from up high,” Mara said. “Stood on the mountain, picked the far point, walked to it.”

“From where?” Naila pulled the view up, set the line against the terrain. “There’s no vantage. There’s no point on the ground where you can see both ends of a twenty-kilometre line over a ridge. The ridge is the whole problem — it *blocks* the line of sight. That’s why surveyors use instruments. You can’t eyeball past a hill that you yourself can’t see over.” She sat back. “And there are no instruments. No theodolite, no chain, no plan anyone has ever found. No central authority telling everyone where to put the next one. Decentralised. Built piecemeal. Over three thousand years.”

The bulb buzzed. The heater ticked.

“The published survey says it plainly,” Naila said, and she read it off her notes flat, no spin on it, the cold eye she was so good at. *“Neither the purpose nor how the makers achieved such precision is completely understood.”*

Nobody said anything for a while.

Then Frik, who could not help it, who never could, said in a small voice the thing the room had been circling: “No king made this. No engineer. No — *fok* — no boss. Nobody ever stood anywhere and saw the whole thing. And every one of them — every separate person, three thousand years of them — kept the line straight over the hill they couldn’t see over.” He blinked. “Why would you do that? Why would you all — *agree* — to do the hard thing? For thirty centuries? With nobody making you?”

Naila looked at the line on the wall. “That’s not the question I can answer,” she said. “I can tell you it’s real. I can tell you it’s not woo and it’s not footpaths and it’s not impossible. I can tell you it’s *harder* than either of those, by hand and by foot.” She turned the screen brightness down a notch, like the line was tiring her eyes, which maybe it was. “I just can’t tell you how.”

Late, when the heater had given up and the others had gone to find what warmth there was, Bashir stayed with the screen.

He pulled the view all the way back out. The whole network, what they had of it, every thread at once. From up here it was beautiful and it was total and it explained nothing — a vast and perfect god’s-eye image of the largest thing his species had ever drawn, and the longer he looked at it the more certain he became that he was looking at the wrong thing entirely.

Because the makers had never seen this. Not one of them. Not the first walker three thousand years ago, not the woman with the herbs this afternoon, not anyone in between. There was no satellite then. There was no drone then. There was no *up*. Whatever the lines were, whatever held them straight over ground no eye could survey, it had never once depended on the view he was sitting here drinking in. The view was his. It had never been theirs.

Out on the rise to the north, the adversary’s drone was a faint moving

light against the violet sky, mapping by night now, climbing higher, hunting for exactly the angle Bashir already had on the wall in front of him and was beginning to understand was useless.

Solving it from above. The way Nazca got *solved*.

Somewhere out in the dark the woman in the bowler hat was — what. Asleep. Or not. Reading the room the way Niamh read it, the way they all read everything, because the world had never once let any of them stop watching it. Deciding whether they were more of *them*.

Bashir looked at the screen, at the sixteen thousand kilometres of bearing held by feet across three thousand years, and he reached for the word for what he was feeling, in every language he had, and came up — for the first time he could remember — short in all of them.

He turned the screen off. The line on the wall went dark and the line on the ground, out there, stayed exactly where it was.

You couldn't read it from here. You'd have to walk it.

And that was not yet his to do.

Chapter 2 — The Mapping Team

The generator started before the sun cleared the ridge, and Mara heard it the way she heard everything now — as a thing that might be a thing, or might be nothing, her body deciding before her mind got a vote. Diesel. Steady. Not a vehicle. A camp.

She came out of the tent with the cold in her teeth and the cone of Sajama hanging over the plain like a held breath, pink at the snowline, and she stood there a moment letting the mountain do what it did to people, which was make them small and quiet, before she turned toward the noise.

Across the flat, maybe a kilometre off, white shapes had grown overnight. Not adobe. Not tin. Domed tents, the expensive kind, with a flysheet that snapped in the surazo and a logo on it she couldn't read at this distance but could already tell was *designed* — a word she'd used about a hundred press kits and never once as a compliment.

"They moved fast," Naila said behind her. She had her hands wrapped around a tin mug and her hood up and her eyes on the white shapes with the flat attention she gave a circuit diagram. "Yesterday that was empty ground."

"Yesterday they were a rumour." Mara lifted the long lens out of habit, framed the camp, and then — out of a newer habit, the one she was still learning — lowered it again without pressing the shutter. Just looked. Six domes. A larger marquee. Two pickups, dust to the windows. A drone case open on a folding table, foam cut to shape, the foam empty. So the drone was already up. She tilted her head

back and found it: a fleck against the violet zenith, holding a slow box over the plain, methodical as a printer.

“They’re surveying,” Naila said.

“They’re announcing.” Mara had been to enough launches to know the difference. A survey is quiet. This had a marquee.

They walked over after breakfast because not-walking-over would have meant pretending, and Bashir said pretending was a thing you could smell. He led, which was correct; the language went in front. Frik came because Frik came, hands jammed in his pockets, jaw working on a syllable he was sitting on hard. Niamh came with the small notebook she read faces into, and her interpreter, Tomás, a quiet Bolivian-Welsh kid who’d learned BSL in Swansea and Aymara from his grandmother and had the rare gift of disappearing while he worked. Mara brought the camera and a promise to herself about it.

The man who met them at the edge of the camp was about forty, fleece and good boots, the unhurried friendliness of someone whose funding was secure. “You’re the documentary lot,” he said, in English, before Bashir had said a word in anything. “Word travels. There’s about nine people on this plain and four of them are us.” A grin. “Daniel. Daniel Roeg. I’m running the survey.”

“Bashir.” A small nod, and then — Mara watched him do it, watched him *choose* — he stayed in English, matched Daniel’s register exactly, the easy mid-Atlantic of a man who’d done a lot of conferences. He could have gone anywhere. He went where Daniel already was. The door half-opened. Daniel relaxed another notch.

“Come see,” Daniel said. “We’ve got coffee that didn’t come out of a sachet.”

The marquee was warm and bright and smelled of real coffee and hot electronics. A bank of monitors along one wall, and on the largest of them the plain laid out in false colour — the lines picked out in hot pink against a cool grey ground, a web of them, radiating, crossing, running off the edge of the frame and on, and on.

“LiDAR composite,” Daniel said, with the helpless pride of a man showing you his child. “Drone-flown, ground-truthed. Six weeks of

flying. We've mapped"— he touched the screen and the figure ticked up in a corner —"call it eleven thousand kilometres of confirmed line so far. We think the real number's north of sixteen."

"It is," Naila said.

He glanced at her, recalibrating. "You've read the Tierra Sajama work."

"I've read everyone's work." Naila wasn't being rude. She was being accurate, and accuracy in her came out flat as a ruler. She stepped close to the screen, close enough that the false colour lit her face pink, and traced one line with a fingertip — a long one, running from a node near the mountain's foot straight off toward the south, over what the topo shading showed clearly as a ridge. It did not bend at the ridge. It climbed it.

"That one," she said. "How long?"

"Bit under twenty K." Daniel was pleased to be asked. "Beautiful, isn't it. Dead straight over that whole rise. We've got bearing-deviation under half a degree across the run."

"With what instrument?"

"Total station, GPS base, the usual—"

"No." Naila turned to look at him, and Mara felt the temperature of the conversation change, the way you feel a cloud cross the sun. "Them. The makers. With what instrument."

Daniel opened his mouth, and Mara watched a small honest thing happen on his face, a thing she liked him more for. He didn't have an answer. He knew he didn't. "That," he said, "is the question, isn't it. Best guess is incremental. You sight short segments, you correct as you go, errors cancel over distance—"

"Errors don't cancel," Naila said. "Errors accumulate. That's what errors do." She looked back at the screen, at the line that climbed the ridge instead of skirting it, the line that had cost more to make than the easy line beside it which did not exist because no one had ever wanted the easy line. "If you walk a bearing by eye over a hill you can't see past, you drift. Every time. Half a degree over twenty kilometres is"— her lips moved —"under two hundred metres of lateral error. They held it to that. By foot. Over three thousand years,

by *different* feet.” She said it the way another person might say *and then the bridge held*, with a kind of cold awe that had no room in it for the word *miracle* and no patience for the word *easy*.

The marquee was quiet. The drone hummed somewhere overhead, mapping.

“Yeah,” Daniel said, softer. “It does that to you, doesn’t it.”

While Naila and Daniel orbited the screen, Mara drifted, because drifting was how she saw. There was a folding table with the press kit fanned across it, the laminate catching the worklights, and she let her eyes graze it the way she’d graze a room before she lifted a camera in it.

UNLOCKING THE GREATEST ARTWORK ON EARTH, the cover said, over a drone shot of the lines so over-saturated the subsoil glowed like neon. Inside: phrases. *First complete survey. Definitive map. The mystery, solved.* A timeline. A rendering — and here Mara’s drifting stopped, because the rendering was an artist’s impression of a *visitor centre*, glass and rammed earth, tasteful, low, with a viewing platform and a little dotted path leading out onto a line, and tiny rendered people in tiny rendered anoraks walking it with their tiny rendered phones up.

A second board, behind it. *PROPOSED INTERPRETIVE TRAIL*. A map with one of the long lines highlighted in friendly orange, waymarked, with icons — a viewpoint, a rest stop, a QR code on a post.

She didn’t photograph it. She wanted to. The frame was *right there*, the whole argument of the book in one laminate, the gloss render of the path next to the screen showing the real one. She felt the old pull in her shutter finger, the war-photographer’s reflex that had never once asked permission, that had taken the worst day of a stranger’s life and made it a prize-winning rectangle. She breathed. She let it go. Some images you don’t take, not because you can’t, but because taking them is the same gesture as the render: lifting the thing out of the feet that made it and hanging it on a wall.

But she read it. Reading it was hers.

“Roeg,” she said, casual, camera down. “The trail. The waymarked

one. Whose land does it cross?"

A small pause. The right kind of question landing in the wrong kind of silence.

"It's a partnership," Daniel said. "Community partnership. We've got a memorandum with the regional—" he caught himself. "We're talking to people. It's early."

Across the marquee, Niamh's hand moved against her thigh, low, the small private sign she made to Tomás that meant *watch*. Tomás watched. Mara watched Niamh watch.

The thing about Daniel Roeg, Mara decided, watching him pour her coffee he didn't need to pour, was that he was not a villain and would have been so much easier if he were. He believed it. The visitor centre, the trail, the QR posts — he believed they were *saving* the lines. He said so, unprompted, in the warm tent, with the genuine feeling of a man who'd flown six weeks of drone box-patterns over the most beautiful thing he'd ever mapped and could not bear the thought of it being forgotten.

"Nobody's heard of them," he said. "That's the scandal, isn't it? Fifteen times Nazca. The biggest thing people ever drew. And Nazca gets a quarter of a million visitors a year and a UNESCO listing and these"— he gestured at the screen, the hot-pink web —"get *me*. Get a Penn project from the nineties and a film from the seventies and then thirty years of nothing. If we don't put them on the map, properly, with infrastructure, with a *story* people can follow, they vanish. The young people leave for El Alto, the walking stops, and you know what happens then." He looked, for a second, genuinely stricken. "It greens over. The line you saw climb that ridge. Three thousand years and it greens over in *forty*, because the feet stopped."

It was, Mara thought, the most dangerous kind of true. He had the fact exactly right. The line lives by the walking. Stop and it dies. And from that true fact he had built a glass visitor centre and a QR post, the way you'd build a fence to save a wild thing, never noticing the fence was the thing that killed it.

Bashir hadn't spoken in a while. Mara found him at the marquee's open flap, looking not at the screens but out — out across the real

plain, where, perhaps two hundred metres off, three figures had appeared. Aymara. An older woman in a bowler hat and layered pollera, two younger walkers behind her. They had stopped at the edge of the camp's churned ground, where the pickups had cut the surface, and they were not coming closer. They were looking at the white domes the way you look at something pitched on your floor.

The older woman's eyes went up — to the drone, the fleck in the violet, holding its slow box over the lines. She watched it for a long moment. Then she said something to the two behind her, short, and the three of them turned and walked back the way they'd come, out onto the pale ground, in a single file that was, Mara saw, dead straight.

"What did she say?" Mara asked. Quietly. Just to Bashir.

He didn't answer at once. His whole gift was reaching all the way in, and Mara watched the cost of it cross his face — that he *had* reached, that he'd caught it on the wind, and that he was deciding something about whether it came back out of his mouth in English in a tent full of monitors.

"She said," Bashir managed, and then stopped. Tried again. "It's — the verb. There's a verb. It means *to read aloud while walking*. One word." He looked at the drone, and then at the glowing screen, the plain rendered in colours no maker ever saw. "She said the machine is looking at the words and can't hear them."

Behind them, the figure on Daniel's monitor ticked up. *11,140 km confirmed*. The drone hummed. The marquee was warm and bright and smelled of good coffee and the thin electric ozone of everything that could be measured.

Frik, by the press kit, had been holding it a long time. Too long. The plain was quiet and the generator was steady and the word came out of him the way it had to, sudden and loud and entirely uninvited:

"Wrong map!"

Daniel turned, startled. Frik's jaw clenched, his hands flat against the table, his face doing the thing it did — the apology and the helplessness and the truth all at once. Tomás, gently, started to explain the Tourette's, and Daniel, to his credit, waved it off kindly, *no, no, all good*.

But Mara was watching the laminate under Frik's hands. The orange trail. The friendly waymarks. The QR post out on a line that the old woman, just now, had read aloud as she walked it, in a verb the survey didn't have.

Wrong map. It was, she thought, the only thing anyone had said all morning that was completely accurate, and it had come out of the one of them who could least help saying it, and Daniel had filed it under *symptom* and poured more coffee.

The drone changed pitch, banking for its next pass.

"Daniel," she said. "When does the press launch run?"

He brightened, back on solid ground. "Three weeks. We've got two networks and a streaming deal interested. *The mystery, solved.* Big reveal." He grinned the secure grin. "Why — you want in? Plenty of room for the documentary lot."

Out on the plain, the three figures had become one, a single dark stroke a long way off, holding their line over the ground toward the foot of the mountain, getting smaller, not bending.

Mara looked at them, and looked at the screen, and said nothing at all.

Chapter 3 — The Potato Line

The stakes went in at first light because Naila wanted the cold for it. Cold meant the air sat still. Still air meant the laser held its dot without the heat-shimmer that, by ten o'clock, would turn a clean red point at four hundred metres into a trembling smear the width of a fist.

She set the total station on its tripod and let it find level on its own, the little bubble crawling to centre, and she breathed the way the altitude made you breathe — shallow, often, never quite enough. The instrument cost more than the truck. It could turn an angle to a fraction of an arc-second and shoot a distance to a millimetre against a prism, and it did not care that it was four thousand and something metres up a volcano's skirt with frost still grey on the *paja brava*. It only cared about physics, which was the thing Naila liked about it. Physics did not change its mind. Physics did not look at you sideways when you stilled your thumbnail against your teeth, did not need eye contact, did not require you to guess what it wanted. You gave it a backsight and a foresight and it gave you the truth.

Bashir was somewhere behind her, talking. He was always somewhere, talking. This morning it was to the four walkers who had come up the slope without being asked and now stood at a polite distance with their hands in their *lluch'u* sleeves, watching the foreigners build their machine. One of them — the older woman, Doña Justina, who Bashir had named the first night the way you'd name weather — said something low. Bashir laughed, his real laugh, the one that climbed.

"What," said Frik, who was holding the prism pole and trying not to.

"She asked if it's a telescope." Bashir's grin did not leave his face when he answered her in Aymara and the answer made her chin lift. "I told her it measures the world. She said the world is right there, you can just look."

She's not wrong, said the fish.

The fish was not a fish. The fish was the thing in Naila's head she'd been calling the fish since she was nine, the heckle that arrived when something was about to be embarrassing, and it had the timing of a comedian and the loyalty of none. She put it away and looked through the eyepiece.

The plan was simple. The plan was a sentence: lay one straight line, two hundred metres of it, over the small ridge to the east — the modest one, not even a real ridge, a swell in the plain with a spine of dark stone — using everything the ancients did not have. A total station. A GPS rover that talked to satellites. A laser. Daylight. A printed bearing. Five people, all of whom could read. They were not going to scrape the line; that would take weeks and they had not earned the right to scrape anything here. They were going to *peg* it. Stakes every twenty metres, dead on the bearing, and then they would stand back and photograph a string of stakes marching arrow-straight over the rise, and Mara would have her before-and-after, and they would understand, in their bodies, what the Aymara had done sixteen thousand kilometres of by foot.

That was the plan. Naila loved the plan the way she loved any plan, which was completely, right up until the world got involved.

She shot the first peg herself. Set the bearing, sent Frik out with the pole, talked him left, right, left a hair, *there*, and Bashir hammered the stake while Frik held it plumb. Forty metres. Eighty. The dot sat on the prism like it was glued. The pegs came up white against the ochre, a clean dotted line drawn by mathematics, and for eighty metres Naila felt the specific, narrow joy of a thing going right.

Then the ground stood up.

You could not see the ridge from the instrument, was the problem. That was the entire problem, and she had known it abstractly and now knew it the other way. The swell of stone rose just enough that the last two pegs went behind it. The prism vanished. The dot had

nothing to land on. You cannot sight a line through a hill; light does not bend, which was the second thing Naila liked about physics and the first thing that betrayed her now.

So you leapfrog. You move the instrument up to the last good peg, you backsight onto the one behind it to re-establish the bearing, and you carry on. Every surveyor knows this. It is not hard. It is just where the error lives.

She moved the station. She set up over the eightieth-metre peg, levelled, found the backsight, turned the angle. And here was the thing the printed bearing did not tell you: to re-aim along the line, you sight *backward*, down the line you already have, and then you flip the scope a hundred and eighty degrees to look forward. The instrument does this perfectly. It plunges the telescope and the line of sight comes out the other side true to a few arc-seconds. But the *setup* — the centring of the instrument over the peg, the levelling, the human reading of the human-placed stake that was itself a millimetre off — all of that has a slop in it. A tiny one. A few millimetres of centring error over a peg, eighty metres back, fans out into centimetres ahead, and you do it again at the next ridge, and again, and the errors do not cancel. They are not polite. They accumulate, the way a rumour does, each retelling sworn true.

“How is it,” Mara asked. She had the camera down at her hip, not up. She’d been doing that more.

“Fine,” said Naila, which was true at one hundred metres and becoming a lie.

By a hundred and forty they had crested the stone spine and started down the far side, and Naila put her eye to the scope to check the closing bearing back along the whole run, and the fish laughed first, before she’d even understood why.

The line bent.

Not much. You could not have seen it standing at one end with the naked eye — Doña Justina’s eye, the world’s right there, just look. But the instrument saw it, because that was the entire reason the instrument existed. The far pegs had wandered. The leapfrog had walked the line a degree and change off true, a slow drunk drift accumulated across two setups, and the last peg sat nearly three metres south of

where the bearing said it should be. Three metres in two hundred. Over twenty kilometres, that error, faithfully repeated, would put the far end of the line the better part of a kilometre into the next valley.

Naila straightened up. Her lungs were doing their high-altitude arithmetic, in and in and never quite enough, and the cold had got into the metal so the focus knob bit her fingers, and she looked down the run of white pegs at the visible, measurable, undeniable curve in a line laid by five literate people with a machine that cost more than the truck, in daylight, with a plan.

“It’s a potato,” said Frik.

“It’s not—”

“It’s a potato.” He was delighted, the way the Tourette’s sometimes made him delighted, riding the word. “Potato. Pot-ato. We made a potato.” He clamped his jaw, breathed, let it go. “Sorry. But we did.”

The fish, traitor, agreed. *You built the wrong thing very precisely.*

She wanted to argue. She did the thing she always did, which was to find the error and name it, because a named error is a defeated one — *centring slop, two iterations, leapfrog accumulation, I can correct for it, give me a third setup and a forced-centring tribrach and I’ll bring it back under a centimetre* — and all of that was true. She could fix this. With more instruments and more time and a closed traverse she could lay a line so straight it would shame the mountain.

And the moment she thought it, the size of the real thing arrived, the way altitude arrives, all at once and from underneath.

Because she had a backsight. She had a peg behind her to re-aim from. She had a printed bearing to chase and a closing check to tell her she’d failed. The makers had none of that. There was no master line drawn somewhere to copy. There was no peg from last year to leapfrog off — there was only the scraped trail itself, holding its own bearing, and across the ridge, on ground a maker standing on the near slope could not see, the line came up the far side *still true*. Not corrected after the fact by a man with an instrument. Held. By a method she could not name, walked by people who could not have closed a traverse because there was nothing to close it against, across hills exactly like this one and worse, for twenty kilometres, and then for the next line, and the next, until the count ran to sixteen

thousand and the years ran to three thousand and no king had ever stood on a vantage and said *that one's drifting, bring it back*.

She had three metres of error in two hundred. They had effectively none, over ranges that made hers a rounding fault, and they had no eye that could see what she could see and no machine to do her arithmetic and no hill high enough to read it from, because the only hill was the mountain and you cannot stand on a mountain and see a line on the ground at the mountain's foot; the angle is wrong, the curve of the swell hides it, light does not bend.

"Mara," she said. "Come look through this."

Mara came. She set her eye to the scope and was quiet, and then she said, "Oh," very softly, the way you say it at a thing you didn't expect to be moved by, and she did not raise the camera. She stood back up and looked along the pegs the way you'd look down them yourself, and then she turned and looked at the four walkers standing in their patient distance, hands in their sleeves, and something passed over her face that Naila could not read but knew the shape of, because Mara was the one who read faces for all of them and to see her caught by one meant it had cost.

Doña Justina had come a few steps closer to look at the pegs. She did not look impressed and she did not look unimpressed. She looked the way Naila's grandmother used to look at a thing a child had built and was proud of — kind, and entirely unfooled. She said something to Bashir, and waited while he turned it over, and Naila watched Bashir's face do the work it always did, the small frown of a man weighing whether a sentence could even survive the crossing into another tongue.

"What did she say," Naila asked.

Bashir took a moment. "It loses something."

"Tell me anyway."

"She said—" He stopped. Started again, slower, the way he did when he was being careful not to round off the corners. "She asked why we're holding the line up with sticks. And I started to explain the bearing, the angle, all of it. And she let me finish, which was kind, and then she said—" His mouth did something complicated. "There's a verb. It's not *measure* and it's not *make*. It's closer to *say*. She said

you don't hold the line up. You hold the line up *by saying it*. And the sticks—" He gestured at the white pegs, the curve in them caught now in the climbing light. "The sticks are quiet. So they wander."

The sticks are quiet, said the fish, with no joke in it for once.

Nobody said anything. The *surazo* had started, the morning wind, lifting a little grit off the swell and ticking it against the tripod legs, and far off and above and white past saying, the cone of Sajama stood in the violet-deep sky and presided over all of it — over the pegs and the machine and the five literate foreigners and their three metres of honest error, and over the bright old scraped line a hundred metres south that none of them had walked yet, that came over its own ridge without a stick to hold it and did not wander, and had not wandered while empires rose and forgot it, because something kept saying it, and the saying held the bearing, and Naila with all her physics did not know the verb.

She crouched and looked along her own line one more time, at the curve she could prove and could not undo, and then past it to the other one. She had come here certain that the question was *how did they keep it straight*. She had the instrument to answer that question and the instrument had answered the wrong one. The right question was standing behind her in a knitted hat with its hands in its sleeves, and it had let Bashir finish, which was kind, and it had not, she understood now, told them anything it didn't choose to.

"Leave the pegs," she said.

"You don't want the—" Frik began.

"Leave them. Mara, don't shoot them straightened." She got up, knees cold, lungs short. "Shoot them bent. That's the picture."

Behind her, Doña Justina had turned to start back down the slope, and she said one more thing as she went, easy, over her shoulder, and Bashir's laugh climbed after it, and he did not translate this one. He just shook his head, smiling, and Naila found that she did not need him to. There were going to be sentences here that were not hers to carry, and this was one of them, and the not-knowing of it sat in her, for the first time in her measured life, like something she could live next to.

The walkers went down off the swell in single file, in order, saying

nothing she could hear. The line they were not on stayed bright in the long light, holding its bearing over the ridge for a reason no one on it had ever had to see.

Chapter 4 — A Meeting in Sajama

The chapel at Sajama village is the colour of nothing — a white that the altitude has scoured down past white into the bare idea of it, the lime washed thin by thirty thousand frosts. Bashir stood in its small square of shade and listened to the language he had come four thousand metres up to hear, and for the first time in his life he could not get into it.

Not the words. He had the words. He had spent the flight from La Paz, and the long cold drive, and two nights of thin sleep, pouring Aymara into the part of him that held languages the way a cistern holds rain — the suffixes that stacked like vertebrae, the three-way evidentials that made a speaker say *whether they had seen the thing themselves* before they were allowed to say the thing at all. A language where you could not lie casually because the grammar made you mark the seam between what you witnessed and what you were merely told. He loved it the way he loved a clean engine. It was the first thing in a week that had quieted the noise behind his eyes.

But the words were not the door.

Three women sat on a low adobe bench against the chapel wall, wrapped against a sun that burned and a wind that froze, both at once, the brutal arithmetic of this plain. Bowler hats. Layered *polleras* the colour of fruit. They were sorting something in a cloth — dried *ch'uñu*, the freeze-dried potato that the Altiplano had been making by leaving potatoes out in exactly this killing cold for longer than there had been a Spain to translate it into. Beside them sat the one Bashir had come for. The crew had been told a name only in the way you are told

a direction: *ask for the one who walks. She will be at the chapel, or she will not.*

She was old in the way the queñua trees on the mountain's flank were old — the highest forest on Earth, gnarled and red-barked and refusing, by some stubbornness no botanist had fully accounted for, to die at an altitude that should have killed it. She did not look up when the crew approached. She looked at the cloth.

"Let me," Bashir said, low, to Mara — and Mara, who had been raising the camera by reflex, the conflict-photographer's hand that found the frame before the mind found the manners, let it fall against her chest. She'd been getting better at that. He clocked the small cost of it in her jaw.

He crouched, not too close. He did not start with *hello*. He started, in Aymara, with the weather — the *surazo*, the wind that had come down off the cone in the night and rattled the tin — and he marked it, carefully, with the suffix that said *I felt this myself, I am not repeating it*. He had practised that one until it sat right.

The woman's hands stopped on the potatoes.

She said something to the three on the bench. One of them laughed — not unkindly, a short surprised bark — and answered, and Bashir caught it and felt his face go hot, because what she'd said was, roughly: *the foreigner has been studying*. The way you'd say it of a dog that had learned to sit. Affectionate. Devastating. He'd heard that tone in eleven languages and it always meant the same thing: *you have done the homework, and the homework is not the thing*.

"Oh, he ordered the phrasebook special," said the fish, who had wedged himself into the chapel's one cold shadow with the air of a creature who had personally negotiated the altitude down. "Two-day shipping. Now watch the woman who's been walking these lines since before this guy had a passport — a passport, plural, he's got like nine — out-talk him with one eyebrow."

The woman — *yatiri*, Niamh had signed to Bashir on the drive, the word lifting her interpreter's hands, *a reader, a keeper, do not call her a priest in your head, you'll get it wrong* — looked at Bashir directly for the first time. Old eyes, clear at this altitude the way everything

was clear, the air giving nothing the soft lie of distance.

“You speak it from a book,” she said, in Aymara, and marked it: *this I observe*.

“Yes,” Bashir said. He did not soften it. He marked his own answer the same way. *This I confess*.

That was the thing that moved her a centimetre. He saw it the way Niamh, two steps back, must have seen it whole — the micro-shift in the set of the shoulders, the door not opening but *unlatching*. Not because his Aymara was good. Because he had not pretended it was something it wasn’t. In a language built to mark the seam between the seen and the secondhand, he had told the truth about which side of the seam he stood on. That, and not the vocabulary, was the courtesy.

She went back to her potatoes. But she did not tell him to go.

Naila had drifted, as Naila did, to the edge of the square where a line came in.

It arrived from the north — you could not call it a path, it was too straight to be a path, too indifferent to the lie of the land. A scrape, a metre wide, the dark surface stones cleared away to show the paler subsoil beneath, running off across the plain toward a low ridge and not, Naila noted, *around* it. Over it. The line met the rising ground and went up it, dead-straight, and over the top, and was gone, and somewhere beyond it kept going for — she had done the sum on the satellite tile last night, on her tablet, in the truck — up to twenty kilometres. A scratch a metre wide and twenty kilometres long, held to a bearing that her tablet’s app, with its GPS chain and its drone-derived elevation model and its god’s-eye certainty, had measured at a deviation she’d had to zoom in three times to even see.

She crouched at the line and put her hand flat on the cold pale stone of it.

The whole network was like this. Sixteen thousand kilometres of it — she’d said the number aloud in the truck and Mara had said *say it again* and she’d said it again — sixteen thousand kilometres of scraped line, which was on the order of three times the width of the

continental United States, drawn by *foot*, across twenty-two and a half thousand square kilometres of plain, fifteen times the spread of the Nazca lines that the whole world had heard of, while this — the largest single drawing the human animal had ever made on the skin of the planet — sat here, barely studied, sorting potatoes in the sun.

And not one wheel. Not one instrument anyone had ever found. No plan in any archive. No king's name on any stone saying *I commanded this*. And the line went over the ridge instead of around it, holding its bearing for the bearing's own sake, refusing the easy ground.

"How," Naila said, to no one, to the line.

"She's gonna be doing that for the rest of the book," the fish observed. "Get comfortable."

The denial happened while they were still at the chapel, and they got to watch it.

A white Hilux came in off the plain trailing its own dust, too fast, the way the mapping team always drove, as if the altitude were a thing you could outrun. Two men got out and a woman in a fleece with a logo on it Bashir had already learned to read across a square: **Alti-Plano Heritage Initiatives**, which was a private outfit with a public-good name and a German-Bolivian funding stack and a very good drone and a press release, already issued, about *opening* and *protecting* and *bringing global attention to a neglected wonder*. They had drones up most days. They had a grid. They had, the village had heard, plans for a marked interpretive trail and a visitor structure and a parking area, and they had the kind of paperwork that in most places in the world was the same thing as permission.

The woman in the fleece walked toward the chapel with a tablet held out in front of her like a credential. She had a phrase ready, Bashir could see her loading it, and when she got close enough she delivered it — a memorised line of Aymara, gracelessly stressed, the suffixes all flat and wrong, the courtesy-greeting rendered with the warmth of a parking ticket. She had clearly been told it would unlock things.

The three women on the bench looked at her. The *yatiri* did not look up at all.

The woman in the fleece tried again, in Spanish, faster, with words like *collaboration* and *documentation* and *access for tomorrow*, and one of the women on the bench answered her in Spanish, briefly, and the only word Bashir needed was the last one, which was *no*, and which carried no apology in front of it.

“Translation,” murmured the fish. “She said no.”

The woman stood there with her tablet. She was not a villain. That was the thing Bashir kept having to hold onto — she had a real grant and a real belief that a thing barely studied was a thing being *lost*, and that she was the rescue. She believed her drone could see what no one had bothered to see. She had the god’s-eye view, the very tool that had cracked Nazca open for the tourist planes, and she was about to learn what the crew had already half-learned: that from above, this thing explained *nothing*. The image showed you the lines. It could not show you the one fact that mattered, which was that the lines were not looked at. They were walked.

She caught Bashir’s eye, recognised him for what he was — another outsider, better dressed for the altitude — and her face did a hopeful thing.

“You speak it?” she said in English. “Could you — if you could just translate, just tell her we only want to—”

“That’s the part I won’t do,” Bashir said, and was surprised by how easily it came out, how much it sat like the truth. The one gift he had — reaching all the way in, becoming whoever the next door needed — and here was a door he could feel he was *not* going to use it on. “She heard you fine.”

The woman’s jaw worked. She looked, for a second, like she might say the thing people in her position always eventually said — *they don’t even understand what they have* — and Bashir watched her decide not to, which was the most he could credit her with, and then she went back to her Hilux, and the two men got back in, and they drove off across the plain not toward the village now but toward the ridge, toward the line, with a drone case in the back, to go look at the thing from above because above was the only place they had been given.

It was the *yatiri* who broke the quiet, after the dust had settled.

She said something to the women on the bench, and stood — slowly, with the care of a body that had walked a great many kilometres at a height where every step is a small negotiation with the lungs — and she looked at the line where Naila still crouched with her hand on it, and then at Naila, and something passed over her face that Bashir could not read but Niamh apparently could, because Niamh's hands went still in a particular way that meant *watch this*.

The old woman walked over to Naila. Bashir came up quiet behind, ready to carry the words.

The *yatiri* looked at Naila's hand on the pale stone. Then she said, in Aymara, slowly, watching Bashir to see if it would land: "She wants to know how it stays straight."

Bashir translated it down to Naila — *she says you want to know how it stays straight* — and Naila looked up and nodded, once, hard, the whole question of her life in the nod.

The old woman almost smiled.

"From up there," she said, and tipped her chin at the sky, at where a drone would hang, at the satellite Naila had measured it from, "you can see that it is straight." A pause. The wind off the cone. "You cannot see why."

She let that sit. Bashir handed it to Naila word for word and did not add anything, did not gloss it, did not do the machine-thing of explaining what she meant — because he didn't know what she meant, not yet, and the not-knowing was suddenly the most honest thing in his chest.

Then the *yatiri* turned to Bashir directly, and marked the next thing with the suffix that meant *I have decided this, here, myself, now* — not repeated, not customary, a choice made in front of him.

"There is a walk," she said. "Before light. You may come and put your feet on it." She looked at Mara, at the camera dark against her chest, at the way it had stayed down. She looked at Naila's tablet, screen-down on the stone. "You may come and listen. Not to take."

She did not say what they would hear. She did not say what it was for. She turned and went back to the bench and the potatoes and the women and the white chapel, leaving the line running off across the

plain and over the ridge and gone, holding its bearing into the dark it had held for three thousand years, and the only thing she had given them was the smallest, most enormous word in any language Bashir carried.

Come.

The fish said nothing. Even the fish, for once, kept it down.

Chapter 5 — The Trailhead

The cold came up through the soles of Niamh's boots before the sun cleared the ridge, and she read the morning the way she read everything — by where the bodies pointed.

Six of them stood at the edge of a thing she could not yet see. The plain ran pale and frost-burned to the foot of the mountain, and the mountain stood over it the way a parent stands over a sleeping room: not watching, exactly, but present in a way that organised the air. Sajama. White at the top against a sky already going that bruised violet it only went up here, where there was too little atmosphere left to soften it. Below the snow, the red-barked queñua trees clung to the slopes in their impossible groves, gnarled and low, the highest forest on the planet and looking like something dreamed rather than grown.

Niamh did not look at the mountain long. She looked at Doña Rufina.

The old woman stood three paces ahead of the crew with her back to them, and her stillness was not the stillness of waiting. Niamh had spent her whole life inside silence, and she knew its dialects the way Bashir knew the seam where one language gave way to another. There was the silence of someone who hadn't decided. There was the silence of someone gathering. And there was this — the silence of someone who had already decided everything and was simply letting the morning catch up.

Beside her, Yola the interpreter signed low and close, fingers tucked in against the wind: *She's reading the ground.*

Niamh nodded. She'd guessed. The yatiri's eyes moved along something at her feet, slow, the way you'd run a finger down a page in a

script you'd known since childhood. There was a line there. Niamh could half-see it now as the light came round — a paler thread in the dark gravel, a hand's width, maybe two, running dead away from them toward the lower ridge and over it and gone. It did not waver. It did not consult the land. It went.

Forty metres off, the mapping team was setting up.

She felt them before she turned — a wrongness in the morning's weight, bodies clustered with the particular busy lean of people who are running a clock. Three of them, then four, around a tripod-mounted rig that caught the early sun on its lens housing. A generator coughed. A man in a clean technical jacket — Devereux, the one who shook hands like he was confirming a transaction — was walking the perimeter of where the line began with a tablet held out in front of him, framing it, framing the crew, framing Rufina's back.

Niamh watched his mouth. Distance and the angle made it hard, but she'd read worse. *...the radial origin point, you can see it converges right*— and then his face turned and she lost the rest in his cheek.

Frik had gone rigid the way he did when he was holding a sound down. His shoulder jerked once. He breathed through his nose, eyes on the team, and Niamh saw his jaw working at a word he wouldn't let out — not here, not at her back, *not at her back* he'd said in the truck last night, knuckles white, and Mara had said *you're fine, Frik, we're all white-knuckling it*.

Mara had her camera at her chest. Not up. Down.

Devereux's people had a drone on the ground beside the generator, rotors folded, a fat grey thing the size of a dinner plate. One of them — younger, sunburnt, eager — knelt over it. Niamh watched the way his hands moved and knew it was about to go up.

Rufina turned around.

She was not tall and she was not soft. Her face was the colour and texture of the plain itself, scored by sixty years of this sun and this wind, and her eyes when they came up off the ground and onto the crew were not unfriendly. They were *exact*. She looked at each of them the way she'd looked at the line — reading, placing — and Niamh felt herself read in turn and held still under it, the way you hold still

when someone competent is taking your measure and you want them to get it right.

Rufina spoke. Two words, maybe three, the Aymara coming out of her low and flat and final.

Bashir answered.

Niamh couldn't hear it but she could see the whole shape of what happened to it — to the morning, to Rufina's shoulders. Bashir had stepped half a pace forward and said something back in the same tongue, and it was the *register* of it that landed, Niamh could tell, the way his voice must have dropped and curved into a courtesy that wasn't on any phrasebook page. Rufina's eyebrows moved. Just a fraction. The corner of her mouth did something that wasn't a smile and wasn't not one.

He greeted her like a person, Yola signed, and there was respect in the interpreter's hands. Not — he didn't ask her anything. He just — said good morning the long way. The proper way.

Niamh had watched Bashir do this for three books now and it still cost her something to witness, a small clean ache. He reached people through the door of their own mouths and the door half-opened and you could see the room behind it warm by a degree. And then — she'd watched this too — he'd stand in that doorway and be unable to walk away, translating the menu, translating the argument at the next table, carrying every conversation in the place and never once just being inside one. The loneliness of it had a shape and the shape was *standing in doorways*.

The drone whined up off the gravel.

Niamh felt it before she saw it — a stutter in the air, a frequency that lived in her chest more than her ears. The sunburnt kid had launched it and it climbed fast, tilting toward the line, toward the ridge, toward the place where the pale thread crested and vanished. Going up to get the picture. The god's-eye. The thing that had cracked Nazca on a thousand magazine covers — *see, it's a hummingbird, it's a monkey, mystery solved, the makers must have had* — Niamh stopped the thought. She watched Rufina.

Rufina did not look at the drone.

That was the thing. That was the whole thing, and Niamh felt it go down her spine like cold water. The old woman did not give the climbing machine so much as a glance. She watched the crew, and she let the drone go up, and her face said — clearer than any sign, clearer than any word Yola could hand her — *let it. Let it see everything. It will see the line and it will not see one single thing that matters, and you all know this, and the fact that you know it is why you are still standing here and they are over there.*

Niamh's breath caught.

Up the slope the drone hung over the crest and pivoted, and even from here she could see the operator's posture change — the lean toward the screen, the small frustrated reset. Whatever he was getting, it wasn't resolving into anything. Lines on dirt. A thread that ran over a hill for no reason a camera could give.

Devereux was coming over.

He had the walk of a man who'd already won the meeting in his head. He came up to the edge — to the *edge*, Niamh noted, to where the gravel changed, and stopped there as if a wall stood at the line's first metre, because somebody had already told him and he had already learned what *no* sounded like out here even if he hadn't accepted it. He held the tablet at his side now. He'd put away the frame.

His mouth, close enough now to read clean: *Doña Rufina. With respect. My team has permits from the department, we've coordinated with—* a name Niamh didn't catch *—and all we're asking is a few of my surveyors on the trail behind your group. We document, we don't disturb. We're trying to protect this. Get it recognised. Funded.* He turned the tablet face-up, a brochure-bright render of the plain crossed with neat green lines, a logo in the corner. *A managed heritage corridor. Boardwalks at the sensitive points. We keep the lines from—*

Bashir translated. Niamh watched him do it and watched the cost in it, because translating a man who was lying with his whole sincere heart is its own kind of labour — Bashir had to carry every word of it faithfully into Rufina's tongue without letting his own face editorialise, and his face did not, and that was the discipline of him.

Rufina listened. When Devereux said *protect* she did not move. When

he said *boardwalks* something happened behind her eyes that Niamh would have called a wince in anyone else and called, in her, an old fatigue — the look of a person who has heard *we're here to help you* arrive over the top of the mountain her whole life and has buried most of the people who believed it.

She answered him in Aymara, four sentences, even and unhurried.

Yola translated for the crew, signing fast, her face apologetic at the bluntness of it: *She says the line does not need a boardwalk. She says a boardwalk is a thing you walk on. The line is a thing you walk.* A pause, the interpreter's hands hesitating over the next part. *She says — if the feet stop, the line goes back to the ground in a few years. The grass takes it. So a managed corridor with no feet on it is a — she used a word — it's a dead line. A picture of a line.* Yola's mouth tightened. *She says you can photograph a dead thing all you like.*

Devereux's face did the small math of a man recalculating. *Tell her, he said, we can arrange access for traditional users, of course, alongside the documentation phase, we'd never—*

He didn't finish, because Rufina had already turned away from him.

It was the cleanest thing Niamh had seen all morning. Not rude. Not a dismissal you could put in a complaint. She simply finished the conversation by ceasing to be in it, the way you close a book you've read the end of, and she turned to the crew and looked at them and the morning narrowed to the six of them and her.

She spoke. Yola's hands kept up.

You. Rufina's eyes went down the line of them and stopped, briefly, on Bashir, and then moved on, and Niamh understood that the stop had been the permission and the moving-on was that the permission was for all of them, given on his account. *You can come. To the next wak'a. Not far. You walk where I walk and you walk behind me and you do not walk on the line — you walk beside it, here—* and she gestured, a clear hand's-breadth to the right of the pale thread —*because the line is not for your feet.*

Niamh felt Naila beside her go very still and very alert, the particular attention Naila gave to a *rule*, a constraint, a thing with edges she could hold.

You can listen. Rufina went on. *Some of what I say I will say so you can hear it. Some of it is not for you and I will say it anyway and you will not ask what it was.* Yola's hands slowed here, careful, getting it exact. *The black box—* she meant Mara's camera, and Mara's hand had already tightened on it —*stays down at the places I tell you. You will know the places. If you do not put it down I will know, and that will be the last morning you walk.*

Mara nodded once. Niamh saw her thumb move to the lens cap and rest there, ready, and something in the older woman's shoulders eased a hair at the sight — she'd read Mara's hands the same way Niamh read everyone's, and she'd seen the answer before Mara gave it.

And you— Rufina looked at Bashir last, and what she said to him she said in Aymara, only to him, and she did not wait for Yola to render it. She watched his face take it.

Niamh watched it too.

Whatever it was, it was short, and it landed in him like a stone into still water — she saw the rings of it go out across his expression, surprise and then something more complicated, something that closed a door very gently from the inside. He did not translate it. Yola's hands stayed down; the interpreter looked at the ground, having understood and having understood, too, that it was not hers to pass on.

A sentence Bashir would not carry. Niamh filed it where she filed the most important things, the wordless things — the *won't say* she'd spent her whole life learning to tell apart from the *can't*. This was a *won't*. And it had been given to the one man in the world built to need it most, and he had — she watched him do it — *let it be his to keep*.

Rufina turned to the line.

Behind them the generator droned and the drone came down somewhere out of sight and Devereux's people gathered at the boundary they would not cross, and ahead the pale thread ran away over the frost-burned plain toward the lower ridge, dead straight, refusing the land, climbing the hill it had no reason to climb except that three thousand years of feet had said it would. The light was full now. The thread caught it.

Rufina stepped onto the morning beside her own line, and began to walk, and began to speak — low, steady, naming as she went — and the crew fell in behind her, one body's width to the right of the bright scraped sentence in the ground, and Niamh stepped off the gravel after them, into the rule and out of the camera's reach, with the mountain at her shoulder and the unread line running out ahead of her into a country that had never once been visible from above.

Chapter 6 — The First Steps

The line started at a rock.

Not a marked rock. Not a sign, not a cairn, not anything Mara would have framed without Rosa pointing first — just a hump of dark andesite the size of a sleeping dog, half-skinned with orange lichen, and beyond it the ground went pale. That was the whole announcement. The walking surface ran away from the rock toward the ridge in a strip maybe a metre wide, the colour of old bone against the rust-dark plain, and it did not waver.

Rosa stood at the rock with her hand resting on it the way you'd rest a hand on a gatepost you'd touched ten thousand times. She wasn't looking at the line. She was looking at the five of them.

Mara felt the look land. After eleven years of being looked at across checkpoints and through ruined doorways, she knew the difference between a person clocking your gear and a person clocking your *gait* — and Rosa was reading their feet. How Frik shifted, how Naila had already gone still and inward, how Bashir held his weight loose and ready. Mara had the camera up at her chest, lens cap off, finger off everything. She had decided that this morning, in the dark, lying in the cold adobe room listening to her own breath sound like someone else's: today she would carry it and not lift it. The strap was a known weight against her sternum. The not-lifting was the work.

"She says we go now," Bashir said. He said it quietly. His Aymara had a seam in it Mara couldn't hear but could see the effect of — the women at the rock had stopped treating him as furniture sometime yesterday, and now one of them, the old one with the green-and-

pink *aguayo* knotted across her back, had said something to him that made him laugh, short and surprised, and not translate it. “She says we go and we don’t talk going up.”

“Define talk,” said Frik, and then his shoulder jerked and his head ticked left, once, hard, and he breathed through it. “Sorry. Define talk.”

Bashir asked. Rosa answered without taking her eyes off the ground.

“She says —” Bashir paused, and Mara watched him hold something, weigh it, set part of it down. “She says *they* talk. We listen.”

They. The other walkers. Six of them besides Rosa, ages Mara couldn’t read at this altitude where everyone’s face was wind-cured to the same lacquered brown — and they were already moving, already on the line, not in single file exactly but threaded onto it, each finding the bright strip with their feet the way you find a kerb in the dark.

Mara stepped on.

The altitude took her in the first ten metres. Not dramatically — no swoon, no spots — just a tax, levied immediately and without appeal: a breath that didn’t fill, a heart that answered a gentle slope as though it were a flight of stairs. The air at four thousand metres is a liar. It looks like air. It is missing a third of itself. She’d shot in thin air before, Kashmir, the high passes, and she still hadn’t believed it until her lungs sent up the old report — *this is not enough, this is not enough* — on a grade her eyes told her was nearly flat.

The light was the other thing. The light was almost violent. It came down hard and clean and made the pale line glow against the dark ground like a filament, and overhead the blue went so deep toward the zenith it had a bruise in it, a purple at the top of the sky she’d only ever seen from aircraft. Sajama stood off to the right, white and indifferent, a cone so symmetrical it looked drawn. Everything looked drawn. Distance lied here too — a ridge ahead that her photographer’s eye filed at *twenty minutes* and her lungs would later correct to *an hour and a half*.

The walkers talked.

Not to each other, exactly. The old woman with the *aguayo* had be-

gun a low steady murmur the moment her feet found the strip, and it didn't stop. It rose and fell in a shape Mara recognised without understanding — the cadence of someone *naming*. Place after place. A word, a pause, a word. Sometimes the others answered, a single syllable dropped in like a stone into the rhythm, and the murmur went on. Bashir was three behind Mara and she could feel him listening with his whole spine, the way she listened with her whole eye, and once she heard him exhale like a man set down after carrying something a long way.

The clean grammar of it. She didn't know it was that, for him. She only saw his shoulders come down.

She kept the camera at her chest and let the picture build and not be taken: the thread of bone-pale ground, the strung-out dark shapes of the walkers, the white cone, the bruised sky. It was the best frame she'd had in two years. It would have run a cover. She held it in her chest where the strap was and let it go by.

The line met the ridge and did not turn.

That was the thing. She'd known it from the satellite tile, from Naila's drone footage glowing on a laptop in a cold room, from the dossier's flat sentence — *will not bend for a ridge*. She'd known it as a fact. Now her body learned it as an insult. The ridge came up — a brown shoulder of the plain, broken with loose dark stones, steep enough that the easy line, the line any sane animal would walk, ran obviously off to the left along the contour, a soft curve the eye begged for. The pale strip ignored it. The pale strip went *up*. Straight up the fall line, over the loose rock, over the false crest, and Mara's lungs filed a formal protest and were overruled, because the walkers went up without breaking stride or breaking the murmur, and the line went where the murmur went.

She climbed. Her thighs burned and her breath tore and the camera knocked once against her chest and she steadied it with one hand and kept the other free for balance and thought, with the part of her brain that never stopped composing even when her body was failing: *no one ever stood here and decided to do this. That's the whole — that's the —*

She lost the thought to a coughing fit and let it go.

Naila had gone past her on the climb. Mara saw it sidelong: Naila moving with a strange, economical certainty up the loose pitch, not fast, but without a single wasted negotiation, her eyes down on the strip and her lips moving in some count of her own — and Mara understood that Naila was measuring even now, climbing and measuring, that the slope and the loose stone and the refusal-to-bend were going into the same ledger where the woman kept the world. She'd argue it out later, on paper, with that fury she had when a thing wouldn't resolve. For now she climbed and counted and the line held its bearing under her feet the way it had held it under three thousand years of feet, and held it not because anyone was holding it but because *the walking held it* and the words held the walking, and Mara still didn't understand that, she only felt the edge of it the way you feel a drop in the dark before you see it.

At the false crest the old woman stopped.

Everyone stopped. The murmur didn't. The old woman stood with the wind taking the loose threads of her *aguayo* sideways and said three words to the rock that sat there — another dark hump, sister to the one at the start — and the others said the answering syllable, and then they were moving again, over the crest, and the line ran on across the next stretch of plain toward the next rise, perfectly, infuriatingly straight, a line of bone laid on the ochre by no one, for no one to see.

Mara reached the crest and turned, hands on her knees, lungs sawing, and looked back the way they'd come.

And there was the picture that explained everything. From up here you could see the line run back down the ridge and out across the plain, a pale seam stitched dead-straight to the horizon, the satellite shot made flesh, the god's-eye view she'd flown a drone to steal and could now simply see — the answer, the proof, the cover, the thing.

It explained nothing.

She stood and breathed and looked at it and felt the bottom drop out of something she hadn't known she was standing on. The straightness was *there*, plain as a ruled line, magnificent, impossible to argue with — and it told her not one thing about how a hundred separate generations of separate walkers, none of them up here, none of them with this view, had agreed on it. The view was hers. The view had

never been *theirs*. They'd made the line by walking it and naming it from down inside it, eyes on the bright strip a metre ahead, and the perfect straight seam she could see from up here was a thing the makers had produced and *never witnessed* — like a sentence that comes out grammatical from a mouth that can't hear itself.

She got the camera halfway up before she knew she'd moved.

The frame was right there. The line, the plain, the white cone, the walkers small and dark down on the seam. It would be the most beautiful, most sellable, most thieving image of her life — the aerial answer, the *here is the largest drawing on Earth and here is how it looks solved*. Her thumb found the dial. The light was perfect. The light was always perfect here, that was the trap.

She felt Rosa watching her.

Not down on the line — Rosa was up here too, must have come up last, behind all of them, and she was standing a little apart with her hand again resting on the crest rock and her eyes on Mara's hands. Not on the camera. On the hands. Reading what the hands were about to do, the way she'd read all their feet at the start.

There was no command in the look. That was what undid her. A command Mara could have argued with, photographed around, forgiven herself for breaking. This was just an old woman watching to see what kind of person had walked up her line, and being prepared, Mara understood, to be either kind of disappointed — the loud kind or the quiet kind, but disappointed either way, in a manner she'd survived disappointment from outsiders for three thousand years and would survive it from one more.

Mara lowered the camera to her chest.

The strap took the weight. The picture stayed in the air over the plain, unrecorded, the way the best ones always should have. Something in her ribs let go that she'd been holding since a doorway in Aleppo.

Rosa looked at the lowered camera for a moment. Then she said something, four or five words, dry, almost amused, and turned to start down the far side of the crest after the others.

Bashir came up beside Mara, still breathing hard, and he was almost laughing again, that same surprised short laugh.

“What did she say?”

He watched the old woman pick her way down onto the bright line, picking up the murmur as her feet found it, the naming starting again where it had paused.

“She said the bird with the eye in the sky,” Bashir said, “already came. Big one. Last month. Buzzed the whole valley, up and down, for a week.” He paused. “Then it went home and it still doesn’t know anything.”

Down on the plain, the line ran on toward the next rise without bending, and the wind came off Sajama with a edge of frost in it even now, even in the violent noonday light, and Mara stood on the crest with the most powerful tool in the world dead against her chest and understood — not the way Naila understood, on paper, but the way you understand a closed door is closed — that the drone had been useless from the start.

It had only just taken her this long to be high enough to see it.

She fell in behind Bashir, found the bright strip with her feet, and started walking down.

Chapter 7 — The Words in the Walking

The line started behind a chapel the size of a tool shed, whitewashed and leaning, and it went uphill in a way that no path with sense in it would.

Bashir saw that first — before the cold, before the burn already starting in his chest from a hundred metres of walking at four thousand metres. The line did not curve. There was a ridge ahead, a low brown swell of the plain with a saddle in it not two hundred metres to the left where any reasonable foot would have gone, and the line ignored the saddle the way a man ignores a beggar he has decided not to see. It walked straight at the high shoulder of the ridge and went up.

Elena went up with it.

She was ahead of him, the *yatiri*, a small woman in three skirts and a bowler hat the colour of wet slate, and she did not hurry and she did not stop. Her feet found the pale stripe of scraped ground and stayed inside it. Behind her walked two others from the village — an old man named Mauricio with a face like a dropped apple, and a girl maybe sixteen who Bashir had not yet heard speak. Then the crew, strung out and gasping. Naila counting her own steps under her breath. Mara with the camera down at her hip, not up, the strap doubled around her wrist. Niamh watching everyone's mouths and hands at once, the way she did, reading the walk like a sentence written in shoulders.

The fish was in the daypack, where it had no business being and where it insisted on living.

"This is a hill," it observed, from inside the canvas. *"You understand that's a hill. You're walking up a hill on purpose when there is a perfectly good not-hill right over there."*

"Yes," Bashir said quietly, in the register he used when he wanted a thing to subside.

"I'm just saying. Three thousand years of people. Not one of them goes 'lads, the saddle.'"

"No."

"It's a saddle. It's right there."

He let it go. The air did not leave room for argument; it barely left room for breathing. He had read, on the plane, all the things one reads — the *paja brava*, the diurnal swing, the way distance lies to you here so that a ridge an hour off is half a day's misery. He had not read the way it felt to be inside a sentence the ground was saying and to be too winded to listen.

Because that was the thing. Elena was speaking.

Not to them. She had begun it at the chapel, low, almost under the breath, and she had not stopped, and the others took it up in pieces — not in unison, not a chant you could write down, but more like the way a family finishes each other's prayers, one voice carrying a phrase and another catching the tail of it. Bashir's ear did what his ear always did. It could not not.

Sara. He had that one. Sara — to go, to walk; but here, walking it, the word turned in his mouth into something nearer *the going itself*, the act with the name folded into it. Then a place-word he didn't have, a name, three syllables with the glottal catch in the middle that Spanish never taught a tongue to make. Then *thakhi*. He had *thakhi* — road, way, path. But she said it the way you'd say a person's name, and the old man Mauricio said it back to her, soft, like agreement, like yes, *that one, that's the one we're on*.

Bashir had walked into more rooms in more tongues than he could count. He had stood at a checkpoint in Sarajevo as a child and become, in four sentences, a boy whose papers made sense. He had ordered tea in Tigrinya from a man who wept because no one had spoken to him in it in eleven years. He knew the exact warmth of the

door half-opening — the way a face changes when you reach it in the language it dreams in. He had built a whole self out of that door.

This was not that.

He was inside the language. He was *getting* it — the grammar of it lay open in his ear, clean and old and beautifully tight, the suffixes stacking up the way Aymara stacked them, evidential markers telling you not just *what* but *how you came to know it*, whether you saw it or heard it or were merely told. A language that built doubt and witness right into the verb. He loved it the way he loved a clean machine. And he understood, climbing, with the burn moving up into his throat, that the *meaning* was somewhere he was not.

He had the words. He did not have the saying.

They came over the shoulder of the ridge and the plain opened on the far side, and Sajama stood across all of it.

The mountain did that. You forgot it was there — it hid behind your own labour, behind your feet — and then the ground gave you a horizon and there it was, the cone, white past white, so clean against the violet-deep zenith that it looked cut from the sky rather than standing in it. Mara made a sound. The camera stayed at her hip. Bashir watched her hand tighten on the strap and not lift, and he thought: *that's costing her*, and then he had no more thought to spare because Elena had stopped.

She stopped at a stone.

It was nothing. A grey rock, knee-high, with a paler stone resting on top of it that had clearly been placed and replaced a thousand times, the lichen worn off where hands went. A *wak'a*. The line ran straight up to it and straight away from it on the far side, on toward the next pale node out across the plain, kilometres off, and Bashir understood — the way you understand a hinge — that this was a word in the sentence. A place where you said the thing.

Elena said the thing.

She said a phrase Bashir did not have, four words, and the girl said it after her, and Mauricio said it after the girl, each of them touching the placed stone, not lifting it, just resting two fingers on it and lifting

them again. And then — this was the part — Elena said a different phrase, shorter, and the other two did *not* repeat it. They went quiet for it. They let her have it alone.

Bashir's ear caught all of it and his mind, traitor that it was, was already laying it out: *that first phrase, formulaic, a greeting-form, you'd say it to a person — they're greeting the stone, no, they're greeting the place, no —* and the second phrase he did not have at all, a verb-stem he half-knew with a suffix he'd never met, and the *want* came up in him so fast it frightened him.

The want to ask. The want to reach all the way in.

It was the only hunger he'd ever fully trusted in himself. Other people wanted money or to be loved or to be right; Bashir wanted the inside of a sentence, and that want had kept him alive across more borders than he could number. It was not a flaw he'd been taught to hide. It was the engine. *What did she say. Give me the second phrase. I'll hold it gently, I promise, I'll carry it well —*

He opened his mouth.

And Niamh was looking at him.

She had stopped a little behind, where the line came over the ridge, and she was watching not the stone but Elena's face and then his face, going between them, reading the room the way she'd read rooms her whole life because no one had ever bothered to make a room easy for her. And she made the smallest movement with her flat hand, palm down, low, near her hip where only he would catch it.

Not that.

He shut his mouth.

They walked again. The line went on, dead-straight, refusing the plain's small mercies — a dip here it climbed through instead of around, a scatter of rock it held its width across rather than parting and rejoining. Naila was beside him now, and she had her phone out, the inclinometer app open, and she was not happy.

"It's holding," she said. Flat, the way she said true things. "Over the ridge. It didn't drift. It came up the slope and over the top and down

the other side and the bearing's the same to within —" she turned the phone, frowned at it, the angle, the long pale line running off ahead of them perfectly true toward a node neither of them could yet see. "There's no vantage. There was nowhere to stand and check it. You can't see the far end from here. You couldn't see the far end from anywhere. The ridge is in the way."

"I know," Bashir said.

"From the top of the ridge you can see ahead, but you can't see *behind* and *ahead at once* to know you're straight. And the people who made this didn't make it at once. It got walked for three thousand years. Different people. Different —" She stopped, because she was bumping into the thing, the cold real shape of it, the gap. *No central authority. No instrument. No elevated vantage. No plan anyone has ever found.* And the line straight as a drawn rule for twenty kilometres over ground that did everything it could to bend it.

"*Maybe they were just really, really committed,*" the fish offered.

Naila looked at the daypack. She did not have a relationship with the fish. "That's not an explanation. That's a personality trait."

"*I'm a personality. I contain multitudes.*"

"It's not an instrument and it's not magic," Naila said, to Bashir, ignoring it, getting back to the cold eye she trusted. "Both of those are lazy. It's something humanly done that I can't model. That's worse. I'd rather it were magic. Magic I could put down."

She put the phone away, which for Naila was a kind of grief.

Bashir watched Elena's back going up the next rise, and he listened, and he caught it again — *thakhi*, and the place-name with the glottal catch, and a word that meant *to follow* but stacked with the evidential suffix that meant *as I was told, as it was told to me, as it has always been told* — and he had a sudden, vertiginous understanding that came not from his mind but from his lungs.

The straightness was in the saying.

Not metaphorically. He felt it in his own feet, which had begun, without his deciding it, to stay inside the pale stripe — because Elena's voice was on the stripe, because the words landed at the nodes,

because the rhythm of the saying was the rhythm of the keeping-straight. You didn't sight a line and then walk it. You said the line, in order, with the places named in their order, and your feet went where the words went, and the next walker said it after you, and after them, for thirty centuries, and the bearing was held not by an eye on a horizon but by a mouth on a path. The order of the words was the geometry. Stop saying it and your feet would wander to the saddle, to the easy ground, and the line would green over and be gone.

It was the most beautiful answer he had ever almost-had.

And it explained everything except the one thing. It told him *how the bearing was held*. It did not tell him *what was being said*, fully, all the way down — because the words he had were the road-words, the going-words, the safe public surface of it, and underneath them ran a register he could hear the shape of and not the inside, the way you can hear a room is full through a wall without knowing what they're laughing at. The second phrase, at the stone. The phrase the others let her say alone.

He'd built his whole life on the conviction that there was no door he couldn't reach through, given the language. That the warmth was always on the other side and the language was always the key.

Here was a door that opened — they'd let him walk, hadn't they, they were saying the words out loud where his ear could not help but catch them — and behind the open door was another door, and that one was not a translation problem. It was not that he lacked the word. He could *get* the word. He could lean over and ask Elena, in her own clean grammar, *what was the second thing you said at the stone*, and she had the kind of face that might even tell him.

The want stood up in him again, full height.

They crested the rise. Sajama hung there. Elena had stopped once more — another node, a low ring of stones with the line threading dead-centre through it — and she turned, and she looked back down the line at the strung-out crew, at the photographer with her camera down, at the woman who'd put her phone away, at the Deaf woman reading all their faces, and last at Bashir.

She knew. He could see she knew exactly what he carried — that of all of them he was the one who could ask in the right tongue, in the

right register, with the right respect folded into the right suffix, the one who could make the asking itself a courtesy. She'd heard him not-asking at the first stone. She was waiting, with the patience of a woman whose people had outlasted every empire that ever decided they were too simple to have anything worth keeping, to see whether he understood that the open door was the gift and the second door was not for sale at any price of fluency.

The wind came off the snow. Mauricio said the road-word, soft, *thakhi*, and touched the stone.

Bashir drew the breath to ask. He had the sentence built and clean in his mouth, every marker in its place.

He held it there, and did not let it go, and the moment stretched, and Elena watched him hold it.

Chapter 8 — The Potato Revisited

The GPS unit said the line was straight to within ninety centimetres over four kilometres, and Naila did not believe it, because that was impossible, and so she walked the four kilometres again.

It was the third time. The sun had not yet cleared the shoulder of Sajama, and the cold was the kind that lived in the marrow rather than the skin — a dry, mineral cold that made her fingers slow on the screen. Each breath came short and expensive. At four thousand and something metres the body did arithmetic it never had to do at sea level: a step costs this much, a slope costs that much, do you have it. Mostly she did not have it. She walked anyway, because the numbers were lying, and Naila had a low tolerance for numbers that lied.

She had set the rover unit on the *wak'a* at the south end — a low cairn of dark stones with one pale offering-stone laid on top, a knot of dried grass tucked into a cleft — and she walked north along the scraped trail toward the *chullpa*, the squat funerary tower the line aimed at. One metre wide. The exposed subsoil ran pale as bone between the darker oxidised plain, the way a parting runs pale through dark hair. Underfoot the difference was nothing — a few centimetres of scrape, three thousand years deep. From the air it would be a stroke of chalk. From here it was just where your feet went.

She logged a fix every ten paces. Stop. Stand. Wait for the unit to settle, the little number agonising down — 2.1 metres of horizontal accuracy, 1.4, 0.9, *fix* — then mark, then walk. The ridge came up at the two-kilometre mark, a low brown swell of ground maybe forty metres of rise, nothing dramatic, the sort of hummock any sane trail

would slide around to the east where the plain was flat and kind.

The line went over it.

Straight up the face, straight down the far side, and — she checked the unit, checked it again, breath sawing — it came off the back of the ridge on the *same bearing it went up*. Not a hair of correction. Whoever first walked this could not have seen the *chullpa* from the south *wak'a*; the ridge stood between them, a solid wall of ground. You cannot sight a target you cannot see. You cannot correct toward a thing you have never laid eyes on. And yet here was the line, climbing a hill it had no reason to climb, holding a heading it had no instrument to hold, arriving at a tower it could not have seen when it set out.

She sat down on the cold ground at the crest and pulled the data onto the tablet and tried to make it be wrong.

This was the part Naila was good at — better than good. The part where a pattern that everyone called *obvious* turned out, under measurement, to be a stack of impossible things wearing a coat. She liked the official story. She wanted to stress that, even just to herself, in the cold: she *liked* it. It was true and it was beautiful and the people who'd worked it out had earned it. Pilgrimage footpaths. Tony Morrison flying over in the seventies and seeing the chalk-strokes nobody had named. The Penn survey crews pegging out their transects across the largest drawing on Earth and finding it — what was the word in the paper, she could see it — *neither the purpose nor how the makers achieved such precision is completely understood*. That was an honest sentence. She respected an honest sentence in a survey paper the way other people respected a cathedral.

The trouble was that *footpath* did a great deal of quiet work.

A footpath was a thing made by laziness. By the cumulative wisdom of feet that wanted the easy way. You did not need a committee to make a footpath; you needed a desire line and time, and the path appeared where the walking was cheapest. Naila had mapped desire lines across university lawns for a methods course once. They bent. They always bent — around the wet patch, toward the gap in the hedge, away from the slope. Feet are economists. Feet hate hills.

These feet had walked up a hill for three thousand years and never

once decided to go round.

She opened a clean sheet and started building the case against herself, because that was the only honest direction to build in. *Hypothesis: the straightness is illusory, an artefact of selection — we only notice the straight ones.* She'd looked. The Penn data and her own dozen transects agreed: the network was straight as a habit, straight as a rule, not straight as an accident. *Hypothesis: short straight segments chained together read as one long straight line, the way a polygon fakes a circle.* She measured the segment angles. If the line were a chain of guesses, the bearing would drift — a random walk, error compounding, the kind of slow wander any uncorrected process accrues. The arithmetic on a chain of independent guesses over twenty kilometres should put you hundreds of metres off your target. This line was off by a man's height. *Hypothesis: there was a vantage — a high point, a sighting post.* She'd stood on every rise within sight. From none of them could you see both ends of a single long line. The ground would not allow it.

She did the calculation she'd been avoiding, the one with the rover data fed into it raw: take the standard deviation of her fixes from the best-fit line, propagate it, ask what instrument you would need to do this on purpose, today, with a team and daylight and a plan.

A theodolite. A clear sightline or a chain of them. A datum. A surveyor who'd trained for it.

The makers had none of those, and had done it anyway, and had done it without anyone in charge telling them how, because there was no one in charge. It was not one genius with a secret. It was *everybody*, for thirty centuries, none of them able to see the whole, all of them somehow agreeing on a heading none of them could measure.

She put the tablet face-down on the stone. The wind came up off the plain and found the gap at her collar. Above her the cone of Sajama had taken the first light and gone the colour of a struck match, and around its lower flanks she could see the red, gnarled smudge of the *queñua* — trees where there had no business being trees, the highest forest on the planet, growing because the mountain said it could. Everything here was doing something it shouldn't be able to do. She was beginning to take it personally.

The walker found her on the crest.

Naila hadn't heard her come up — at altitude you heard your own pulse before you heard anyone's feet — but there she was, an Aymara woman somewhere north of sixty in a layered *pollera* skirt and a hat the wind couldn't touch, breathing as if the slope were nothing, which for her it was. Doña Rosa. Bashir had reached her, three days ago, in her own language, and a door that had stayed shut to the surveyors' clipboards had come not open but *ajar*. Naila had no Aymara. She had a tablet full of numbers and the few words Bashir had drilled into her, and she used one of them now — a greeting, badly — and Doña Rosa's mouth did something that wasn't quite a smile but was related to one.

The woman looked at the rover unit on its tripod over the *wak'a*, then back along the line the way Naila had come, then at the tablet face-down on the stone. She said something. Naila caught nothing of it but the shape — a question, lifted at the end.

Naila turned the tablet over and showed her, because showing was a language. The best-fit line, dead straight, screaming red across the topographic shading. The hill rendered in contour. The line ignoring the hill. She pointed at the line, then at the actual ridge under their feet, then made a flat blade of her hand and held it level and rigid: *straight. This is straight. Over this. How.*

Doña Rosa looked at the screen for a long, courteous moment. Then she looked at Naila with an expression Naila had spent her whole life on the receiving end of and usually hated — the patient look people gave you when you had got the question wrong in a way that was somehow endearing. Coming from this woman, on this hill, it did not feel like being managed. It felt like being corrected by gravity.

She did not answer the *how*. She made a small gesture instead — two fingers, walking, along the line, north — and said a word Naila did know, because Bashir had given it to her: *sarnaqaña*. To walk. To go about. To live, the way you live a road by being on it.

Then she said something longer, and pointed not at the screen but at her own mouth, and walked the two fingers again, and Naila understood with her body before she understood with her head that the answer to *how is it straight* was being declined. Not hidden. *Declined*. The way you'd decline to answer how a song stays in tune — because

the question contained a mistake about what kind of thing it was.

Naila tried once more. She crouched, smoothed a patch of pale sub-soil with her palm, and drew with her finger: two dots, a line between, the line bowing wrong, then a line bowing right, then a perfect straight one. She tapped the straight one. She tapped the rover. She held up the tablet. *This. This is the achievement. This precision. Surely this is the thing.*

Doña Rosa crouched too, with a grace Naila's knees envied, and looked at the three drawn lines. She put her finger on the crooked one and shook her head, gently — not *wrong*, more *not the point*. She put her finger on the straight one and said *sarnaqaña* again, softly, almost amused, as if to say: *yes, and?* As if the straightness were not the cathedral but the floor of it. As if Naila had walked into the largest drawing on Earth and asked, with great seriousness, *how do you keep the chalk so white*, and the answer was: *by walking on it*, and the *why* of the walking was a separate and larger thing, and that thing was not on offer.

The straightness wasn't the trick. The straightness fell out of the practice the way a path falls out of feet — except it fell out *straight*, and the reason it fell out straight was the practice, and the practice was hers and not Naila's, and there the door stopped.

Doña Rosa stood, said one more thing — a kindness, by the tone of it — touched the offering-stone on the *wak'a* with the side of her hand in passing, and went on north along the line, the two fingers of her gait holding a bearing Naila's nine-hundred-thousand-rand instrument could only describe and never produce. Within a hundred metres she was a small dark figure on a pale thread, and the thread ran true to the *chullpa* she could not possibly have sighted from the south, and Naila sat on the cold crest with the most accurate map she had ever made of a thing she now understood less than when she'd started.

Hecklefish, who had appeared on the stone beside the tablet with the unexplained reliability of a thing that exists mainly in the margins, regarded the screen.

"So let me get this straight," he said. "You measured it."

“I measured it.”

“And the measurement is perfect.”

“The measurement is the problem.”

“And the nice lady, who can actually *make* the perfect line, just told you the perfect line is the *boring* part.” He let a beat go. “I love this place. They’ve got the largest drawing on Earth and to them it’s *housekeeping*.”

Naila didn’t answer. She was looking at the best-fit residuals — the tiny scatter of her fixes around the impossible straight, the breath-and-altitude wobble of her own hand — and underneath it, holding it, the thing the residuals were scattering *around*. The line her numbers could find and never explain. She had come up here to solve a footpath. She was going back down with a footpath that had been kept arrow-straight over a hill it had no reason to climb, for three thousand years, by people who would not tell her how, because *how* was the wrong word, and the right word — the word that walked north on two fingers and didn’t look back — was theirs.

She put the cap on the rover. She did not feel solved. She felt, for the first time in a long methodical while, the specific and excellent vertigo of a problem that was not going to let her win — and, underneath that, smaller and warmer and harder to admit: she could not wait to walk the whole thing.

She just wasn’t going to be the one who got to say what it was for.

Chapter 9 — The Chapel and the Chullpa

The chapel had no business being beautiful, and it was.

Mara stood thirty metres off with the camera down at her hip and let herself look before she decided anything. Adobe walls washed white, gone the colour of old teeth where the lime had worn. A bell-gable with one bell and a sky behind it so violet at the top that her eye kept arguing with it, kept insisting that blue did not do that, that she had the white balance wrong. She didn't. The plain did that. The air up here was thin enough that the sky ran out of things to scatter and just kept getting darker the higher you looked, the way water does over a drop-off.

A line ran to the chapel door.

That was the part she could not stop seeing. Not a path — a *line*, scraped pale through the dark surface stones, one metre wide and arrow-true, coming down off the low ridge to the north and arriving at the threshold like a sentence arriving at a full stop. It did not wander up to the chapel the way a road would, finding the gentle grade. It came straight at it. It had climbed the ridge to do so. She had watched it climb the ridge.

"They put the church on the line," Naila said beside her. She had her tablet out, the satellite tile glowing on it, and she was holding the screen up so it sat in the same frame as the real thing, comparing. "Or the line came first and they put the church on it. You can't tell from the date which way the sentence runs."

"The line came first," said Bashir. He'd been quiet most of the morn-

ing, which for Bashir meant he was listening to something the rest of them couldn't hear yet. "Three thousand years first."

The local — her name was Eulogia, and Mara had spent two days learning to say it the way she said it, the stress sitting differently than a Spanish ear would put it — came up the line itself. Not beside it. On it, her feet in the pale scrape, an old woman walking unhurried with a younger man a respectful pace behind, and Mara understood without being told that this was not casual. You did not walk the line to get somewhere. The line was not for getting somewhere. She was *saying* it, the way you'd run a finger down a page you'd known by heart for sixty years.

Bashir went to meet her and the two of them talked, and Mara watched the talking the way she watched everything, for the thing under it. There was a courtesy in how Bashir held himself — half a step back, hands loose, the words coming soft and low and in the old woman's own tongue, the real one, not the phrasebook. Eulogia answered him and her face did a small thing, a loosening at the mouth, and Niamh — who read faces the way Mara read light — caught Mara's eye and tipped her chin a quarter inch. *That one's real*. The door had opened a finger's width. It had opened because of words, not because of anyone's press credentials, and somewhere out on the plain there was a team with forty thousand dollars of drone who had not managed to open it at all.

The hummingbird at the back of Mara's skull — the one that always wanted the frame — was very awake. The light on the white wall. The line coming down to the door. The old woman standing in it. She knew, without lifting the camera, that it was the photograph. The one that ran in the magazine, the one that won the thing, the one that made the lines *legible to people who would never walk them*.

She kept the camera at her hip.

Eulogia took them up the line to the chullpa.

It was maybe a kilometre, all of it a negotiation with the lungs. Mara had been at altitude before — she'd worked a war at altitude once, in a place she did not let herself name on the good days — but altitude

did not get easier for being familiar. Twenty paces and the body sent its bill. She watched Naila do the arithmetic on her own breathing, counting steps between breaths, and watched Bashir do the thing Bashir did, which was simply absorb the cost without comment because complaint cost air too.

The chullpa stood where the line bent — except it didn't bend. It arrived at the tower and a second line left from the other side, on the same bearing, the tower threaded onto both like a bead. A funerary tower, square-shouldered, built of fitted stone and clay, older than the chapel by a span of time Mara's mind refused to hold. The dead were in there, or had been. The walkers came to it the way they came to the chapel. The line did not care that one was a church Spain had built and one was a tomb that had stood here while Rome was a city. It scraped its pale path to each of them with exactly the same straightness, on exactly the same bearing, and Mara felt the whole architecture of it tilt in her chest: *the line ate the church*. It didn't surrender to it. The new sacred thing got put on the old true line, and the walking went on.

Bashir was translating, low and continuous, and Mara caught the shape of it through her own air-starved attention. The chullpa was a *wak'a* — a place where something was. The chapel was a *wak'a* too, now, had become one, absorbed. The line between them was — and here Bashir paused, and chose, and the choosing was visible — the line between them was *said*. Eulogia had used a word for it and Bashir had set it down carefully in English as *said*, not *walked*, not *drawn*, and Mara filed the precision away. The man whose whole gift was carrying words from one mouth to another had just declined to round one off, and that was worth more than the word itself.

"How do they keep it straight," Naila said. Quiet. Not to anyone. The question she'd been carrying like a stone since La Paz. She had her tablet out again, had laid the chapel and the chullpa onto the tile and drawn the bearing between them, and the scraped line on the ground matched her drawn line to within — she'd measured it yesterday, on her knees with a hand level and a compass and a temper — to within a width Mara could cover with her thumb at arm's length. Over a ridge. Over a kilometre. With nobody standing high enough to see both ends.

Eulogia looked at the tablet. Looked at Naila. Said something short.

Bashir held it a moment before he gave it over. “She says you are asking how the words stay straight in a prayer you have said every day since you were small.”

Naila looked at the line. The fish would have said something here, Mara thought — the fish always had something for the moment a smart person ran headfirst into a wall that wasn’t a wall. *Yeah, but how’d they do it without a satellite, lady?* And the joke would land and the joke would be wrong, and that was the point of the joke. Naila didn’t say anything. She put the tablet away. It was, Mara thought, the most respect she’d ever seen Naila pay a thing she couldn’t model.

The mapping team arrived at the chullpa from the east, which meant they’d driven the long way around the ridge the line had simply climbed.

Mara heard the vehicle before she saw it, the engine wrong against the enormous quiet, and then the people, four of them, the man in front she’d already learned to dislike a little and then check herself for disliking. Köhler. He ran the survey. He was not a villain — that was the thing she kept having to hold onto, because it would have been easier if he were. He had clean hands and a real CV and a genuine, slightly boyish thrill in him about the lines, and he believed, sincerely, that he was *saving* them. Mapping them, dating them, getting them into the literature, onto the register, behind the rope that protected things. He’d said as much, two nights ago, over bad coffee, *one of the largest artworks on Earth and nobody’s even surveyed it properly*, and the awful part was that the second clause was true.

He had a camera operator with him. Big rig, gimbal, the kind of thing that cost what Mara’s car cost. The operator was already lining up the chullpa — the tower, the light on the fitted stone, the line running off it — and Mara watched him find, in his viewfinder, the exact photograph she had refused to take at the chapel. He had it. He was a quarter-second from having it.

Eulogia turned and said something to Köhler in Spanish, flat and final, and the younger man behind her translated it down to Bashir in Aymara just to be sure, and Bashir gave it to Mara in English because she’d drifted close: *Not the tower. Not while we are at it.*

Köhler's hands came up, placating, charming, *of course, of course*, and then — and Mara saw it, the thing he didn't even know he was doing — he turned half away as if to comply and gave the operator the smallest nod. The nod that means *get it anyway*. The professional nod. She'd given it herself, in places worse than this, when she was younger and certain the picture mattered more than the people in it.

"Eulogia," Bashir said. Just her name. And then a sentence Mara didn't follow, soft, and the old woman's eyes went to the operator and the big rig still up at his shoulder, still recording, the red light a small obscene star against the violet sky.

The operator kept shooting.

It was Niamh who moved. Niamh, who read the room because the room had spent her whole life talking over her head and she'd learned to survive by watching the hands and the mouths and the small betrayals of the eyes. She stepped — not aggressive, not fast, just *into the sightline*, into the frame, a body where the picture wanted clear air, and she lifted her own hands and signed something at the operator that needed no interpreter at all. *No*. The plainest word there is.

The operator lowered the rig. Looked at Köhler. Köhler's charm flickered and held and he said, "We have permits," to no one in particular, to the plain, to the violet sky, and it was the most naked thing Mara had heard a man say in a long while, because it was true and it did not matter at all. Spain had had permits too. The line had outlasted the permits. The line would outlast Köhler.

Eulogia turned back to her own people, to the line, to the chapel a kilometre off and the tower at her shoulder, as if the team had simply stopped existing, which Mara thought was probably the kindest possible response and also a kind of verdict.

And Mara stood there with her own camera at her hip, the good one, the one that had seen things she'd never sell and never show, and felt the hummingbird beat itself against the inside of her skull.

The photograph was *right there*. The old woman in the pale line between the tomb and the church, the two sacred things three thousand

years apart threaded on one held bearing, the light doing its impossible thing on the white wall in the distance. It was the frame that would make people *understand* — and she heard, in the place where she kept the arguments she'd lost, the answer to that: understand *what*? That the line was beautiful from outside it? That you could lift the whole meaning out of three thousand years of walking and hang it on a wall where no one's feet would ever touch the scrape?

The makers never had this view. That was the thing Naila kept saying and the thing that kept being true. There was no vantage. No one had ever stood high enough to see the line whole, not the people who walked it, not for three millennia. They'd held it straight without ever once seeing it. And here she was being handed, by the light and the luck and the geometry, the one image that would let the whole world see what no walker ever had — and the price of taking it was the same price Köhler's operator had nearly paid. You'd be lifting it out of the feet. You'd be taking the one thing it wasn't for.

Eulogia was watching her. Not the team. Her. The old woman's eyes had come to rest on Mara and the camera at her hip, and there was a question in them, level and patient, the same question that lived in the lens she'd carried out of one war and into a life of trying to know when *not* to press the shutter.

Mara raised the camera.

Slowly. So they could all see. And she turned it, deliberate, away from the line, away from the tower, away from the old woman in the scrape — out to the empty plain, to the *paja brava* running silver to the foot of the white mountain, to nothing anyone could own. She made one exposure of nothing. Of grass and light and the cone of Sajama. Then she let the camera down to her hip again and lowered her eyes, and lifted them, and gave Eulogia the smallest nod she had — not the nod that meant *get it anyway*. The other one. The one she was still learning.

The old woman held her look a moment longer. Then she turned and walked back down the line toward the chapel, on the line, saying it, her feet in the pale scrape, and the younger man fell in behind her, and after a moment — because Eulogia had not told them no, and that was its own kind of door — the crew followed. On the line. In order. In the body.

Behind them the red light on the big rig had gone dark, and Köhler was already on his phone, walking toward the vehicle, telling someone in Munich that they'd be back tomorrow with the right paperwork, and Mara did not turn around to watch him be wrong about that.

Chapter 10 — The Map That Fails

The generator in the back room of the *alojamiento* had a stutter to it, a missed beat every nine seconds or so, and by the second hour Bashir had stopped hearing it as a fault and started hearing it as a word — *ka, ka-ka, ka* — the way he heard everything, parsing the cough of a machine for grammar it didn't have. He pressed two fingers to the bridge of his nose and let the syllable dissolve.

On the trestle table, Naila had laid the plain out flat.

Six A1 sheets of satellite tile, edge-matched and weighted at the corners with whatever the room offered — a tin mug, a fist-sized rock with a chalky underside, the LENS's lens cap, a folded glove. Above the paper, propped on a crate, the drone footage looped on the laptop: Sajama rising white and indifferent off the left of frame, and below it the plain combed with lines, fine as the grain in old wood, running away to the violet edge of the sky.

"That's it," Naila said. "That's the whole god's-eye."

It was beautiful. Bashir would give it that, would give it everything. From four thousand metres up — borrowed altitude, borrowed by a quadcopter that cost more than the village's only truck — the lines did the thing the famous Peruvian glyphs did in every coffee-table book on the planet. They resolved. They became a thing you could see. Threads radiating from a dark knot that was a *wak'a*, a shrine, a place where something had once happened; threads crossing other threads; a whole written page of plain, three thousand years in the keeping.

“Read it to me,” Mara said. She wasn’t looking at the paper. She was looking at the loop, at the mountain, with the specific stillness she had when a frame was good and she was deciding whether good was a sin.

“That’s the problem.” Naila put one blunt finger on a line where it met the ridge marked in faint topographic brown. “There’s nothing to read. There’s a line. It goes from here” — the finger walked — “to here, twenty kilometres, and it crosses the ridge at the steepest place instead of going round, and I can tell you to the half-degree how straight it is, and it tells me *nothing*. It’s a sentence with the letters but no language.”

Here is the official story, and it is true, and Bashir had spent enough years at enough borders to know how rare it was to be able to say *true* without a caveat snagging in your teeth.

In the 1970s a British filmmaker named Tony Morrison came across the lines and brought word of them out to the world that catalogues such things, and decades later a university project out of Pennsylvania surveyed them properly, and the answer they returned was clean and good: these are pilgrimage paths. The Aymara have walked them for three thousand years and walk them still, scraping the dark oxidised stone aside to bare the pale ground beneath, line after line linking the shrines and the funerary towers and the villages and, after the Spanish came, the little white chapels that the practice simply absorbed without surrendering anything older. Not a monument. A landscape that is alive because it is in use. Stop walking it and it greens over and is gone.

Sixteen thousand kilometres of it. Naila had done the arithmetic on the back of a fuel receipt their first night and then sat with the receipt in her hand longer than the sum warranted. Three times the width of the continental United States, scored by foot. Twenty-two and a half thousand square kilometres of patterned ground — fifteen Nazcas, give or take — very likely the largest single thing human beings ever drew on the face of the Earth.

And the most-photographed lines on the planet were eight hundred kilometres north in Peru, where they let you fly over in a Cessna for a hundred dollars and feel the airsickness of awe.

“The famous one is the decoy,” Mara had said, that first night, turning the receipt over in the lamplight. Nobody had argued.

“Bashir.” Naila tapped the laptop’s spacebar; the loop froze with the line halfway up the ridge. “Tell me what they could see when they made it.”

“From the ground?”

“From anywhere. There’s no tower. There’s no scaffold anybody’s ever found. There’s no hill in the right place to stand on and check the back-bearing — and even if there were, the line goes *over the next ridge* where you’d lose sight of where you started.” She wasn’t excited. She never sounded excited; she sounded the way a level sounds when the bubble finds centre. “So. No instrument. No vantage. No one in charge — it’s not a king’s road, it’s a thing a thousand separate people kept up over a hundred generations. And it holds to under a degree for twenty kilometres over broken ground.”

“That’s the published thing,” Bashir said. “Word for word, nearly. *Neither the purpose nor how the makers achieved such precision is completely understood.*”

“Not understood by *them*,” said a voice from the doorway, and it was not warm.

The adversary did not look like an adversary. Bashir had learned to distrust the part of himself that wanted villains to have a tell. Dr. Esteban Olmedo had clean hands — literally clean, soft, a man whose work happened on screens — and an open, tired face, and a way of standing slightly stooped as though apologising in advance for the size of his funding. His outfit was called something with *Heritage* in it. They had drones better than the crew’s, surveyors with total stations, and a press release already drafted, Niamh had read it off a tablet over a man’s shoulder in the one café — drafted, and gentle, and devastating: *the mystery of the Sajama Lines, explained at last.*

“May I?” He came to the table without waiting for the answer, which was its own kind of answer. He looked at the loop, at the frozen line on the ridge, and he smiled, and the smile was real. He loved this.

That was the worst of it. “You see it too. The radial geometry. Ceque logic — like Cusco, the shrine-lines out from a centre, only scaled up across a whole district. We’re modelling the whole network. Every node, every bearing. We’ll have it solved by the dry season.”

“Solved,” Naila said.

“The straightness.” Olmedo spread his soft hands over the paper as if warming them at it. “People want to make it a riddle. It isn’t. Give people a fixed start, a fixed target they can see across the flat, and a rope, and an afternoon, and they’ll lay you a straight line. Repeat it for three thousand years and refresh the easy stretches and—” He shrugged, fond, dismissive. “The hills are the only interesting part, and the hills are just persistence. We’ll demonstrate it. We have a slot booked on the eastern segment. Total station, dGPS, the full kit. We’ll walk a line ourselves, in a day, and put the *how* to bed, and then the tourists can come and the lines can be properly *valued*.”

Valued. Bashir heard the word go in like a splinter. He watched Ni-amh, across the room, who was watching Olmedo’s mouth with the flat attention she gave to people who talked too much, and he saw her file something — the small tightening at the corner of the man’s eye when he said *valued*, the thing the man himself didn’t know he’d shown.

“And the people who walk it now?” Bashir asked, in Spanish, mildly.

“Are welcome to keep walking it,” Olmedo said, and meant it, and that was the splinter going deeper. “We’re not taking anything. We’re *explaining* it. There’s a difference.”

When he had gone — the soft handshake, the genuine warmth, the slot booked on the eastern segment like a dentist’s appointment — the room held the generator’s stutter for a while.

“He’s not wrong about the rope,” Naila said at last. She said it the way she said hard things, flatly, against herself. “On the flat. Two people, a sightline, you can do a kilometre dead straight with nothing. I could do it. The fish could probably do it.”

From the floor, where it sat in the cooler with the last of the good water, Hecklefish offered its opinion. “*I could ABSOLUTELY do it. I*

have an excellent eye. I'm basically a level with a personality."

"It's the ridge," Naila went on, not dignifying that. "The over-the-hill bit. You lose the back-sight the second you crest. And then the next stretch on the far side has to *match* — has to be the same bearing, picked up by somebody who maybe wasn't there yesterday, maybe wasn't born yet, with no one to phone, no plan in a drawer, no map." She put her hand flat on the satellite tile, on the line, on the very thing she'd been hired by her own brain to measure. "And the map doesn't help. *This* doesn't help. They never had this. This is the one tool that makes it look easy and it's the one tool that proves nothing, because the people who made it never once saw it."

"That's the joke," Mara said quietly.

"It's not a joke." Naila looked up. There was something raw in it, just for a second, the thing she didn't show — the pattern that wouldn't resolve, sitting in front of her, refusing to be a problem she could close. "I'm the one who's supposed to model it. I've got the tiles and the drone and the lidar offset and I can give you the straightness to three decimals and I cannot tell you *how a person standing on the ground did it*. I keep doing the thing he's doing. I keep looking at it from above."

Bashir went out for the air, which was a thing you did here, because the air was the whole argument.

Outside, the cold came down the way it did the instant the sun dropped behind Sajama — not a chill, a subtraction, the heat of the day simply removed from the world in the space of a breath. The *paja brava* hissed in the *surazo*. Up the slope, surreal in the last light, the highest forest on Earth held its red-barked, gnarled little stand of *queñua*, trees that had no business at this altitude and grew here anyway, stubborn as the lines.

An old woman was coming down the trail from the *chullpas* with two others, walking unhurried, walking the way they all walked here — economical, lungs banked against the thin air, a gait that knew exactly how much each step cost and spent not one breath more. The *yatiri*. She had not given the crew much. She had given Bashir something the others hadn't gotten, which was a door left on the latch, and she

had given it to him not because his Aymara was good — it was passable, walker's courtesy, *kamisaraki*, the small right words in the right order — but because he had used the right words in the right order and then *stopped*, and let the silence be hers.

She stopped now, a few metres off, and looked at him, and then past him at the doorway with its rectangle of generator-light and the laptop glow inside.

She said something. Bashir caught it — caught the shape of it before the sense, the way he always did, the grammar arriving a half-beat ahead of the meaning. She nodded at the lit room, at the paper he knew was spread on the table in there, the whole plain flattened and weighted under a tin mug and a rock.

"Ukax janiw uñjañ kunäkiti," she said. And then, because she was kind, or because she wanted him to carry it back exactly, she said it slower.

He turned it over. *That thing is not a looking-thing.* Not — *that's not a picture.* Closer: *that is not for looking.* The verb sat where the verb sat in Aymara, the way it always undid him a little, the action holding the centre of the sentence and the thing itself orbiting it.

He could have argued. He could have said *we know, we're not trying to look, we're trying to understand.* But that was the same sentence Olmedo had used with his clean soft hands. *We're not taking anything. We're explaining it.*

"Jisa," Bashir said instead. Yes. And then, carefully, in her language, with the small right words: "Then how is it for?"

The two younger walkers had stopped a little up the slope. The wind moved the grass. The old woman looked at him for long enough that he understood he had asked the question slightly wrong — not wrongly enough to close the door, but wrongly, the *how* where some other word should sit, a wrongness she registered the way Niamh registered the splinter in Olmedo's eye.

She didn't correct him. She started walking again, down past him toward the village, and as she passed she said it once more, almost to herself, the way you'd say a thing a child needed to find out by doing rather than being told —

“Sarañatakiw.”

And then she was gone down the trail, the cold filling in behind her, and Bashir stood holding the word in his mouth like a stone with a chalky underside, turning it, because it would not lie flat the way the satellite tile did. *Saraña*. To walk, to go. *-taki*, for. *-w*, the affirmative, the *it-is-so*.

It is for going.

No. Not quite. The map of the word failed the same way the map of the plain failed. The meaning wasn't *in* it, laid out to be read from above. It was in the verb, in the doing, in the part you only got by—

He went back inside, where Naila still had both hands flat on the line she could not solve, and the loop still hung frozen with the line halfway up the ridge, and the generator said *ka*, *ka-ka*, *ka*, and nobody had moved.

“We’ve been doing it wrong,” he said.

Mara lowered the camera she hadn’t quite been raising. “All of us?”

“All of us.” He looked at the paper, all six beautiful weighted sheets of it, the largest thing humans ever drew, flattened and lit and as silent as the day Nazca went quiet. “We brought the one tool the makers never had and we’re standing here wondering why it won’t tell us anything.”

“So what’s the right tool?” the fish said, from the cooler. *“And before you say ‘feelings,’ I want you to know I’m prepared to leave.”*

“No,” Bashir said. He picked up the rock off the corner of the satellite tile, and the paper curled, and the plain went back to being a flat thing that meant nothing without feet on it. “Not feelings.”

He weighed the stone in his hand.

“She didn’t say it’s for looking at. She said it’s for walking.”

Chapter 11 — The Adversary's Pitch

The room they'd taken was the new wing of the municipal building in Sajama village — concrete block, fresh paint, a roof that hadn't yet learned to leak. Niamh clocked it the way she clocked every room: the exits, the light, the faces and where they were pointed. Forty plastic chairs in rows. A projector throwing a rectangle of dust-haze onto a pull-down screen. At the back, a folding table with thermoses and a stack of paper cups, because even a corporate land grab knows you offer people coffee first.

The heating was a single gas blower roaring in the corner, and it made the air taste of butane and altitude. Niamh felt the roar more than heard it — a pressure on the skin of her face, a low confusion in the floor through her boots. She didn't have the words coming off the mouths yet. She had the bodies. The bodies were already telling her the whole story.

She found her interpreter — Tomás, hired in La Paz, patient, good hands — and set him where she could see him and the front of the room in one sweep. Then she settled in to read.

The man running the show was named Holloway. She'd learned that much from the lanyard and from Bashir, who'd shaken his hand at the door and come back with his jaw set in the particular way it set when a language had been *used* at him instead of spoken to him. Holloway was English, fifty-ish, weathered in the good-boots-and-fleece way of men who fly to high places and stand near things. He had the easy stillness of someone who had given this talk before. His hands stayed open. His weight stayed even. He believed himself, which was the

dangerous kind.

He clicked the projector. The first slide came up and the room made the small collective intake that Niamh saw as shoulders rising an inch all down the rows.

An aerial. The plain from above, false-coloured, the lines leaping out of the grass like stitching pulled tight on a sleeve. From up there the network was legible the way a circuit board is legible — radial, deliberate, *enormous*. The officials in the front row leaned forward. A man from the department in La Paz, two from the regional tourism board, a woman with a press badge who had not stopped filming on her phone. Niamh watched the wonder land on them and saw it for what it was: the easy wonder. The kind you get from above. The kind that costs nothing and explains less.

Sixteen thousand kilometres, Tomás signed, lagging the English by a half-second, his fingers crisp. *He's saying it again. Largest. Single. Archaeological. Artwork. On Earth.*

It was true. That was the thing about it that made Niamh's chest tighten. Every figure on the slides was real. Holloway clicked through them like a man laying out evidence he was proud of, and he had every right to be proud of finding them, because the world had spent a hundred years staring at Nazca's hummingbird while the bigger thing — fifteen times bigger, never abandoned — sat up here in the cold barely looked at. Holloway hadn't lied about a single number. The numbers were a gift to anyone who'd listen.

It was everything *between* the numbers where the floor went thin.

She watched his mouth and let Tomás carry the words and read the rest off his body. *A scientific framework*, the hands said. *Mapping. Conservation. Sustainable access*. The slide turned to a clean schematic — proposed visitor trails, dotted in red, looping out from a planned interpretive centre, here, a polite asterisk on the plain a kilometre from the village. *Protecting the heritage*, Tomás relayed, *by formalising the experience*.

Niamh felt Mara go rigid two seats down. She didn't have to look. She knew the photographer's stillness by now — the held breath of someone watching a frame compose itself that she did not want to exist. The slide after showed an artist's render: a boardwalk. A view-

ing platform with a rail. Two cartoon tourists pointing at a line.

Holloway's hands opened wider. He was getting to the part he liked.

And we believe, Tomás signed, careful, neutral, *that we have begun to understand the method.*

A new slide. Survey lasers, a tripod, a GPS rover the colour of a traffic cone. A heat map of one line segment with deviation measured in centimetres. Holloway was saying — Tomás's fingers steady — that with modern instruments they could now reconstruct, with high confidence, *how it was likely done.* Sighting stakes. Fire-signals at night. Relay teams. A lost surveying tradition, recoverable, *explicable.*

And here, Niamh thought, here is where you have walked off the edge of the cliff with your nice open hands still spread, because you have done it with all your kit and you still made a—

She caught herself. She glanced sideways. Naila was sitting very upright at the end of the row, completely motionless except for one foot, which was tapping out a count against the concrete that Niamh could feel through the floor like a pulse. Naila had spent four days trying to lay a single straight kilometre with a laser level and a clear morning and a hilltop to stand on, and she had a notebook full of the centimetres by which she'd failed. The makers had no laser, no hill to stand on, no morning agreed in advance across three thousand years, and they'd held it for twenty kilometres over a ridge that *had no business being crossed.* Naila's foot kept counting. She wasn't going to say it here. This wasn't the room for it.

Holloway clicked again and the projector showed his last slide: the company logo, a website, and a single line of text Tomás rendered slowly, letting each word stand.

Opening. The. Lines. To. The. World.

The officials applauded. Light, polite, real. The press woman lowered her phone and raised her hand. Niamh watched the question form on Holloway's face before Tomás could catch the words — that small downward settle of relief men get when the question is the one they prepared for.

Then she stopped reading Holloway, because the room had changed temperature in a place the gas blower couldn't reach, and she turned

to find the source.

Doña Lucía had not moved.

She was sitting where she'd been sitting since before the lights dimmed, third row from the back, on the aisle, in a brown skirt and a hat the colour of dried apricot, her hands folded over the bundle in her lap. *Yatiri*. The walker who out-read all of them, who'd taken four days to decide whether to let Bashir's careful Aymara even half-open the door. The crew had come to her village; she had come to the company's room. That was a thing Niamh filed and did not yet fully understand: she had *come*. She was here. She was watching it happen.

And she was perfectly, deliberately silent.

Niamh knew silence. It was her whole country. She had spent a life being talked over, talked around, talked *about* in the third person two feet from her own face, and she had learned the grammar of it the way Bashir learned verbs. There is the silence of someone who has nothing to say. There is the silence of someone who hasn't been given room. And there is the third kind, the rarest, the one nobody who's never lived inside silence can read at all — the silence of someone who has everything to say and is *choosing*, second by second, with total control, not to give it to you.

Doña Lucía was doing the third one. She was doing it with her whole body. Her hands were still. Her chin was level. Her eyes were on the screen where the boardwalk render still glowed, and she was not unsettled by it, and she was not afraid of it, and she was not — this was the part Niamh felt go cold and clean through her — she was not going to correct it.

That was the threat. Niamh saw it then, fully, the way you see the shape of a room when the light finally finds the corner. Holloway wasn't going to bulldoze anything. He had open hands. He was going to build a boardwalk and a rail and an interpretive centre, and he was going to put up a *sign*, and the sign was going to say *how it was likely done* — sighting stakes, fire-signals, relay teams, a lost surveying tradition, recoverable, explicable, *solved* — and the sign would be wrong, and it would be *plausible*, and it would be in three languages, and it would be there in laminated print every dawn that Doña Lucía's people came to walk, and within a generation the children would read

the sign before they walked the line, and the line would still be there, bright, scraped, held arrow-straight over the ridge, and it would mean what the sign said it meant.

He wasn't going to take the ground. He was going to take the *answer*. And the people in the front row, the decent ones, the tourism board and the department, were applauding because the answer he was offering was tidy, and tidy is what officials are for.

Niamh's hands wanted to move. She put them flat on her thighs.

The press woman's question came. Tomás caught it. *She is asking* — his face went carefully blank, the interpreter's discipline — *she is asking whether the local community supports the project*.

Holloway smiled. He did not look at Doña Lucía. He gestured, generously, toward the back rows, toward the handful of Aymara who'd come, and said something Tomás gave to Niamh in pieces: *deep consultation — partnership — the community's heritage at the heart of everything we do*. His open hands swept the room and rested, for a beat, palm-up, in the general direction of the people he was speaking for without speaking *to*.

Niamh watched the swept hand pass over Doña Lucía like a searchlight over a stone.

And Doña Lucía, who had been asked nothing, who had been gestured at as a backdrop to a yes, did the smallest thing Niamh had ever watched a person do.

She looked, for one second, directly at Niamh.

Not at Holloway. Not at the press. At the Deaf woman in the row across the aisle who had been reading the room all morning, who could not hear a word of the pitch and had therefore heard none of the velvet on it. One second. A flat, level, unhurried look, the look of one person who lives in silence acknowledging another, and in it Niamh read — not a word, not a code, nothing she could carry out of the room and translate, just the plain fact of it — *I see what he's doing. You see it too. Watch what I do about it*.

Then Doña Lucía stood up.

The plastic chair scraped. Heads turned. Holloway's hands paused mid-sweep. The press phone came up.

She did not go to the front. She did not take the floor. She gathered her bundle against her hip, settled her hat, and walked — unhurried, the high-plain walk, the walk of someone who has crossed this floor and floors like it for longer than the building has stood — toward the door at the back. As she passed the other Aymara in the rear rows, one of the men rose. Then a woman with a baby on her back. Then two more. No signal Niamh could catch. No word. They simply stood, the way water finds its level, and turned, and went out into the white hammering light of the plain, and the door let in a slab of cold and the roar of the *surazo* and then swung shut.

The front rows sat in the new quiet. The tourism board glanced at one another. The department man's smile had nowhere to go. Holloway, to his credit, kept his open hands open, though Niamh saw the recalculation move behind his face like cloud-shadow over the grass — saw him understand, just enough, that the yes he'd gestured at had stood up and walked out before he could photograph it.

Tomás's hands were still. There was nothing to translate. That was the whole point.

Niamh looked at the empty chairs in the back rows. She looked at the screen, where the boardwalk still glowed, two cartoon tourists pointing at a line nobody in this room could read. She thought about the difference between *doesn't know* and *won't say*, the difference she'd been reading off faces her entire life, and she thought: *they know exactly what it's for. They have always known. And they have just decided, with their feet, in front of the press and the department and the man with the lasers, that knowing it is not the same as handing it over.*

Holloway said something. Tomás began, automatically, to render it, then stopped, and let his hands fall.

Outside, through the block wall, faint enough that Niamh felt it more as a rhythm in the floor than anything else, the small group of walkers had not gone far. They had simply moved off across the plain, toward the lines, in the direction they always went — and they were going on foot, in order, the way you keep a thing alive, the way you keep it *yours*, by doing the one thing a boardwalk and a laser and a laminated sign can never do for you.

They were walking.

Chapter 12 — Holding the Line

The light at dusk on the Altiplano does a cruel thing: it lengthens. Already the plain ran long and wrong — a ridge that read as twenty minutes was half an afternoon — but at this hour the sun came in flat from over Chile and laid every line on the ground into a thread of fire, and the threads went *on*, past where Naila's eye could hold them, out to the violet edge of the world.

She had her tablet out. She put it away. There was nothing on the tablet that the ground wasn't already saying.

Doña Ximena set off without ceremony. She was perhaps sixty, perhaps eighty — the cold and the sun made a single weathered fact of an Aymara woman's face and refused to itemise it — and she walked the way water finds a channel, no wasted motion, the *pollera* skirts swinging, a coca quid making a slow knot in her cheek. Bashir fell in two steps behind and a little to the side, which Naila had learned was the correct distance: close enough to hear, far enough not to crowd the saying. Mara came last, the camera at her hip, switched off. Niamh walked beside her interpreter, both of them reading the old woman's shoulders.

The line they were on was maybe a metre wide. Pale subsoil, scraped clean, the darker oxidised stones pushed to either edge in a low berm you'd never notice if you didn't know to look. It ran ahead of them up a slope of *paja brava*, the tough silver bunchgrass hissing at their shins, and it did not so much as flinch at the slope. It went straight up. A footpath, a sane footpath, would have switchbacked. This one climbed.

“Okay,” Naila said, to herself, in the voice she used for problems. “Okay.”

She had a hypothesis and she wanted to test it with her body, which was the only honest way she knew. The official record was clear and she respected the official record. These were Aymara pilgrimage trails, three thousand years walked, linking *wak’as* and *chullpas* and the white chapels, scraped to the subsoil and kept bright by feet. That part was settled and true and she had said so out loud, twice, because she meant it. The thing that wasn’t settled — the published survey said it in plain words, *neither the purpose nor how the makers achieved such precision is completely understood* — was the straightness. Up to twenty kilometres. Over hills. Over ravines. With no instrument, no central authority, and — this was the part her hands kept returning to — no place to stand and look.

You cannot correct a line you cannot see.

So she would try to make one.

She stopped at the foot of the slope, faced uphill, and picked a target: a knob of red-barked *Polylepis* at the crest, the highest forest on Earth growing where no forest should, gnarled and patient. *Walk to the tree*. Easy. She started up.

Twenty paces in, the slope hid the tree. That was the first thing nobody tells you. The ground was not a tabletop; it bellied and rolled, and the moment the crest dropped below her own brow the target was gone, and she was walking toward a memory of a tree.

She kept her feet pointed where the tree had been. She was good at this — she had a body that catalogued angles, that knew when a picture frame was four degrees off true from across a room — and she trusted it more than most people trusted anything. Forty paces. The slope steepened and the thin air put its hand flat on her sternum and pressed, and her breath came in the short hard sips the altitude allowed, and somewhere in the counting of breaths the careful held bearing in her hips loosened by a degree she couldn’t feel and didn’t catch.

Sixty paces. She crested the belly of the slope.

The tree was there. It was off to her right by — she stopped, and stared, and did the geometry without wanting to — a good fifteen

metres. Maybe more. Over sixty paces she had drifted a body-width every ten, and she hadn't felt a single one of them leave her.

Behind and below her, dead straight, the line she had *not* walked ran up the slope past her left boot and on to the tree without apology.

"Huh," said Mara, who had stopped at the bottom and was watching with the still attention of someone who had decided not to photograph this. "You curved."

"I curved." Naila's voice came out flatter than she meant. She turned and looked back down her own track — you could see it, faintly, where her boots had bruised the grass — and it was a banana. A gentle, confident, completely unconscious banana. "Sixty paces. On open ground. With a target I could see for the first third of it." She wiped her mouth. The cold was already coming up off the plain to meet the falling sun; in an hour there'd be frost. "They held this over twenty kilometres. Through dead ground. Over ridges where the far end is below the horizon for half the walk."

"With no theodolite," Bashir said quietly, from up beside the old woman.

"With *nothing*." She heard her own pitch climbing and reined it. This was the place she could over-reach, and she knew it, and she'd watched the believer-drone do it on a dozen forums and despised it. *No instruments therefore aliens. No vantage therefore lost technology.* No. The hole was not a door to that. The hole was just the hole: an instrument-less, vantage-less, uncommanded method, and an arrow-straight result, and the honest twenty centimetres of air between them. She made herself stand in that air. It was a hard place to stand. It was much more comfortable to leap.

Doña Ximena had been watching this the way you watch a child stack blocks — patient, unsurprised, faintly fond. She said something, three or four words, and looked at Bashir.

Bashir's face did the thing Naila had come to wait for: a small interior loosening, the relief of clean grammar after the static of a hard language. He listened the way other people looked. "She says," he murmured, "you walked with your eyes."

"Where else—"

He held up a hand, not to silence her but to keep the channel open, because Ximena was still talking, and his job in this moment was to be the wire and not the message. He listened a long beat. Then: “She says the eyes lie on this ground. The ground lies. The light lies.” A pause while she went on, and his brow drew in — not confusion, concentration, the particular labour of carrying meaning across a gap without dropping any of it. “She doesn’t walk to a thing she sees. She walks to a thing she says.”

“A thing she says,” Naila repeated.

The old woman turned and started uphill again, and now she was talking as she walked — low, even, a rhythm to it, words Naila didn’t have and would never have, but the *shape* she could hear. It rose and fell on a beat. It came in pairs and then a longer phrase, then pairs again, like the swing of the skirts, like the press and release of breath at altitude, like a thing built to be done while your lungs were screaming and you couldn’t spare attention for a horizon.

Bashir walked behind her and did not translate the words. After a moment Naila understood he *wasn’t going to*, and that this was not a failure of his gift but the whole exercise of it — that she had asked him once, on the first day, what one of the spoken lines meant, and he’d gone still and said *some of them aren’t mine to carry*, and she’d filed it as politeness and only now felt the floor of it. The saying held the bearing. He could hear that the saying held the bearing. He could not hand her the saying.

So Naila did the only thing she could. She fell in behind, and she stopped using her eyes.

She listened to the rhythm and she put her feet into it. Left on the pair, right on the pair, the longer phrase carrying her three strides where she’d take two, and she found — slowly, then with a lurch of something that was close to vertigo — that the rhythm did not let her drift. The drift was a thing that lived in *hesitation*, in the half-second where the eye reached for a target and the foot waited for the eye and the body, in that waiting, sagged off true. The saying erased the waiting. There was no half-second. The next foot went where the beat put it, and the beat did not curve, because a sentence does not curve. You do not say a word a little to the left. You say it, and the next one, and the order is the bearing.

She crested the belly of the slope a second time.

The tree was dead ahead. Not fifteen metres off. *Ahead*. She had not looked at it once.

She stopped so hard the grass hissed. She heard her own breath, fast and thin and loud in the enormous silence of the plain, and below it, fading now as the old woman walked on toward the red trees with the words still going, the rhythm she had borrowed for forty paces and would never own.

“Naila.” Mara, at her shoulder, had come up the slope without Naila hearing. The light was going to ember and the camera was still at her hip, still off, and Naila understood that Mara had watched the whole thing through her own eyes on purpose, the lens left dark, witnessing the one image she had decided the world did not get to take. “You walked it straight.”

“I didn’t walk it.” Naila’s hands were doing something — finding nothing to hold, the tablet long pocketed, no instrument, that was the point, that had always been the point and she had not let herself feel it until now. “She walked it. I borrowed the train tracks for forty paces and the second she’s out of earshot I’ll banana again. The straightness isn’t *in* the line.” She turned and looked back down: two tracks now in the bruised grass, her first one bent like a bow, her second one — the one she’d walked inside the rhythm — true as a ruler, running back down to where it had started. “The line is just the place the saying landed. Three thousand years of saying. They didn’t build a straight line. They said a straight sentence and it left a scar.”

She heard how it sounded. She heard the leap waiting just past it — *and therefore, and so, and what if* — and she did not take it, because the dossier said it cold and she would say it cold: nobody had fully explained the how. That was all that was true. Everything past that was hers to wonder and not hers to declare, and the difference between those two was the only honest ground on the whole vast plain.

Up ahead, Doña Ximena had reached the Polylepis. She put one hand flat on the gnarled red bark — a *wak’a*, Naila understood, not because anyone said so but because of the way the hand went down, the way you touch a thing that has a name older than the church on the next ridge. The old woman’s voice changed. The rhythm shortened, gathered, became something else, and Bashir, two steps below the tree,

lowered his head and went quiet in a way that had nothing to do with not understanding.

He understood. Naila could see that he understood. That was what the quiet was.

Niamh had stopped a little way off, reading the old woman's back, the set of her shoulders, the small private finishing of a thing. The interpreter beside her did not move to speak. There was nothing being said to them. There was a thing being said, and they had been allowed to stand near it while it happened, and the line between *near it* and *given it* was a line none of them would cross — Naila could feel all four of them holding to it at once, a kind of group muscle, the discipline of staying on this side.

The sun went under the rim. The plain dropped ten degrees in a breath and the frost-smell came up out of the grass.

Naila looked down at her two tracks one last time before the dark took them — the bent one and the true one, written side by side in bruised silver bunchgrass — and felt the thing settle in her that she had been keeping out all afternoon with her tablet and her geometry and her clean cold love of measurable facts.

She could measure the straightness to the millimetre. She had the survey-grade gear; she'd model the whole sixteen thousand kilometres if they let her. And it would tell her *that* it was straight, and never once *why* it didn't bend, because the *why* wasn't a fact in the ground. It was a fact in the air between a foot and a word, said in a tongue that wasn't hers, by people the world had walked past for three thousand years while they kept the largest drawn thing on Earth bright with their shins.

Ahead, in the last light, Doña Ximena took her hand off the tree, turned, and started back down the line toward them — and the words started again, low, paired, the longer phrase, the beat that did not curve — and Naila, who had spent her whole life being right about angles, stood very still and was, for once, gloriously, terribly unable to write down what she had just seen.

Somewhere down the slope, Bashir was already walking up into the rhythm to meet her.

Chapter 13 — The Practice Endures

The wak'a was a rock.

Mara made herself sit with that before she did anything else, because the camera in her hands wanted to make it something more, and the camera was always lying a little, even when she was telling the truth. A rock the size of a kneeling llama, dark and weathered, sitting where the line ran up to it and stopped — or didn't stop, you couldn't tell, the line went pale into the grass on the far side and kept going toward the next thing the eye couldn't find. Coca leaves at the base, a few of them, green going brown. A smear of fat, old, gone grey. The light at this hour was the kind she'd have crossed a continent for once: low, gold, raking, the *paja brava* lit from the side so every blade threw a shadow as long as a man.

She did not lift the camera.

Doña Filomena came up the line at the pace of someone who had walked it ten thousand times and would walk it ten thousand more, which is to say no pace at all, a pace that had nothing to do with arriving. Two others with her, older women, one carrying a small bundle wrapped in a striped *aguayo* the colour of a parrot. Bashir walked a respectful three steps behind, his hands loose at his sides, his whole body arranged into the posture of a man who has decided not to be useful.

That was new for him. Mara had watched him spend three weeks being useful in nine languages.

Oh good, said the fish, from the flat rock where it had

installed itself in a borrowed dish of meltwater, *we drove eleven hours up a mountain to watch a man practise not talking. Riveting. Tell the Academy.*

Naila was crouched at the line itself, not measuring. Her instruments were back in the truck. She had her hands flat on the scraped surface, palms down, the way you'd feel an animal's flank to know if it was breathing, and she was reading something off it through her skin that Mara couldn't see and didn't ask about. Niamh stood apart, where she always put herself, at the angle that let her see every face at once. Her interpreter, Sol, stood at her shoulder. Neither of them moved.

Filomena reached the rock. She did not perform anything. That was the first thing Mara's hands wanted to make a lie of — there was no *moment*, no gathering of stillness, no breath the camera could have caught and called *the ritual beginning*. The old woman simply arrived at the rock the way you arrive at a kitchen table, and crouched, and her knees cracked, and one of the other women laughed at the crack and Filomena said something that made all three of them laugh, and then she was unwrapping the parrot-coloured bundle and the laughing was still happening while she did it.

Bashir's mouth moved. Translating under his breath, to himself, because he couldn't not. Then he stopped himself doing even that and Mara saw the cost of it cross his face — the specific small grief of a man holding a door shut against his own hand.

The bundle held more coca, and a small bottle of something clear, and three little wrapped sweets in cellophane, the kind sold by the till in any shop on Earth.

Sweets, the fish noted. Three thousand years of unbroken sacred tradition and the offering is grape Chupa Chups. I love these people. No notes.

The clear bottle was alcohol; Filomena tipped a little onto the ground, onto the rock, said the names — Mara couldn't follow but she could hear that they *were* names, the cadence of a list, this one and this one and this one, a roll-call spoken downward into the dirt and outward along the pale line and up, once, with a lift of the chin, at the white cone of the mountain that owned the whole sky behind them. The two other women answered. Not in unison. In the way you answer at a table when someone says a thing you also know.

This is what the books got right and could never get across, Mara thought. *Ritual pilgrimage footpaths linking sacred places, kept by the walking, three thousand years.* All true. The British filmmaker in the seventies, the university survey, the careful map of the network — true, every word, and dead on the page, because the page made it sound finished. A thing that had *happened*. Past tense, completed, available for study. And here was the thing happening, in present continuous, with grape sweets and bad knees and a joke Mara would never understand, and the gap between the page and the rock was the whole distance she'd come.

Sol leaned to Niamh's ear, then signed something low and fast. Niamh signed back, one hand. Mara had learned to read about four of their words by now and this one she knew: *now*. Niamh had said *now*. Meaning, Mara was fairly sure, *they are not remembering this. They are doing it*.

She got it then, in her chest before her head, which was the only place getting anything ever actually mattered.

It was not a re-enactment. There was no original it was a copy of. The women at the rock were not honouring the walkers who'd come before; they *were* the walkers, the same walkers, the practice didn't have a then and a now, it had only ever had a *while-you-go*. The line stayed bright because feet kept scraping it. The wak'a stayed a wak'a because someone kept arriving at it with sweets and saying the names. Stop, and the grass takes the line back in a season; stop, and the rock is just a rock. The thing was alive in the most literal and least sentimental way Mara had ever encountered: it was alive the way a fire is alive. It existed only as long as it was being done.

Her hands lifted the camera.

She didn't decide to. Twenty years of muscle decided for her — the light, God, the *light*, Filomena's profile against the cone, the brown leaves and the cellophane catching gold and the long shadows of the grass, and she had the frame before she'd thought it, the frame that wins things, the frame that ends up on the cover with her name small in the corner, the frame that says *I was let in*.

She brought the eyepiece almost to her eye.

Filomena did not look up. But the woman with the *aguayo* did. Not

sharply. Not a flinch. She just — found Mara's face, across the rock, the way you find a draught in a room, and held it, with no expression Mara could put a word to, and waited.

And there it was: the thing she'd been refusing to learn the whole way up the mountain. The aerial shot of Nazca that made the hummingbird famous, the drone tile that had "solved" it — they'd been her instinct from the first day on the plain, *get above it, get the whole, get the god's-eye* — and they were a dead end that looked like a destination, because the makers never had them, because the meaning had never once been visible from above. And this was the same theft scaled down to one rock and three sweets. The frame would lift the moment out of the feet. It would take a thing that only existed in the doing and make it a thing that had been done. Past tense. Available for study. Hers.

*Take it, murmured the fish, very quietly, not heckling now.
Or don't. Nobody up here's going to stop you, kid. That's
the whole problem, isn't it.*

She lowered the camera.

She did it slowly, so it would read as what it was — not a snatch back, not a flinch of guilt, just a man putting down a thing he'd decided not to use. The woman with the *aguayo* watched her do it. Then she did something Mara would carry: she gave the smallest nod, half an inch, and turned back to the rock, and the nod hadn't been thanks and it hadn't been permission, it had been the thing Niamh had been trying to teach all of them for weeks — the difference between *can't* and *won't*, read in a single tilt of the head. *Won't*. And the *won't*, once you saw it, was not a wall. It was a held bearing. A line that refused to curve around the easy thing.

Mara let the strap take the weight of the camera against her sternum and stood there with her empty hands and felt, for the first time since the war, a particular muscle in her chest unclench that she hadn't known was clenched — the one that turned everything she loved into a thing to be kept.

The ritual, if it was a ritual, was already winding down, or it had no edges, the same way it had no beginning. Filomena rewrapped the bottle. One of the sweets had gone — to the rock, into a crack, an offering; the other two went into a pocket, and that was right too,

that was exactly the rightness of the whole thing, you gave one and you kept two, you didn't make a museum of your own grandmother's snacks. They were laughing again. Filomena said something over her shoulder to Bashir.

He answered. Carefully. A short phrase, the vowels of it placed like a man setting down eggs. Filomena's face opened. Not surprise — the door-half-opening thing he did, the courtesy in the real tongue that disarmed a room — but past that, into something warmer, an old woman finding that the stranger had bothered. She said a longer thing back, and Bashir's eyes shone, and he did not translate it.

Mara watched him not translate it and understood that he had been *trusted* not to. That somewhere in the longer thing was a sentence that was not theirs to carry off the mountain, and that Filomena had said it to him precisely *because* he was the one who'd know to leave it where it lay. The man whose entire gift was reaching all the way in had been let in exactly far enough to learn where the wall was, and the gift Filomena gave him was the wall itself, shown plainly, *here, this far, friend, and that's love, not insult.*

He nodded. He put his hand briefly over his own mouth. It looked like a man covering a smile. Mara knew it for what it was.

Jakobus was further down the line, where he always was — at the edge of the frame, off his own ground, the weathered shape of him reading the *land* the way the rest of them read faces. He'd come up the day before, said almost nothing, walked the line for a kilometre with his hands behind his back and that look he got at a made thing, the *what's-it-for* look, the look that had pulled apart a dozen ruins across three books. He had it now, watching the women at the rock. And then Mara saw him do the thing he did, the thing that was the whole reason the crew followed him onto cold plains: he let the look go. He turned it off, deliberately, the way you'd lower a weapon, and he found Filomena, and he didn't ask her anything. He just inclined his head, the small bow of a man handing something back that was never his to hold, and stepped further out of the frame, toward the truck, toward the road. Leaving the rock to the people whose rock it was.

The women started back down the line. Not toward anything Mara could see — toward the next node, the next pale thread running off

into grass that read flat and was not flat, that climbed a ridge a kilometre off without bending one degree to do it, the arrow held straight over the broken back of the world by nothing anyone had ever found written down. No king had commissioned it. No surveyor had sighted it. No one had ever stood high enough to see it whole. And it was still being walked, this minute, away from her, three women and two sweets, the names spoken downward into the dirt as they went.

Naila stood up from the line. She had a smear of pale subsoil on her palms. She looked at it, then at the women dwindling along the bearing they were not measuring against anything but their own going, and Mara watched the engineer in her finally stop fighting the un-solvable and just — watch. The way you watch weather. The way you watch a fire you've decided not to put out and not to feed, only to sit beside, while it does the one thing it does.

Huh, said the fish, and for once that was all it said.

Bashir came back along the line to where Mara stood. He looked at the camera lying dark against her chest. He looked at her face. He understood, the way he understood everything, sideways and through the words people didn't say.

"You didn't take it," he said.

"No."

He nodded. The wind came up off the plain, the cold edge of it, the *surazo* starting its evening business, and far down the line a woman laughed at something, and the sound carried impossibly far in the thin clean air, the way distance lied up here, the way the ridge an hour off was half a day and the laugh a kilometre away was right at your ear.

"Good," Bashir said. And then, with the specific loneliness of a man who had spent his life being the door everyone walked through and had just, today, been the one trusted to keep one shut: "She left me something to carry that I'm not going to give you."

"I know," Mara said.

He smiled. It was not a happy smile and it was not a sad one. It was the smile of someone who has finally been allowed to *belong* to something by being kept out of part of it, which was the only kind

of belonging the door had ever offered him, and the first time it had ever felt like enough.

They stood and watched the line carry the women off it, away over the ground, the brightness of it renewing under their feet with every step, the largest drawing on Earth getting drawn again, right now, by three people with bad knees who had somewhere to be.

Mara left the lens cap on.

Chapter 14 — The Words Withheld

The frost had not lifted off the *paja brava* when Inés Mamani came for him, and Bashir was already awake, which was its own small embarrassment — awake because he had spent the night running her grandmother's Aymara through his head the way some people count sheep, turning the agglutinated verbs over, the way the language stacked a whole sentence into one long-jointed word: the going, the carrying, the saying, the for-whom, all welded into a single breath. He could not stop doing it. He had never been able to stop. The tin roof of the *estancia* ticked as the sun touched it, and somewhere a llama complained, and Bashir lay in his sleeping bag mouthing *sarañani*, *let us go*, and feeling the cold air saw at the back of his throat at four thousand metres.

She did not knock. There was no door to knock on, only a wool blanket hung across the opening, and she drew it aside and stood there in her *pollera* and two cardigans and a felt hat, and looked at him the way she had looked at him from the first hour — patiently, as at weather.

“*Jutam*,” she said. Come.

He came.

Outside, the plain went on the way it always went on, pale ochre to the foot of the white cone, and the cone above it impossible, hung in a sky so deep at the top that it stopped being blue and became something with a violet in it that Bashir had no word for in any of his eleven languages, and he had checked. Mara would have a word for it in light. Naila would have a number. He had nothing, and for once the having-nothing did not feel like the loneliness it usually was. It

felt like standing under something.

They walked. Not on a line — beside one. He had learned, in the days here, that you did not put your boots on the scraped track unless you were walking it for the walking, and this morning was not that. The line ran north of them, a pale ribbon a metre wide where the dark oxidised surface stones had been cleared away three thousand years deep, exposing the lighter subsoil, kept bright — he understood this now in his body and not just from the dossier — kept bright only because feet kept clearing it. Stop, and it greens over. The largest drawing on the earth, and it lives the way a fire lives: only while tended.

Below them, half a kilometre off and downwind, he could hear the mapping team's generator. A flat industrial buzz that did not belong to the plain. Dr. Renske Vos's people had their drone cases out in the grey light, the foam-cut Pelican boxes open like clams, and a man in a high-vis vest was planting a survey marker with a mallet, the *tock* of it carrying clean across the cold air the way every sound carried up here, wrong and too close. They had been refused the trailhead. They were mapping the approach to it instead, which was permitted, which was legal, and which Inés walked past every morning without turning her head, the way you walk past a dog that is barking behind a fence it cannot clear.

"They will make a beautiful map," Inés said. In Spanish, this — she chose Spanish when she wanted him to hear it as a thing said *at* the team and not *to* the land. "And the map will be correct."

"And it will show nothing," Bashir said.

She looked at him sideways. He had got that right, and they both knew he had got it from her and not from himself, and she let him keep it anyway, which was its own kind of gift.

She stopped him at a *wak'a* — a shrine, though "shrine" was a thieving word for it, too churchy. It was a low rock, weathered, a darker stone than the plain around it, with the line running straight to its foot and straight away again from its other side, dead north on a bearing that, Naila had confirmed two nights ago with her phone and a tripod and a great deal of muttering, did not waver more than a hand's width over the nearest two kilometres of broken ground, including a low

ridge it had climbed rather than gone around.

It refused to curve around the hill, Naila had said, and there had been something in her voice Bashir recognised, because it was the voice he used when a language did something his ear could not yet model. *It would have been easier to go around. It is always easier to go around. They didn't.*

He could see the ridge from here. The line went over it like a seam in cloth, and you could not see the far side of the ridge from this rock, and you could not see this rock from the far side of the ridge, and there was no high ground anywhere that let you see both at once, and there never had been, and a society of separate walkers with no king and no instrument and no vantage had held that bearing arrow-straight for who-knew-how-long, and the published people, the honest ones who had spent careers on this, wrote down plainly that nobody fully understood how. Bashir had read that sentence in the dossier and felt the floor of it tilt — not toward anything, just open. Just *open*.

Inés set a small bundle down at the foot of the rock. Coca leaves, folded in a square of cloth. She did not unwrap it for him, and he did not look too hard, and that was the first of the morning's withholdings, and he let it be one.

Then she said: "I am going to say something. You will hear it. You will not write it. You will not say it again. You will not make it into another language."

The fish — and there was no fish, there was only Bashir, but somewhere in the back of his skull a voice that had been built over years of listening, a dry heckling voice that he privately thought of as the part of him that survived checkpoints, that voice said: *oh, here we go, the forbidden phrase, the magic words, very atmospheric, what's it pay—*

— and then she said it, and the voice shut up.

He could not have written it down if she had begged him to. That was the thing he had not expected. It was not that the words were hard; some of them he knew. It was that they came in an order, with a weight on certain syllables, with a pause where his ear told him no pause should grammatically go, and the pause *was* the meaning,

the pause was load-bearing, and the whole thing was built to be said *while walking*, he could feel that — the rhythm of it was a gait, it was paced to feet on ground, it was a sentence you laid down a metre at a time, and the straightness of the line was not an achievement held *against* the terrain at all.

It was the fossil of the saying.

You said the words, in order, in the going, and the bearing held because the words held the bearing, because you could not say them and drift, the saying was the surveying, the naming-while-going kept the line true the way a melody keeps a singer on pitch without the singer ever seeing a stave. No vantage. No instrument. The instrument was the mouth and the feet and three thousand years of people who knew the words and walked them in the right order, and the map from the air showed none of it because the map from the air was the one view no maker had ever had or needed or wanted.

He stood very still at the foot of the rock and felt the whole architecture of it arrive in him at once, the way a language sometimes did — not learned, *received*, dropping into place with a click he felt in his sternum.

And then, half a second behind the wonder, the second thing arrived, and it was heavier.

He understood it. And he could not have it.

This was the part Bashir had spent his whole life on the wrong side of. His entire usable self was *reaching all the way in* — that was the gift, that was the thing checkpoints could not strip-search out of him, the thing that had kept a stateless boy alive across borders that wanted him to be no one: he learned the next mouth so completely that the room half-disarmed, that the guard heard his own grandmother's village in a stranger's vowels and softened. He carried conversations the way other people carried passports. He had never, not once, met a closed door he could not at least make smaller.

And here was a sentence he had heard — *heard*, taken in, felt the structure of — that he was not to carry.

Not a sentence he failed to understand. That happened, that was

just work, that was the ordinary friction he loved. This was worse and better. He understood it well enough to know that understanding it more was not the point, that translation would not deepen it but *empty* it, that to render it into English or Arabic or Afrikaans or any of the tongues he wore like coats would be to lift the meaning out of the feet that made it and pin it to a page where it would die the way the line dies when the walking stops. The words were alive the way the line was alive: only in the use. Write them down and you'd have a corpse and call it preservation.

Down the slope, faint, the generator buzzed, and the mallet went *tock*, and a man read coordinates aloud to another man in flat Dutch-accented English, numbers, beautiful correct numbers, a map that would be right and show nothing.

Bashir thought, with a clarity that hurt: *they will never get this, because there is nothing here for an instrument to take. And neither will I. And the difference between me and them is the only thing that matters, and the difference is that I know to stop.*

He did not say any of this. Inés would not have wanted it said; saying it would have been its own small theft, dressing her withholding up in his words. He just stood, and let the loss be a loss — because it was one, he was honest enough not to pretend the door closing didn't cost him, the polyglot ache of being so close to a tongue and being told *not this far, friend, not you, not this* — and he let the respect be the larger thing, sitting on top of the loss like the cone sat on top of the plain.

Inés watched him take it. He understood, after, that this had been the whole test, and that it had not been a test of whether he could learn the phrase — she'd known he could — but of whether he could be told *no* and not push the door. Niamh had read this in her days ago and signed it to him across a cold breakfast, her hands quick and exact: *she's not deciding if you're clever. She decided that on day one. She's deciding if you'll stop.*

"You will not say it again," Inés said. Not a question.

"I will not say it again," Bashir said, in Aymara, the courtesy form, and got it right, and meant it more than he had ever meant anything in any language he owned.

She nodded once. And then — and this undid him more than the refusal had — she smiled, a small dry mountain smile, and switched into Spanish, and gave him a different thing, an *easier* thing, a thing he *could* carry, the way you give a child the safe knife.

“You can tell them what it is *for*,” she said.

He waited.

“It is for walking,” Inés said. “Write that. That one is true. That one you can take.”

He almost laughed, because it was a door that opened by being shut, because she had handed him the answer to the only question his whole crew had crossed an ocean to ask and the answer was a closed gate with a sign on it that said the gate is the point. *It is for walking*. Grounded. Physical. A thing you do with your body in order, in the going, and the largest drawing on earth was just the long bright fossil of three thousand years of people doing it.

Below, the mallet stopped. The generator cut out — out of fuel, or someone had thought better of it — and in the sudden enormous silence of the plain the wind came over the ridge with the line in it, the *surazo*, cold and clean, and carried nothing he could write down.

Bashir turned the unwritten phrase over once more, privately, the last time he would let himself, feeling its gait, its load-bearing pause, the place where the bearing held. Then he set it down at the foot of the rock with the coca leaves, in his head, where it would stay, and walked back beside the line — never on it — toward the others, carrying the one true sentence she’d let him keep, and leaving the other one exactly where it lived.

In the feet. On the ground. In a language that was not his to lend.

Chapter 15 — The Ridge That Refuses

The line went up.

That was the first thing Naila's body refused to accept, before her mind got involved. They had come around the shoulder of a low rise and there it was — a pale thread laid across the bunchgrass, one metre wide, scraped to the bone-coloured subsoil, running dead north toward a ridge that had no business being climbed. The ridge sat across the line's path like a closed fist. A sensible trail would have bent. Every trail Naila had ever measured bent. Water bent. Goats bent. Roads built by engineers with theodolites and budgets bent, because bending was cheaper than lungs.

The line did not bend. It walked straight at the ridge and up its face and over the top, and somewhere on the far side, the survey told her, it kept going for another fourteen kilometres without a wobble she could find.

"It refuses," she said. The Aymara word for it, the one Doña Severina had given them two days ago, sat in her mouth wrong; she let Bashir hold it. She had her own language for this. She crouched, set the inclinometer on the scraped ground, and watched the bubble crawl.

"Eleven degrees," she said. "Climbing. It'll be eighteen at the steep part."

Behind her, Frik made a sound that was half cough, half something he hadn't chosen to say. The altitude did that to him — pulled the thread tighter, gave the tics more rope. He'd warned them in La Paz. *The thinner the air, the louder I get.* Nobody had minded. Up here

everyone was breathing like a bellows anyway.

Doña Severina stood at the foot of the climb with two other walkers from her *estancia*, an old man named Eustaquio and a girl maybe seventeen, and they were not looking at the inclinometer. They were looking up the line, the way you look at a road you've driven a thousand times — not seeing the road, seeing the going.

Here is the part you have to take seriously, because it is true and it is the whole point.

This is a pilgrimage. The lines are sacred trails. They were scraped open by Aymara feet three thousand years ago and they have been kept bright by Aymara feet ever since — older than the Inca, older than the chapels the lines later reached out and gathered in. You walk from a *wak'a* to a *chullpa* to a spring to a white-walled church and back out to the open plain, and the going is the prayer. Tony Morrison found them for the outside world in the seventies. A team from Pennsylvania mapped what they could. The archaeology is patient and humble and it says, in print, in the dry careful voice of people who do not like to guess: *neither the purpose nor how the makers achieved such precision is completely understood.*

Naila loved that sentence. She had read it forty times. It was the most honest sentence she'd ever met in a discipline that hated saying it didn't know.

What it meant, standing here with her boots on the scraped subsoil and the ridge leaning over her, was this. Nobody commissioned this. There was no king, no architect, no surveying corps, no single mind that ever saw the line whole. It was made by people, separately, across a hundred lifetimes, each adding their walking to the walking before. And it is *straight*. Not roughly straight. Not straight-enough-for-walking. Straight the way a tightened wire is straight, over a ridge that no instrument-less human being could have sighted across, because to sight across it you would need to *stand above it*, and there is nowhere above it to stand.

A skeptic would say: footpaths. People walk where people walked. The line is just the worn record of habit.

And Naila, who had spent eleven years measuring things that other

people called obvious, wanted to take that skeptic gently by the sleeve and walk him up this hill.

Because habit takes the easy way. Habit *bends*.

This refused.

The climb broke them quietly, one at a time.

It started kind. The grade pulled at the backs of her calves and she leaned into it and counted her breaths in fours the way the guide had taught them — in, in, out, out — and for a while the rhythm held. The *paja brava* hissed against her trousers. The light up here was a physical thing, hard and clean and far too long; the top of the ridge looked twenty minutes off and was not.

Then the grade steepened and the air thinned with the altitude they were gaining and the four-count fell apart.

She'd modelled this. Last night, in the cold of the tent, by headlamp, she had built the little equation that always calmed her: oxygen partial pressure as a function of height, the body's cost per metre, the slope she'd measured. She'd proven on paper that the line *should* have gone around. That a curve adding six hundred metres of distance would have saved the walker something like a third of the work. That the straight path was, by any honest accounting of human effort, the *expensive* path. Stupid, even, if effort were the thing being saved.

The numbers were right. She trusted the numbers. And the numbers explained nothing, because the makers had not been trying to save effort. They had spent it on purpose. The straightness cost — and the cost was not a flaw in the design. The cost was the design.

She understood it as a fact at sea level. She was learning it now as a thing that happened to your lungs.

Mara was ahead of her, camera down, both hands free, climbing like she'd done worse. She had — you could see it in how she moved, economical, never spending more than the slope demanded. She had not lifted the camera since the foot of the ridge. Naila had noticed. Naila noticed everything; it was the cost and the gift, the same wiring, no seam between them. Mara had pointed the lens up the line once, at the bottom, and then she had looked at the back of

Doña Severina's head, at the unhurried way the old woman started up, and she had let the camera fall against her chest and left it there.

Niamh climbed beside her interpreter, and the two of them had worked out a thing where the interpreter signed against her own thigh, low, so Niamh could read it without either of them stopping. Niamh was watching the walkers' faces. She did that. She read the room because the room had spent her whole life talking over her head, and so she had learned to take the meaning off the surface of a face the way other people took it off the air. She wasn't reading the line. She was reading Doña Severina reading the line.

And Bashir — Bashir was beside the old woman, and they were *talking*. Climbing this, at this height, and talking, low, in Aymara, in the real grammar of it, not the phrasebook. Naila couldn't follow it. She didn't need to. She could see what it did. Doña Severina's mouth moved as she walked, steady, almost under the breath, and Bashir's head was tipped toward her, and his lips were moving too — not echoing, *catching*. Learning the shape of whatever she was saying as her feet laid it down.

He'd told them, last night, in his careful way, the thing he wasn't sure of yet. *I think she's not just walking it. I think she's saying it.* He hadn't explained. He'd looked tired, the specific tired of a man who carries every conversation and is never just inside one. *Give me the ridge*, he'd said. *I'll know on the ridge.*

At the steep part Frik went down on one knee and the cough turned into a word he hadn't picked, sharp and ugly, and it rang off the bare slope and away across the plain. He flinched at himself.

The seventeen-year-old, the girl, turned around. Naila braced for the look — the flicker people couldn't hide, the recalculation.

The girl waited. She put out a hand, not to pull him up, just to be there, the way you'd steady a fence-post. Frik took it. Got his foot under him. Said *sorry* in three languages because that was where the thread had him, and the girl said something back, easy, that Bashir caught and rendered low over his shoulder without breaking stride.

"She says the hill takes everybody's words. She says you should hear her grandmother on a cold morning."

Frik laughed, which broke into the cough, which he let happen, and he climbed.

That was the moment Naila stopped measuring.

She had the instruments out of habit and she put them away because she understood, with her body now and not her paper, that the instrument was the wrong end of the thing. She had brought a theodolite to a sentence. She had been trying to read from the air, with optics and arithmetic, a thing that only existed when feet were on it, in order, going. The map was a dead end that looked like progress because the makers never had the map. They had this. The burn in the thigh. The four-count gone to pieces. The ridge that refused, refusing *through you*.

She wasn't tracking the line anymore. The line was tracking her. It went where it went and her feet found it without her looking down, because once you were on it there was only the one way that didn't feel like falling off, and that way was *up*, and *straight*, and the straightness wasn't something you read.

It was something you held.

They heard the mapping team before they saw them, which was its own small joke.

Down at the foot of the ridge, where the line met the rise, two of Renner's people had come around the shoulder with a drone case and a tripod and the survey-grade rig that could, given a clear sky and a calm day, lay down a line to the centimetre across forty kilometres of nothing. Naila knew the kit. It was beautiful kit. It was the kit she'd have killed for, once, before this place taught her what it couldn't do.

They got the tripod up. One of them started up the slope after the walkers — young, fit, sea-level fit, the wrong kind for here — and made forty metres before the air took him. He stopped. Hands on knees. Looked up the line at the small, unhurried, ancient procession that was already two-thirds to the ridge top, an old woman and an older man and a girl and four strangers she'd decided to trust, and you could see him do the arithmetic Naila had done on paper last night and get the same answer.

He couldn't keep pace. Not the climb — anyone fit could *eventually* make a climb. He couldn't keep pace with the *walking*, because the walking wasn't his. There was no instrument in the case that knew the way the way a body that had walked it knew the way. His drone could photograph the line from a thousand metres up and the photograph would be true and would mean precisely nothing, because the meaning had never once in three thousand years been visible from above.

He shouted something. The wind took it. Doña Severina did not turn around. She had not turned around for him the whole time, Naila realised — not out of rudeness, just the way you don't turn around for weather. He was a thing happening at the bottom of the hill. The walking was up here.

Bashir glanced back at the stranded surveyor, then forward at the old woman, and something crossed his face that Naila filed and did not name. Then he faced front and kept catching the shape of what she said.

The ridge top, when it came, came all at once, the way they do — the slope falling away on the far side and the whole plain opening pale and immense and the white cone of Sajama presiding over every kilometre of it, and the line going *on*, down the far face, straight, into the distance until the eye lost it in the long light.

Naila stood with her hands on her knees and her lungs working and the cold sweat already turning to frost-edge in the wind, and she did not say anything, because there was nothing to say that wasn't smaller than this.

Mara was beside her. The camera was still down.

"You could have had that shot," Naila said, when she had the breath. "Coming over the top. That's the shot."

Mara looked out at the line going on without them. "Yeah," she said. "It is."

She didn't lift the camera.

Frik was sitting on a stone with his head back, eyes shut, the thread gone quiet for once, the way it sometimes went after a body had

spent everything it had. Niamh was watching Doña Severina, and Doña Severina was looking down the far face of the ridge at the line she'd just laid back open under her feet, her lips still moving, low, saying the thing she'd been saying the whole climb, the thing that held the bearing.

Bashir came and stood by Naila. He'd stopped catching it. He was just listening now.

"You got it," Naila said. "Whatever it is. On the ridge. Like you said."

He didn't answer for a while. The wind moved the grass.

"I got *some* of it," he said finally, and his voice had a thing in it she'd not heard from him, who was at home in every language and native to none. "The order. The names. She says them as she walks — the *wak'a*, the spring, the dead, the next — in the order the feet meet them. The line is the saying." He stopped. "And there's a part at the end she stops saying out loud. Right at the end."

"What's the part?"

Bashir watched the old woman's mouth.

"I don't think it's mine to ask," he said.

Down at the bottom of the hill, very small now, the surveyor was packing the tripod back into its case.

Chapter 16 — The Night on the Plain

The cold came up out of the ground before the sun was properly down, the way it always did here — not a chill that arrived but one that had been waiting under the *paja brava* all day and rose the moment the light stopped feeding it. Mara felt it through the soles of her boots first, then her knees, then the small of her back where she'd crouched too long over the fire ring, feeding it dried llama dung and a few sticks of queñua that snapped like old bone.

She did not lift the camera.

That was the discipline now, the one she'd been practising for four days the way you practise not touching a bruise. The fire was beautiful. Of course it was. Firelight on dark Aymara faces under a sky going violet at the top and bruise-orange along the rim of the plain, Sajama itself a pale ghost over the herder's left shoulder, holding the last of the day on its snow like it was reluctant to let go. It was the most photographable thing she had stood in front of in two years. The frame composed itself without her. And she let it pass, and pass again, and the not-taking sat in her chest like a held breath.

Across the fire, Tomasa Quispe was telling a story Mara couldn't follow a word of.

She was the walker who had brought them here — older than she looked or younger, Mara couldn't tell, with the kind of face the wind had worked on until it stopped showing age and started showing weather. *Yatiri*, Bashir had said the first day, very quietly, and then had not used the word again, because using it felt like reaching for a handle that wasn't his. She read the lines. Not read them the way

Naila did, with a tape and a clinometer and her jaw set against the impossible. Read them the way you read a sentence you already know by heart.

Now she was talking, and the four other walkers around the fire were laughing at the turns, and Bashir — sitting cross-legged with his hood down despite the cold, because the cold was nothing next to a language he could hear the shape of — was laughing half a beat behind. The half-beat was him translating. It was always him translating. Mara had watched him do it across a dozen countries and she still couldn't decide whether the half-beat was the loneliest thing she'd ever seen or the most generous.

He leaned toward her without taking his eyes off Tomasa. "She's saying her grandfather walked the Pumiri line so many times he could do it in the dark. With his eyes shut. The others are saying that's a lie because nobody can do that line drunk, and apparently the grandfather—" he listened, the corner of his mouth going up "—the grandfather was famously, *historically* drunk."

"And could he?"

"Do it drunk?" Bashir's head tilted. There was a longer pause, a longer listen. Tomasa said something else and the laughing changed key, went warmer and lower, and then folded itself away into the snap of the fire. "She says the line holds you up. If you say it right, it carries you."

Mara waited for more. There wasn't more. Bashir had stopped translating, and she understood — the way she understood a shutter that had jammed — that the stopping wasn't a failure to keep up. It was him declining to carry that one across. *Say it right*. Whatever Tomasa meant by saying it right, Bashir had heard the edge of it and set it down on the far side of the fire where it belonged.

Hecklefish, if Hecklefish had been allowed within a thousand kilometres of a sacred *wak'a*, would have had a great deal to say about a sixteen-thousand-kilometre artwork maintained, per the dossier, *by drunk grandfathers walking home*. Something like: *oh good, the largest drawing on Earth and the surveying instrument is a man who's had eight*. He would not have been wrong, exactly. That was the mad-

dening thing about him. He'd point at the gap and the gap would be real.

Because here was the gap, and Mara had spent four days watching it refuse to close.

The line that ran north from this *estancia* — Tomasa's line, the one they would walk at dawn — went up over the Pumiri ridge instead of around it. Naila had walked the whole climb yesterday with the laser rangefinder, gone grey and breathless at four thousand metres, and come back and sat down hard and said the deviation across the visible two kilometres, over a *ridge*, was less than a body's width. No instrument. No vantage. You could not see the far end of it from anywhere on it; the ridge itself blocked the sightline at exactly the point you'd most need to correct. And the walkers had held it straight, by foot, for three thousand years, building it the way you build a path — by going. *Subtractive*, the survey called it. Scrape the dark stones, expose the pale ground beneath, keep walking so it never greens over.

Mara had photographed the line. The straightness didn't read in any frame she'd taken. It was the thing about this whole place that broke her tools clean in half: from above, from a drone, from the satellite tile Naila had spread across the truck's hood that first night, you could see *that* it was straight and you could not see *one single thing* about why or how, because the why and how were not in the geometry. They were in the going.

She set another knuckle of queñua on the coals and did not reach for the camera that was warm against her hip.

Niamh sat on Mara's left, close, the firelight giving her hands something to be legible in. The interpreter — Esteban, a quiet UPenn-trained Bolivian who'd come up with them from Sajama village — had gone to sleep an hour ago in the back of the truck, which meant the conversation had narrowed to whatever Bashir could relay and whatever Niamh could read off the faces. And Niamh, Mara had long since stopped being surprised, read more off the faces than Bashir got off the words.

She touched Mara's wrist. Pointed two fingers at her own eyes, then

tipped them toward Tomasa, then made a small flat gesture, palm down, settling — the sign she used between them for *watch this, it's about to go quiet*.

Mara watched.

Frik, three places round the fire, had been doing what Frik did when he was nervous and trying very hard not to be, which was talk too much in the gaps and ride the edge of the thing that made the words jump. He'd been good all night — the cold and the altitude and the careful slow rhythm of the walkers had given his nervous system somewhere to put itself — but now he leaned in, all enthusiasm, and asked Bashir to ask Tomasa the question Naila had been dying to ask for four days.

"Ask her—" a small jerk of his shoulder, swallowed "—ask her how they *check* it. The straight. How does anyone keep it straight if you can't — *brick* — if you can't see the end?"

Bashir didn't ask it straight away. He held it, the way you hold a glass you're not sure is full. Then he asked it gently, in the long looping Aymara that Mara couldn't parse but could hear was *careful*, hedged round with what she now knew were courtesies — *forgive me, I am only asking, you do not have to*.

Tomasa looked at the fire.

This was the moment Niamh had flagged. Mara saw it land. Not a flinch — nothing so coarse. The walkers around the fire didn't go silent so much as *make a space*, the way a room makes space when someone says a name that shouldn't be said at dinner. One of the younger men picked up a stick and turned a coal. Tomasa's hands stayed in her lap.

She said something short. Bashir translated it short.

"She says: 'You don't check it. You say it.'"

Frik waited for the rest. Mara waited for the rest. There wasn't any rest. There was the fire, and the wind starting its night-work in the bunchgrass, and Sajama gone now to a darker grey against the stars that were coming out hard and close the way they only did this high, where the air was too thin to soften them.

Niamh's fingers moved against Mara's wrist again. Slow. *She knows*.

That was the whole of it, and Mara felt it go through her like the cold had gone through her boots. There was a difference — Niamh had spent her entire life on the wrong side of it, being talked over by people who assumed a silence was an absence — between *doesn't know* and *won't say*. Tomasa was not a woman who didn't know how the line stayed straight. She was a woman who had just been asked, kindly, by a guest she'd chosen to bring to her fire, to translate a sentence that did not survive translation, and who had given them exactly as much as the question deserved and not one syllable past it.

You say it. Said while walking. The dossier had a clean archaeological word for the radial logic of it — *ceque*, sightlines out from a centre, the way Cusco organised its shrines — and the word explained the map and explained nothing about the night. Because the saying was the surveying. The words you spoke as you went, in order, the naming of the *wak'as* as you passed them, the grammar of the going — *that* was the instrument. Walk it saying it right and the bearing held, and no one had ever needed a vantage because no one had ever been reading it from above. They'd been *inside the sentence*.

And Tomasa would tell you that, and let you feel the size of it, and she would not say the words themselves. Those were the ones that did the work. Those were not for the fire, not for Bashir's careful mouth, not for Esteban asleep in the truck and certainly not for the mapping team forty kilometres south with their drones and their press release about *opening the lines to the world*.

Hecklefish: *so the answer is a sentence and she won't tell you the sentence. Yeah. And the largest artwork on Earth is being kept secret by a woman who's giving you tea. Yeah. That too.*

Bashir didn't push it. Mara saw the cost of that on him as clearly as she'd seen the not-taking sit in her own chest. His whole gift was reaching all the way in — the *sawubona* of it, the door that half-opens because you knocked in the right language. He had spent his life being the one who got let through. And he set his hands on his knees and inclined his head a fraction toward Tomasa, an acknowledgement, the smallest possible *I heard where the door was, I won't lean on it*, and he changed the subject to the grandfather again, the drunk

and famous grandfather, and the walkers laughed, and the space the question had opened closed back over like water.

Tomasa looked at Bashir for a moment when he did it. Mara caught the look because she catches looks for a living. It wasn't gratitude, which would have been too small. It was *recognition*. The look of a keeper clocking that the man across the fire knew what a kept thing was, and what it cost to keep it, and had just chosen — in front of all of them, in her own language — to help her keep it.

That, Mara thought, was the only thing they'd actually been given tonight. Not the words. Not how the line stayed straight. They'd been given the knowledge that there *was* a door, that it was real and old and held shut on purpose by someone entirely capable of opening it, and that they'd be allowed to walk up to it at dawn and stand beside it and feel the size of the room behind it.

She would not photograph the dawn walk. She'd already decided. The frame that would make her name — the line going arrow-straight up over the Pumiri ridge into the rising sun, pilgrims small and black against the pale scraped ground, the largest drawing on Earth caught in the one image that proved it existed — was the exact frame that would lift the meaning out of the feet and pin it to a wall in a gallery in a city where no one would ever say it right. The drone stayed in the case. The thieving frame stayed untaken. That was the whole of her discipline and it felt, sitting in the cold with the fire dying, less like a sacrifice than like finally putting down something heavy she'd been carrying since the last war.

Niamh nudged her. Pointed at Tomasa, then up the dark slope of the plain to where the line ran invisible toward the ridge, then made the small settling gesture again, palm down — *watch this* — but slower now, gentler, turned at the end into something almost like the sign for *trust*.

The walkers were banking the fire. Tomasa got up, joints and weather, and stood looking north at the ridge they couldn't see and would walk before the sun cleared it. She said one more thing, to no one, to the dark, to the line.

Bashir didn't translate it.

Mara didn't ask him to.

Chapter 17 — The Dawn Walk

The cold came up through the soles of her boots before the light did.

Niamh stood at the edge of the village while the sky was still the colour of slate, and read the morning the way she read every room — by who was looking at what. Doña Rufina was looking at the mountain. Not glancing. Standing square to it, the way you stand square to a person you owe a greeting, with her shawl pinned and her two long braids gone silver at the roots and her face doing the thing Niamh had learned to wait for: nothing. A stillness that wasn't absence. A stillness that was a decision being held.

Bashir stood a half-step behind the old woman's shoulder, hands loose, not speaking. He had not spoken since they'd left the adobe in the dark. Niamh had watched him not-speak with the particular care of a man putting down something heavy and being careful where it landed.

Frik signed at her, low, hands close to his chest so the gesture wouldn't carry: *they really letting us*.

They're letting us, she signed back. Then, because his eyes had gone wide and bright and his jaw was ticking sideways — the tell that meant he was about to say a true thing too loud for the hour — she put two fingers flat on his forearm. He breathed. The tic ran out through his shoulder instead, harmless, into the cold.

Behind them, down the single dirt track, the other thing was happening. Niamh turned just enough to take it in without making a show of turning.

Headlights. Three vehicles, white, the kind that came with a logo and a permit and a man in a fleece who said *we're all on the same team here*. They had stopped at the cattle-grid a kilometre out, where the track met the community's land, and they were not moving. A figure had got down from the lead truck and was standing with his hands on his hips in the posture men adopt when they have been told *no* by someone they assumed would say *yes*. Niamh couldn't hear him. She had never been able to hear him. She had spent a week reading the back of his neck and she knew the shape of him better than his own surveyors did. The shape of him this morning was a man recalculating.

Two community men stood at the grid with their backs to him. Not arguing. Just there. The most expensive instrument in the truck behind him — and there was a lot of instrument in that truck, total-stations and GNSS rovers and a drone in a foam case worth more than the chapel — was at this moment less useful than two men with their backs turned, because the thing the team had come to map was about to walk away from them up the mountain, and nobody was going to tell them the words.

That, Hecklefish would have said, surfacing in some bucket nobody packed for four thousand metres, *is the single most satisfying use of two guys standing still I have ever witnessed. Frame it. Oh wait — you can't.*

Mara came up beside her. The camera was on its strap but turned, deliberately, so the lens pointed at the ground. She had carried it that way since yesterday, the way you'd carry a dog you'd promised not to let off the lead. Her face had the flat, scoured look it got when the want was strong and she was choosing against it in real time, frame by unframed frame.

You okay, Niamh signed.

Mara tipped her head at the eastern ridge, where the sky had gone from slate to the grey-gold that meant the sun was about to clear the line of the world. The light here didn't arrive. It detonated. One minute the plain was a held breath of bone and ash; the next the *paja brava* lit up gold to the horizon and the white cone of Sajama went from a darker dark to a thing so bright it hurt, and every shadow on

the plain lay down pointing west in a single instant.

Mara's hand twitched on the strap.

She didn't lift it.

Niamh watched her not lift it and felt, ridiculously, her own eyes sting. Some images you don't take. It was a sentence Mara had said exactly once, in the truck, in the dark, to no one, and Niamh had read it off her mouth in the dashboard glow and pretended she hadn't.

Rufina turned from the mountain. She looked at the five of them — at the strangers her cousin's husband's word had brought up the track in the dark — and her face opened by one degree. Not a smile. The thing before a smile. An acknowledgement that they were here and that here was a thing being given.

She spoke. Niamh caught the shape of it on her lips and a half-second behind it Bashir's hands moved, low, fingerspelling and signing the rough of it for her the way they'd worked out — he was not a fluent signer, his hands stumbled, but his ear was perfect and he gave her the meaning even when the grammar fell over.

We walk before the sun is high, he gave her. *We walk to the* — his hand stopped, searched — *to the high wak'a, the rock where*— and then his hand simply stopped, fingers half-formed, and he shook his head, once, small.

Some sentences you don't translate.

Niamh nodded that she understood. Not the words. The stopping. She had spent her whole life on the receiving end of *I'll explain later* and *it's not important* and the small theft of being talked over and around, and she knew — better than anyone here, better than Bashir who could enter a language and better than Naila who could measure a thing to the millimetre — she knew the exact difference between *doesn't know* and *won't say*. Rufina knew. Rufina was not going to say. That was not a door stuck shut. That was a door someone was holding, on purpose, with a hand on the latch and a kind face, and you did not push it. You said thank you for the part of the room you'd been let into, and you stood in it carefully.

So Niamh put her hand to her chest and bowed her head the few degrees that meant the same thing in every room she'd ever read.

Rufina's eyes crinkled. She turned and started to walk.

The line began at a low stone heap at the village edge — a *wak'a*, Bashir had said, a place where something had happened that the rock now remembered — and it ran from there toward the ridge with the absolute conviction of a thing that had made up its mind three thousand years ago.

Niamh had seen it from above. They all had. Naila's drone footage from the first week, the satellite tiles spread on the table in La Paz: the lines from the air were a fan, a god's-eye blueprint, beautiful and dead. From above you could see *everything* and it told you *nothing*, because — and this was the joke the whole plain was playing on the white trucks at the cattle-grid — the makers had never once seen it from above. Not a single foot that scraped this line had ever stood where the drone stood. The map was a thing nobody who made it had ever owned.

On the ground it was different. On the ground it was a pale ribbon a metre wide, the dark oxidised stones scraped aside to bare the lighter subsoil, running straight at the foot of a ridge that any sane path would have curved around.

It did not curve around.

It went *up*.

Niamh felt Naila go rigid beside her. Naila had spent four days proving how hard this was — proving it with her own body, with a sighting rod and a length of string and her lungs screaming at four thousand metres, trying to lay forty straight metres across a slope with no instrument and no vantage, and failing, and failing better, and finally sitting down in the dust with a face that said *this should not be possible and it is sitting right here being possible*. Now she watched the old people start up the ridge along a line that did not deviate, and her hands came up in front of her and pressed flat together, fingertips to lips, which was not a sign, which was just Naila trying to hold something in.

Because here was the thing the instruments in the truck could not measure.

They started to chant.

Niamh could not hear it. She would never hear it. But she could read it, and reading it she understood the shape of the answer the way you understand a shape in the dark by running your hands along it.

It went like this. Rufina spoke a phrase — Niamh caught it on her lips, a name, then a word that turned, then another name — and on the name the lead foot came down. The phrase and the step were one motion. The old man behind her echoed the phrase a beat late, and his step landed a beat late, and the woman behind *him* echoed it again, so that the chant ran backward down the line like a wave and the feet ran backward down the line like a wave and the whole string of them moved up the ridge as a single travelling sentence with legs.

The straightness was *in the words*.

That was it. That was the whole thing the white trucks would never get into their foam cases. The line did not stay straight because someone had surveyed it. It stayed straight because each person said the next name in the order the names came, and to say the names in order you had to face the next *wak'a*, and to face the next *wak'a* you had to be standing where the last one put you, and the saying held the bearing. The naming was the surveying. The mouth was the instrument. You could not curve the line without lying, and nobody up here was going to lie on the way to the rock that remembered.

Bashir was beside her again. His hands had stopped trying to translate. He was just walking, mouth moving — he had the phrases now, was saying them under his breath, his ear *cannot not* take a language's shape and it had taken this one — and his face had a thing on it Niamh had not seen on him before. The polyglot who was at home in every tongue and native to none, the man who carried every conversation and was never simply *in* one, was walking inside one. Not translating it. Not carrying it across to anyone. Just saying it, in step, in order, with the breath the altitude allowed him, one foot and one name at a time.

He was, for the length of one line up one ridge, not alone in a language.

He felt her looking. He glanced at her. He did not explain it. He just kept saying the words, and Niamh understood that *this* — the not-explaining — was the gift Rufina had given him, and that he knew it, and that he would die before he printed it.

The sun cleared the ridge and hit them full.

The cold broke into warmth on her left cheek; the cone of Sajama burned white above; the gnarled red queñua on the lower slope caught the light and went the colour of old blood, the highest trees on the whole earth, holding on at an altitude that should have killed them, the way the people holding on. The line ran up into the brightness and the chanting wave ran up the line and Niamh walked it, in the order, in the body, in the place where the meaning lived and had always lived, where no overhead view could ever follow.

She looked back, once, down the long pale ribbon to the plain.

The white trucks were tiny now. The man with his hands on his hips was a speck by the grid. He had a continent's worth of line in his drone footage and not one metre of it that meant anything, and somewhere down there a foam case held an instrument that could measure the straightness to a hair and would never, not in a thousand survey seasons, find the reason it was straight, because the reason was a name said on a footfall by a woman who would say it whether they mapped her or not.

Honestly, said the absent fish, quieter than usual, almost respectful, *I got nothing*.

Frik was crying. Not loudly. His jaw worked and a sound got out of him, one syllable, sharp, that wasn't a word and that landed in the chant like a stone in a stream — and the old man ahead of him did not turn, did not frown, just let the sound be there and said the next name and stepped, and the line did not bend, and Frik's face came apart and put itself back together in gratitude, and Niamh put her hand flat between his shoulder blades and felt the next phrase come up through him into his feet.

She did not know what the line said. She would go home not knowing. There would be a book and the book would have a hole in it shaped exactly like this morning, an unanswered thing measured with a cold eye and left open, and that was right.

You don't solve a pilgrimage.

You're invited on it, or you aren't.

And for the length of one line, in the long clean light, with her boots in the bright subsoil and the names she couldn't hear breaking like a wave around her, Niamh Devlin had been invited — and knew exactly, to the millimetre, where to stop.

Ahead, Rufina lifted her chin to the next rock on the ridge, and said its name, and walked.

Chapter 18 — The Handoff

The cold came up out of the ground before the light did.

Bashir had learned, by the fourth morning, that the Altiplano gave its dawn away in stages, like a man counting out coins he resents parting with. First the cone — Sajama, white and impossible, taking the sun an hour before anyone on the plain felt it. Then the high *queñua* on the flanks, the red bark going copper. Then, last and grudging, the floor of the world where the people actually stood, where the frost had welded the *paja brava* into little spears of glass that snapped underfoot.

He stood in that last cold with the others, and he kept his mouth shut, which for him was the hardest discipline there was.

There were eleven of them on the line. Doña Rosa at the head — the *yatiri*, though Bashir had stopped calling her that in his own head somewhere around the third day, because the word did less work than her hands did. Two of her grandsons. An old man named Mauricio who had walked this segment, he'd said, since before the road came. A woman with a child wrapped against her back, the child's face the only part of either of them not bound in cloth against the *surazo*. And the crew, strung out behind, told once and clearly where to stand: behind. Always behind.

Mara's camera hung at her chest, capped. She had capped it herself, last night, without being asked, and Bashir had watched her do it and said nothing about that either.

"*Kunapachakamasa*," Rosa said. Not to them. To the line.

Bashir's ear caught it and held it the way it always did, helpless, parsing before he could stop it — *until when, for how long, the duration of*

a thing — and then he made himself let it go. That was the discipline. Hear it; don't carry it off.

The official story is true. He kept reminding himself of that, because the truth of it was the only thing that kept the morning from feeling like trespass.

This was pilgrimage. The British filmmaker Tony Morrison had brought word of these lines to the outside world in the 1970s, and the men and women from the University of Pennsylvania had walked the *Tierra Sajama* survey across this district and written down what could be written, and what they had written was not *mystery* — it was *Aymara, theirs, alive*. A web of trails scored from the dark surface stones down to the pale earth beneath, threaded between *wak'as* and *chullpas* and the white chapels the practice had simply absorbed into itself, the way a river takes a new stone. Sixteen thousand kilometres of it. The largest thing human beings had ever drawn on the face of the planet, and Doña Rosa was about to walk a single kilometre of it because today was a day it was walked.

There was no riddle here. He'd believed that, arriving. He still believed it. He just no longer believed it was the *whole* of the thing, and the gap between those two beliefs was where he'd been living for a week.

Rosa stepped onto the line.

The thing about the straightness — and Naila had said this on the second day, flat, in the voice she used when a fact had personally offended her — is that it should not survive contact with this ground.

He could see what she meant now, watching the line run out ahead of them. It did not pick the easy way. There was a ridge maybe four hundred metres on, a low spine of broken volcanic rubble with a perfectly good saddle to the left of it where any reasonable trail would have gone, where his own feet wanted to go just looking at it. The line refused the saddle. The line went *up*, over the spine, dead-straight, and came down the far side on exactly the bearing it had held coming in, and you could see — even from here, even in this raking light — that it had been doing this for a very long time.

Naila had spent two days trying to break it. She'd had the drone up — before Rosa's people had quietly made it understood that the drone was a guest who had overstayed — and she'd laid the satellite tiles over the survey, and she had measured, on the ground, the deviation of a twenty-kilometre run, and she had come back to the *estancia* and sat down hard and said: *they didn't have a hill to read it from.*

That was the whole of it, in seven words. To sight a line straight, you climb something and look. You correct. There is no high place on this plain that lets you see twenty kilometres of your own intention; the curve of the world takes it, the ground heaves and the line drops into a ravine and out again and you, standing anywhere a human being can stand, cannot see whether it came out true. The published surveys said it without flinching, and Naila had quoted it to them like a charge sheet: *neither the purpose nor how the makers achieved such precision is completely understood.*

No king ordered it. No instrument sighted it. No vantage corrected it. It was made piecemeal, by people who did not coordinate across the three thousand years it took, and it came out arrow-straight over the hills.

So *how*— Naila had started, that night.

And Rosa, who had been listening from the doorway with her tea, who they hadn't known understood as much Spanish as she did, had said: *You keep asking how they did it.* And smiled, not unkindly, and gone to bed, and left the *how* lying on the table like a coin she'd declined to pick up.

They walked.

It was not, Bashir found, like walking. It was like being *kept on something*. Rosa walked at the head and she was *saying* — low, steady, a register he had no name for in any of the tongues he carried, somewhere between speech and counting and the thing a mother does over a fevered child. The grandsons answered at intervals. Mauricio answered. The words went down the line and along the line and Bashir, walking, finally understood the sentence the whole book had been trying to make him hear, and it arrived the way it was supposed to — not from above, not as a solution. In the body. In the order. In

the feet.

The line was the bearing.

Not a path to a place. The saying was the path. Rosa was naming the ground as she crossed it — that rock, that turn the spring had made before the spring went dry, that place where the thing had happened that the word still held — and the naming had an order, and the order had a direction, and you could not say the next word from anywhere but the next step. You walked the sentence. The straightness wasn't engineering. The straightness was *grammar*. You held the bearing because the words came in that order and the words came in that order because that was where they were *true*, and a man trying to skirt the ridge would have had to say the wrong word in the wrong place, and so the line went over the ridge, because the sentence did.

No one had drawn this. It had been *said* across three thousand years, and the saying had worn itself into the earth.

He did not translate it. That was the discipline and he held it, and it cost him, and he let it cost him. Some sentences you don't carry off. He walked behind Mauricio with his throat full of words he would not say to anyone and felt, for once in his stateless life, like he was *in* a conversation instead of holding one up.

They came over the ridge. The rubble bit through his boots. His lungs made the high thin protest they made at any slope here, the air giving back about two-thirds of what it owed.

And on the far side, down on the saddle the line had refused — the easy saddle — were the others.

The mapping team. Four of them, around a tripod, in the good outdoor gear that the crew's funding could only dream of, the company name on the windbreakers in a font designed to look like discovery. Their drone was up. He could hear it before he saw it — the flat insect note that did not belong on this plain. They had a total station on the tripod, the laser kind that shoots a bearing and reads a prism, the kind of instrument that could lay a survey-grade line across this whole district in a week and never break a sweat.

They were trying to map the walk.

Bashir watched the lead surveyor — a decent enough man, he'd met him in La Paz, this was greed but it was *honest* greed, a man who genuinely believed he was *opening* something — watched him sight the total station along Rosa's line and read the bearing off and frown at it, and turn the instrument, and read it again. Because the instrument gave him a number. The number was correct. The number was useless. It told him where the line *went*. It could not tell him a single one of the words that put it there. He had the bearing and not the sentence. He had the largest drawing on Earth in his eyepiece, dead-straight, and not one syllable of what kept it straight, and his drone could hover over it for a thousand years and photograph it whole and never see the one thing about it that mattered, because the one thing about it had never been visible from the air.

You could not map a sentence by photographing the ground it had been said over.

The drone hung there, recording nothing.

Rosa did not look at them. She walked her line down off the ridge, said her word at the place the word went, and the team and their instrument might as well have been weather.

Jakobus was at the back. He almost always was.

He'd come the whole week the way he came everywhere — off his own ground, deferring, the weathered face that read a made thing for what it was *for* and then, every time, handed the reading to someone with more right to it than he had. He had not measured anything. He had not asked Rosa a single question that Bashir had heard. He had watched, and he had let Naila do the measuring and Bashir do the listening and Mara do the not-photographing, and he had carried the crew's two thermoses and never once made it about himself.

At the bottom of the ridge, where the line ran on flat and true toward a *chullpa* a kilometre off, Rosa stopped. The walking paused. The saying paused. The cold held them all.

And Jakobus stepped up — not ahead of the crew, level with them, hat in his scarred hands — and he asked her the question. The only question he ever asked. The one he'd asked of a wall in Anatolia and a script no one could read and a silence in a quiet town, the question

he was built around, the question that was the whole reason any of them had crossed an ocean to stand frostbitten on the roof of the world.

“¿Para qué es?” he said. *What is it for.*

Rosa looked at him. Then past him, at the line — running off straight toward the tower, climbing the next rise it had no business climbing, holding its bearing toward Sajama the way everything here held toward Sajama.

“Es para caminar,” she said.

It is for walking.

And that was all.

Bashir had every language. He turned the four words over in three of them, looking for the second meaning, the door behind the door — and found that there wasn't one, or rather that there were a thousand, and that she had said the only one she was going to say, and that she had said it complete. Not *I don't know*. Not the closed face of a secret. The open face of an answer that was whole and was hers and stopped exactly where she meant it to stop, with everything still inside it.

She was telling him where to stop. That was the trust.

Jakobus heard it. Bashir watched him hear it. The old fixer who could look at a thing humans made and tell you the function buried in it — the water map, the almanac, the key — looked at Rosa, and looked at the line, and put his hat back on his head.

“Sí,” he said. Yes. And nothing else.

He did not push. He did not name the question he was declining to answer; he just declined it, the way you set down a thing that was never yours to pick up. The function was *walking*. The line was for the walking and the walking was the line and there was no level under it for an outsider to lift the lid off, because there was no lid, because it had never been a box. He had read the made thing all the way down to the bottom and the bottom said *keep walking*, and he believed her, and he stood out of the way.

Down on the saddle the total station read its useless true number again.

Rosa said her word. The grandsons answered. Mauricio answered. And the line gathered itself and went on toward the tower, toward the mountain, toward the next place the word went, the way it had been going since before there were nations to ignore it.

The crew stepped back.

Not away — back. Off the line, onto the dark surface stones where they were not walking and so had no business being. Naila first, her notebook closed in her cold hand, the measurement she could not finish let go of at last and, somehow, lighter for it. Then Mara, camera capped, hands open and empty, watching the frame she would never take walk away from her toward the *chullpa*. Then Niamh, who had read all week the difference between *won't say* and *can't say* and had refused, every single time, to push the door that was Rosa's to keep shut. Then Bashir, with the sentence still ringing in him, unspoken, kept.

They stood off the line, in the rising cold-bright light, and they watched the largest thing human beings ever made go on being made, one word and one footstep at a time, the way it had to, the way it always had.

The drone ran out of battery and came down on the saddle with a small mechanical sigh.

Nobody up on the line looked back.

Chapter 19 — The Mapping Team Withdraws

The wind came up off the plain at first light and Mara felt it find the gap in her collar before she'd taken three steps from the truck. The *surazo*, Bashir had called it, the night the word came up over the stove — and like everything Bashir handed you, it arrived with its weight attached. A south wind. The kind that strips heat off skin and patience off people. By the time she crossed the frost-stiff grass toward the mapping team's compound, her hands were already in her pockets and the camera, for once, was zipped away.

She'd come to photograph the end of something. She didn't yet know whose.

The compound was three white expedition tents and a generator and a folding table that someone had bolted a satellite dish to, all of it pegged down hard against the wind. Tidy. That was the word that kept surfacing for her, the whole time they'd been here. The mapping team were *tidy* people. Their drone cases were foam-cut and labelled. Their survey stakes were flagged in the same orange, every one. Whatever else you wanted to say about the outfit that had flown in to "open" the Sajama Lines to the world, they had never once been sloppy, and they had never once been cruel. That was the part Mara had stopped expecting and couldn't stop noticing.

Reuben Castellanos was outside the largest tent with a mug in both hands and the dish behind him still ticking as it cooled. The project lead. Fifties, a geographer by training, a fundraiser by necessity. He'd given them the press release on day one without being asked — *Illuminating Bolivia's Forgotten Heritage* — and he'd meant every line of

it. That was the thing about him you had to hold and not flinch from. He wasn't a thief in a movie. He was a man who genuinely believed that a thing unseen was a thing being wasted.

"You came to watch us pack," he said. Not unkind.

"I came to watch," Mara said. "The rest is up to the wind."

He almost smiled. Behind him, two of his people were striking the smallest tent, working the poles down in the cold without gloves because gloves slowed you. The orange stakes were already pulled, bundled in a drum, the plain behind them gone back to plain.

The official story is the easy one to tell, and it deserves telling straight, because it was true. There are thousands of lines out here. Dead-straight, scored across the Altiplano around Nevado Sajama, Bolivia's highest mountain — a snow cone standing alone over the high pale grass, the thing you orient by from anywhere, the way you'd orient by a tower. The Aymara have made these lines and re-walked them for more than three thousand years. Ritual paths, linking the *wak'as* — the shrines, the rock where a thing happened, the spring — and the *chullpas*, the old funerary towers, and the villages, and the white chapels the practice folded in after the Spanish came, the way a river folds in a new stream and keeps flowing.

Not a monument. A living sacred landscape, still walked.

Tony Morrison brought them to the outside world's notice in the 1970s. UPenn's people surveyed them under the Tierra Sajama name. The work was real, the scholarship serious, the respect plain on the page. And Reuben Castellanos had read all of it, more carefully than Mara had, and had concluded — reasonably, defensibly — that the largest single artwork humans ever drew should not be the least visited.

"You know the figures better than I do," he said, when she'd settled on the upturned crate beside him because standing in that wind was its own argument. "Sixteen thousand kilometres of line. Three times the width of the continental United States, scratched into the ground with no wheel, no instrument. Twenty-two thousand square kilometres of it. Fifteen Nazcas." He turned the mug. "Nazca gets a hundred

thousand visitors. This gets us, and you, and a dozen herders who've walked it since they could walk."

"And you wanted to fix that."

"I wanted to *honour* it." He said it without heat, which was worse, somehow. "A boardwalk. Interpretive signage. A viewing platform on the ridge so people could see one line run twenty kilometres without bending. Funded. Real money. The kind that builds a school in the village while it's at it." He looked at her. "Tell me that's villainy."

She didn't, because it wasn't, and they both heard the silence agree with him.

☒ *"Viewing platform. To see the lines. The lines you can only read by walking them on the ground. So — a platform to see the thing the platform makes you stop doing. Bold. Build me a swimming pool to admire the ocean from."*

Here is the part the platform could never solve, and Mara had watched Naila prove it with her own lungs, four days ago, on a ridge a kilometre south of where they now sat packing.

A line out here runs one to three metres wide and up to twenty kilometres long, and it is held arrow-straight over broken ground. Not flat ground. *Broken* ground — hills it could skirt, ravines it could detour, and it does not skirt, it does not detour. It climbs the hill rather than go around it. It holds the bearing.

And the people who made it had no central authority telling them where to put it. No surveying instrument to sight along. And — this is the one that gets into your chest and stays — no elevated vantage. Nowhere to stand and check the line from above. The makers never had the view. The published survey says it without flinching: neither the purpose nor how the makers achieved such precision is completely understood.

Castellanos's team had brought the view. They'd brought everything. GPS, a total station, a drone with a camera that could read a number plate from the platform he'd wanted to build. And on the second day — Mara had the frames, she'd never sell them — they had tried, for

the fun of it and to settle a bet, to lay two hundred metres of survey-grade straight line over one low rise. Daylight. Vantage. A plan. Four trained people and a machine that did nothing but measure.

They'd come out the far side eleven centimetres off. Laughing about it, but off.

Eleven centimetres in two hundred metres, with the best kit on the continent and a god's-eye drone overhead to scold them.

The Aymara had held it over twenty kilometres of ridge and ravine. By hand. By foot. Piecemeal, across a hundred lifetimes, with nobody in command and nobody, ever, standing where they could see the whole of it.

That was the gap. Not *therefore aliens* — there were no aliens in this, the obscurity had spared it even that. Just the gap. The plain, measurable, eleven-centimetre gap between the planned daylight attempt and the flawless thing under their boots, and no closed door at the bottom of it.

A truck came up the track from the village. Not theirs — local plates, a man Mara recognised from the chapel and, beside him, smaller, wrapped against the cold, the woman the whole of this had finally turned on.

Mara wouldn't name her in a caption. She'd learned that much. The *yatiri* — Niamh had read her first, days ago, across a room, had read the difference in her face between *doesn't know* and *won't say* and had told the rest of them to stop pushing the second one. She got down from the truck slowly, the way you move at four thousand metres when you've nothing to prove, and she crossed to Castellanos and stood in front of him, and she did not ask him to leave.

She thanked him.

Bashir had drifted up from somewhere and was at Mara's shoulder, low, giving her the Aymara under the Spanish under the wind — not translating so much as *carrying*, the way he did, the words arriving with their hooks in. The *yatiri* thanked Castellanos for the offer of the school. She said the offer was good. She said the children would be glad of it and named two of them, which was its own kind of answer,

because you don't refuse a man and then list his potential beneficiaries by name unless you mean for the door to stay on its hinges.

Then she said something Bashir didn't render for a moment, and when he did his voice had gone careful.

"She says — the line stays bright because feet keep it bright. She says if you build the platform, the feet stop, and then there is no line, only a place where a line was. She says you would be photographing the grave of the thing you came to honour."

Castellanos didn't answer right away. The wind moved the tent canvas. One of his people had stopped striking the second tent and was just standing, listening, the pole half-collapsed in her hands.

"I checked it," he said finally. To Bashir, but meaning her. "Your colleague. Naila. The straightness — I had my own people run it before I'd believe it from a stranger. We couldn't match it. I want you to know I couldn't pretend that away." He set the mug down on the crate, deliberate. "I came here certain that what was missing was *attention*. That the only reason the world's largest drawing was invisible was that nobody had pointed at it." He looked at the plain, the long lines running off it toward the mountain, pale on pale, legible only to a foot. "And I've spent two weeks learning that it's not invisible. It's just not for the eye. You can stand on every ridge in this district and you will not see it. The only people it was ever visible to are the ones moving along it, saying —" he stopped. "Saying whatever it is they say. Which is none of mine."

He turned to the *yatiri* and inclined his head, slightly, the gesture of a man who knew the local words for *forgive me* and had decided the smaller, surer Spanish would carry less risk of getting them wrong.

"We'll file it as paused," he said. "Officially. Pending community consent. Which is a phrase that means *no* and lets everyone keep their funding intact, and I'd rather you knew that than thought I'd dressed it up." A breath of something almost rueful. "The department will defer to the community. I'll see to it personally. It costs me a platform. It does not cost me a school." He glanced at Mara. "I'd like that on the record, if your photographer's willing."

Mara had her hands in her pockets and the camera zipped away and she kept it that way.

“I’ll write it,” she said. “I won’t shoot it. Not this.”

He looked at her for a second longer than the words needed, and she watched him understand that the refusal was the compliment — that the most sellable frame in two thousand kilometres, the white tent and the wrapped elder and the great blank mountain behind them, the *adversary concedes* frame that would have run on every wire — was being put down on purpose, the way you put a drone down on purpose, and that this was the only way she had of telling him she’d seen him clearly and decided not to take the easy thing either.

“Right,” he said. “Yes. All right.”

☒ *“Hang on. He had GPS, a robot, a plan, daylight, and a view — and he’s leaving because the people with none of that did it better and won’t tell him how. That’s not a defeat, that’s a man getting humbled by a footpath and being gracious about it. I’ve lost to less and sulked harder.”*

They struck the last tent inside the hour. The orange stakes were in the drum, the dish folded down, the generator silent. The compound went back to grass and the grass had already half-forgotten it. Mara stood with the crew at the edge of where it had been and watched the trucks load.

Naila was beside her, not quite looking at the lines, the way she did when a thing wouldn’t resolve and she’d made her peace with that — not solved, *witnessed*, which she’d decided was a different and survivable thing. She’d run the geometry to the edge of what the instruments could do and she’d come to the same wall Castellanos had, the eleven-centimetre wall, and instead of leaning on it she’d taken her hand off it.

“He’s not wrong, you know,” Naila said. “About the attention. The biggest thing humans ever drew, and almost nobody’s looked at it.”

“No,” Mara said. “He’s not wrong about that part.”

“He’s just wrong about what looking is.”

The *yatiri* and the man from the chapel got back in their truck. Before

it pulled away she said something to Bashir through the window, and he stood there with it a moment after the truck had gone, the wind taking the dust off the track.

“What?” Mara said.

He didn’t answer at first. Then: “She said we can come at dawn. The day after tomorrow. One line. Over the ridge.” He turned the words over in his mouth like he was checking them for hooks. “She said — to walk it. Not to bring the machine. Not to bring the camera.” A pause. “She didn’t say not to bring you. She said not to bring the camera. They’re not the same thing, the way she said it.”

Mara looked at the line that ran from somewhere near her boots straight up the rise and over and down the far side toward the mountain, refusing the easy ground, holding the bearing nobody had stood high enough to set.

She thought about the eleven centimetres.

“No,” she said. “They’re not the same thing.”

The mountain held its snow against the violet zenith and the lines ran out under it, pale, dead-straight, kept bright by feet, and waited — as they had for three thousand years — for the morning someone walked them again.

Chapter 20 — The Road Home

The Beast wouldn't start until the sun cleared the queñua, and Naila found she didn't mind waiting. Cold had got into the diesel overnight the way it got into everything here — the water in the jerry can skinned with ice, her own breath frozen to the inside of the canvas, the camera batteries dead until Mara warmed them against her stomach like eggs. The plain held the night long after the sky let go of it. Frost lay blue in the shadow of every tussock.

She had her notebook open on her knees. She had filled most of it.

There were the bearings she'd taken with the hand compass, page after page, and the corrections she'd worked back from them, and the long column of numbers where she'd tried — for nine days — to make the straightness do what straightness was supposed to do, which was *resolve*. A line is the shortest distance between two points. That is the whole of it. Give Naila two points and an afternoon and she would give you a line, and it would be true, because she had a horizon to lay it against and a level to swear by and the patience to walk it twice.

The line above the village had none of that and was straighter than hers.

She'd measured it. That was the part she kept coming back to, the part her hands believed before the rest of her did. She'd set the surveyor's app and the borrowed total station — the mapping company's, lent for an hour by a sheepish junior tech before his supervisor noticed — against a segment that ran two kilometres over a low rise and down the far side, a segment nobody alive could see end to end from any point on the ground. The deviation across that span was

less than the width of the line itself. A metre, in two thousand. Held over a hill that hid one end from the other.

“You’ve read that page forty times,” Bashir said. He was sitting on the running board with a tin mug going cold in his hands, watching the woodsmoke come up off the village in straight grey columns because there was no wind yet. There was never wind, at this hour. The *surazo* slept till afternoon.

“I keep waiting for it to be wrong,” Naila said.

“Is it?”

“No.” She closed the book on her thumb. “That’s the problem. If it were wrong I could fix it.”

They had agreed to leave, the night before, around the stove in the long adobe room, and the agreeing had not felt like a decision so much as a tide going out. Frik had said it first, in the gap between two tics, the way the truest things came out of him — *we should go before we start owning it*. Nobody argued. Niamh had watched the *yatiri*’s face when the words were interpreted to her and then signed something short and flat to her terp, who relayed it without softening: *She already knew that. She’s been waiting to see if you did.*

So: out-read again. Naila was getting used to the feeling, which was not a comfortable feeling and was not meant to be.

She had wanted to solve it. She could say that now, to the page if to no one else. She had come up the plain certain that the straightness was a *how* with an answer, a clever procedure lost to time that a careful enough mind could reverse-engineer — fire-cairns sighted at night, maybe, or a chain of walkers calling bearings, or the old beautiful trick of three stakes and a sightline repeated and repeated up the slope. She’d modelled every one of them. She’d built the cairn version in her notebook and walked the math up the ridge and watched the error accumulate, the way error always accumulates, a degree begetting a degree, until two kilometres out her best honest reconstruction wandered eleven metres off true.

Eleven metres. The real line wandered one.

“You want to know the thing I can’t write down,” she said.

Bashir tipped his head. He had a way of going still when someone was about to hand him a sentence that mattered — the polyglot's stillness, she thought, the ear clearing itself.

"It isn't that they were better than me," Naila said. "I could believe that. Better surveyors than me have existed. It's that they *weren't surveying*. Nobody was holding the whole line in their head. There was no whole line in anybody's head, ever, not once in three thousand years. It got built a few hundred metres at a time by people who'd never see the far end and never wanted to. And it's straighter than the thing I'd build *with* the far end."

"And that's—"

"That's not a how question." She looked at the rise above the village, at the pale scratch of the line going up it and over and not coming back. "I had the wrong question the whole way up the plain. I kept asking how they kept it straight. Wrong verb. They didn't *keep* it anything. The straight is just — what's left. After."

After what, the obvious follow-up, she did not say, because she had already learned where that question stopped being hers.

The *yatiri* came up from the village while the diesel was still too cold to turn over. She came on foot, the way she came everywhere, in the layered skirts and the hard small hat and the woven *aguayo* knotted at her shoulder, and she did not hurry, because nobody on this plain hurried; hurry cost air you didn't have. She stopped a few metres off and looked at the Beast and the half-loaded gear and the crew arranged around it in the postures of people who had decided to go but hadn't moved yet.

She said something to Bashir. Naila caught maybe one word in five now, after nine days — enough to hear the shape, not the sense.

Bashir answered her in the Aymara that had half-opened this whole door, the careful courteous register he'd worked at for years before any of them knew her, and the *yatiri* allowed herself the small upward pull at the corner of her mouth that was, on her, a whole conversation. She answered him. He went quiet for a moment, the way he'd gone quiet twice now this trip when a sentence came at him that he could carry but had decided not to hand on.

“She’ll walk us to the road,” he said. “Part of the way. There’s a line that runs near it.”

They went on foot the last stretch to where the Beast could meet them, the *yatiri* setting the pace, which was slow and even and not slow at all once you tried to match it uphill at four thousand metres with your lungs filing a complaint at every step. The line ran along their left hand for a while, the bright scrape of it holding to its bearing while the path they walked drifted and wandered the way paths do, finding the easy ground, going around the rock the line went over.

Mara walked with the camera down. She’d had it down for days. The drone had gone back in its case after the second morning and never come out — Naila had watched her decide that, watched the most sellable frame in the whole hemisphere offer itself, the god’s-eye sweep up the line and over the ridge, the shot that would have run on every magazine in the world under the words *largest drawing on Earth* — and watched her put it away. The aerial view was the one that lied. They all knew it now. From above, the line was a line. From the feet, walking it, in order, it was — something the feet knew and the eye couldn’t be told.

The *yatiri* walked beside the line and her lips moved. Not at them. Not for them. She was naming as she went — Naila could see that much, could see the rhythm of it even without the words, the saying-while-walking that Bashir had heard down to its grammar and had told them, once, carefully, what it *was* and not at all what it *said*. The naming held the bearing. The line was the fossil of the saying. You did not read it. You walked it and you said it and the straight was the residue of having said it right, in order, for three thousand years, and if you stopped saying it the ground would forget and green over and the largest thing humans ever drew would be gone in a generation of unwalked rain.

There was a fish in Naila’s head by now — there was a fish in everyone’s head by now, an editorial heckle that had attached itself to the crew somewhere around Book One and would not be dislodged — and it chose this exact reverent moment to observe, *sure, it’s a sentence, it’s a three-thousand-year-old sentence nobody will translate for us, that’s not ominous at all, that’s fine*.

She let it heckle. It wasn't wrong, exactly. It just wasn't the point, and the not-being-the-point was the point.

Where the path met the track, the Beast was waiting with Jakobus leaning against the warm bonnet, having got it started somehow, the way he got everything started somehow, off home ground always and never once in charge of it. He'd been ahead of them and apart from them the whole trip, the road and never the lead, deferring, handing the moment over, and he did the last of that here.

He looked at the line. He looked at the *yatiri*. He asked her the question — through Bashir, in the careful tongue, the one question the whole crew existed to ask of a made thing, the question that had cracked open a stone temple and a hill of buried silence and a book no one could read.

What is it for.

The *yatiri* looked at him for a while. The morning had warmed enough now that the frost was off the tussocks and the first thread of *surazo* was coming up off the salt flat to the south. She looked at the line running up the rise and over and not coming back, and she looked at the crew who had come a long way to ask, and she did not look annoyed and she did not look like a keeper of secrets, which was the thing Naila would remember — she looked like a woman being asked, kindly and from a great distance, to explain what walking was.

She said three words. Bashir didn't translate them right away. He stood with them in his mouth the way you'd stand with something fragile, and then he gave them over, plain, no decoration:

"It is for walking."

And Jakobus nodded, slow, like a man who'd just been handed the answer he came for — because he had, Naila understood, that *was* the answer, that was the function, grounded and physical and complete: a thing you walk, that exists in the walking, that the walking *is*. He went quiet then. He didn't reach for more. He read it into her hand and stepped back, and the moment belonged to the *yatiri*, where it had always belonged.

The fish in Naila's head said nothing at all.

The *yatiri* didn't come to the track. She stopped where the line did, where the path's drift and the line's bearing finally parted company for good, and she turned. Not a goodbye, exactly. She put her hand flat to her chest and inclined her head to Bashir, the courtesy returned, and she said one more thing that he carried but didn't pass on, and then she stepped off the easy path and onto the bright scrape of the line, and she went up the rise, naming as she walked, holding the bearing, and over the top of it, and she did not come back, because the line did not come back, because that was not what the line was for.

They watched her until the rise took her.

"Right," said Frik, eventually, to no one, in the gap. "Right. *Okay.*"

Mara had the camera up. Just for a second. She framed the empty rise and the line going over it and the white cone of Sajama presiding behind, and then she lowered it without pressing anything, and looked at the screen that held nothing, and put it in the case.

"You didn't take it," Naila said.

"No." Mara latched the case. "It's not on the rise. It went over with her."

They loaded the last of the gear in a silence that wasn't sad and wasn't easy. Naila got in beside Bashir. She had her notebook still open on her knee, the column of numbers, the eleven metres and the one metre and the long honest record of every way she'd tried to make the straightness be a thing she could own and take home and explain at a conference with a laser pointer.

She didn't close it. She left it open. She'd decided, somewhere on the walk, to leave that page open in the back matter exactly as it was — every failed model, every accumulating degree, the whole record of the not-solving — because the not-solving was the truest thing she'd measured up here, truer than the deviation, truer than the scale.

The Beast pulled onto the track and the plain began to slide past, ochre and bone and that violet zenith, and the line ran along their left hand for a while longer, holding its bearing while they took the

easy road, until the track bent away around a hill the way roads do, around the thing the line went over.

"Question," said Bashir, watching it go.

"Go on."

"Nobody commissioned it. Nobody ever saw it whole. Three thousand years of separate feet, no king, no instrument, no hill to read it from." He paused. "So what told all of them to keep it straight?"

Naila looked at the line until the hill took it.

"She did," she said. "Just then. Walking up the rise. That's the whole answer, and we're not going to get it, and that's correct."

The fish, for once, agreed. The road home unspooled ahead of them, and behind them the plain forgot nothing, because somebody was still walking it.

Chapter 21 — The Wink

The mapping team's diesel generator had stopped sometime in the night, and the silence it left was the loudest thing on the plain.

Bashir noticed it the way he noticed everything — sideways, through the ear, before the rest of him caught up. He was sitting on the cold step of the *estancia* with a tin mug going lukewarm in his hands, and the absence of that low industrial drone was a hole in the soundscape he kept reaching into, expecting to snag something. Nothing. Just the *surazo* moving the *paja brava* in long combed waves, and somewhere far off a single dog deciding whether it cared.

Down the slope, the orange tents were coming apart. Two of the surveyors were folding the tripod legs of the total station into their padded case with the tenderness men reserve for instruments that cost more than a house. The drone cases were already stacked. Vargas — the project lead, clean hands, good shoes, a man Bashir had decided early he could not quite hate — stood with a clipboard he was no longer writing on, watching his people pack.

It hadn't been a rout. That was the part nobody back home would understand. There'd been no shouting, no permit waved, no flashing light. There had been a conversation, in Aymara, that Bashir had carried between Vargas and the community council for the better part of an afternoon, and at the end of it the answer had simply been *no*, *not now*, *perhaps not*. And Vargas had nodded the way a reasonable man nods when he has run out of leverage and discovered, to his own surprise, that he is relieved.

"They'll be back," Naila said. She'd come out without a coat, which meant she'd been awake a while and had stopped registering temperature, which meant she'd been turning something over. She sat down

on the step below him, close enough that he could feel the heat she radiated when her mind was working. “Different outfit. Better funded. Five years.”

“Probably.”

“And it greens over if they stop walking it.” She said it flatly, a fact filed. “So the thing keeps itself safe by needing to be done. You can’t archive a verb.”

He let that sit. The light was just starting — that first violet bleed at the rim of the world that, at this altitude, didn’t look like dawn so much as the sky being slowly switched on from somewhere behind it. Sajama was already lit at the crown, the cone going from grey to a pink so clean it embarrassed the word *pink*. Everything else on the plain was still the colour of ash and bone, waiting.

Here is the official story, and it is true, and the people who wrote it down did honest work.

Around four thousand years ago — give or take the way you have to give or take when nobody was writing it down — people on this plain began to walk between the places that mattered. A spring. A rock where something had happened. A tower of stacked stone where they laid their dead. They walked, and where they walked the dark oxidised crust of the desert scuffed away under their feet and the pale subsoil came up, a bright line drawn by the simple arithmetic of going there and going there again. They added the springs and the rocks. The Inca came and went — *came and went*, on a thing already old enough that the Inca treated it as ancestral. The Spanish came and built white chapels, and the walking absorbed the chapels too, the way a river absorbs a stone, without changing course.

Tony Morrison saw them from the air in the 1970s and told the world there was something here. Surveyors from Pennsylvania came and measured what they could. They wrote it up plainly, with the proper professional honesty that says *we know this and we do not know that*: a living sacred landscape, the lines maintained by use, sixteen thousand kilometres of them scored across twenty-two thousand square kilometres of ground. The largest single artwork human beings have ever made. Still being made. The instructions for its continuation

are *keep going*.

That's the story. Bashir had spent three weeks inside its language and he believed every word of it. None of it was the hole.

Mara was up on the rise with the long lens, and she wasn't shooting.

He watched her not shoot for a while, which was its own kind of thing to watch. The light was doing what light does maybe twice a year on a plain like this — laying itself flat across the ground so that every scraped line stood up in low relief, bright trough and dark shoulder, and the whole web of it suddenly readable in a way it never was in the hard noon glare. A photographer who put that frame on a wall would not have to work again. She had the camera up. She had the exposure. Bashir saw her thumb find the shutter and rest on it, the way you rest a finger on a trigger you have decided not to pull, and then she lowered the body to her chest and just looked, with the eyes she was born with, at a thing she had decided was not hers to take down off the mountain.

He understood that. He had spent the whole book learning to understand that.

There was a sentence — he would not write it down, he would not even shape it fully in the part of his mind that translated — that the *yatiri* had said while they walked, three days ago, on the high segment where the line climbed the ridge it had no earthly reason to climb. She had said it not to him and not to teach him. She had said it *to the going*, the way you say the next word in a thing you are in the middle of saying. And his ear, which could not not parse a language's shape, had caught the grammar of it whole — the verb that held the bearing, the naming that came in an order that was not negotiable, the way the saying and the stepping were one motion and you could not have the line without both.

He had understood, walking it, what no map had told him and no drone could. The straightness was not engineering. Nobody had *solved* the hill. The line went over the ridge because the sentence went over the ridge, and the sentence did not bend because sentences do not bend — you say them in order or you have said something else. The line was the fossil of a saying. The largest drawing on

Earth was legible only to the feet that made it, in the language that walked it.

And he was not going to tell anyone the sentence. That was the discipline. The man whose entire gift was reaching all the way in had found the one room where reaching all the way in was a theft, and had been answered — not by being let in, but by being trusted enough to be shown where the wall was.

But here is the thing, and it is a real thing, and you can check it.

A sentence does not need to be straight.

You can say the words to the spring and then the words to the tower in the right order and in the right breath while you walk, and you will get *there* — you'll arrive at the tower, the bearing held in your mouth the whole way. Nothing in the saying requires that the *trail* run true. A path that wandered would still be the sentence. A path that took the easy contour around the ridge, that did the sensible thing your lungs are screaming for at four thousand metres, would still link the spring to the tower in the right order and could carry exactly the same words.

But it doesn't wander. That's the hole, and it never closed.

Naila had measured it with a cold eye and no woo and she'd come to peace with it without explaining it away. Up to twenty kilometres at a stretch, a metre wide, dead straight over hills and ravines and the broken ground that has no opinion about your ritual and will happily put a rise between you and where you're going. Held straight by a society with no king to command it, no instrument to sight by, no hill high enough and central enough to read the whole thing from and say *that one's drifting, walk it back*. Built not by one crew in one season but by separate people, separate generations, three thousand years of them, each only ever seeing the few kilometres in front of their own feet.

No one ever saw it whole. There was no vantage. There still isn't, not from the ground — you need an aircraft, and the makers had no aircraft, which is precisely why the aircraft view explains nothing.

So who held the bearing?

Not a person — there was no person who could have. Not a plan — nobody's found a plan, and you don't plan a thing across a hundred and twenty generations. Not the saying — Bashir was sure of the saying now, surer than he'd ever been of anything he'd carried between two tongues, and the saying did not require the straightness. The saying could have curved. Something kept it from curving. Something told three thousand years of separate walkers, none of whom saw the whole and none of whom were ordered to, to refuse the easy contour and climb the hill and hold the line arrow-true over ground that gave them every reason and every cover to let it drift.

He sat on the cold step with his cold tea and felt the question sit down next to him, and he did not answer it.

"You've got your closed-mouth face," Naila said.

"I've got my no-comment face. They're different."

"To you."

The *yatiri* came up the track from the lower estancia then, unhurried, a small woman in a brown *pollera* and a hat the wind kept trying for and never quite got, with the rolling economical walk of someone who had spent a life not wasting a single step on this plain. She did not look at the orange tents coming down. She had already, days ago, looked at them exactly as much as she intended to.

She stopped where the line crossed the track — the bright pale scar of it running away north toward Sajama, away south toward a chapel Bashir couldn't see — and she stood on it for a moment with both feet, settling, the way you settle into a thing you're about to continue rather than begin.

Mara, on the rise, did not lift the camera.

The *yatiri* said something, low, to the going, and stepped off north along the line. Two others fell in behind her without a word, an old man and a girl maybe twelve, and the three of them walked the bright scar away from the crew, scuffing it that little bit brighter as they went, keeping it true over the first low swell of ground simply by putting their feet where the words said to put them.

Bashir's ear caught the front edge of what she'd said — enough to

know it was the naming, the order, the bearing held in the mouth. Not enough, and not for him, to be the whole of it.

Behind them the line greened a little less. Ahead of them it stayed bright. The difference between those two facts was the entire reason any of it still existed, and it was being maintained, right now, by three people walking who would be dust before the question they were answering had even been properly asked.

“What’s it for?” Naila said quietly — not to him. To the plain. To the walkers getting smaller. She was asking it the way Jakobus had asked it, three dawns back, and she already knew the only answer she was going to get, which was the answer Jakobus had been given and had gone quiet for: *it is for walking*.

A function, grounded and physical. A bearing held in a sentence, walked into the ground, kept bright by the keeping. That much was real and you could put your hand on it. The crew owned the telling of it. They never came within a continent of owning the thing.

But the function didn’t close the hole. That was the strange beauty of it. You could know exactly what the line was *for* — for walking, for saying, for going to the spring and the tower in the right order with the right words — and still be left holding the one fact the function did not explain. The saying could have curved. It didn’t. No king said don’t. No surveyor said don’t. No one stood high enough to even know it hadn’t.

The walkers crested the swell and went down the far side, and for a moment only the *yatiri*’s hat was visible above the line, a dark dot riding the bright thread north toward the mountain, and then that too dropped from sight, and the line ran on without them up the ridge it had no reason to climb, holding its bearing for whoever came next, true as a drawn breath, over a hill no one ever stood on top of to check.

So. Sixteen thousand kilometres. Three thousand years. No command, no instrument, no vantage, no one who ever saw it whole.

Something kept it straight.

You decide what.

Chapter 22 — Real, Debated, Invented

The notebook is the one thing Bashir packs the way other people pack a passport: spine cracked open, rubber band gone slack, the cover gone the colour of the plain. He had meant, on the drive down off the Altiplano, to write nothing. To let the walk stay in his feet and not in ink. But the road from Sajama village runs four hours of washboard before it touches asphalt, and you cannot translate a road, and the silence of not-translating is the loudest thing he knows, so the pen comes out.

Hecklefish, riding the dash in his travel bowl, watches the pen the way a cat watches a laser.

“Oh good,” he says. “The part where we *show our work*. Everybody loves a man’s homework.”

“It’s not homework,” Bashir says. “It’s a gazetteer.”

“It’s homework with a fancy hat.”

What goes in the gazetteer is this, and the crew agreed on it the night before, in the cold of the *estancia*, by the woodsmoke, with the interpreter’s hands moving for Niamh and Mara’s lens capped on the table where it had stayed for two days: *we write down only what we can stand behind*. Real. Debated. Invented. Three columns and a hard wall between them. The wall is the whole point.

REAL.

The lines are real. You can stand on one. Bashir did — a strip of pale

ground a metre wide running off toward the white cone, the darker oxidised surface scraped away to bare the lighter subsoil beneath, and it ran *straight*, not the apologetic straight of a footpath that mostly wants to be where the walking is easy, but the other kind. The kind that climbs the hill rather than skirt it. He measured nothing. Naila measured everything.

The numbers are real and they do not get smaller the longer you look at them. Roughly **sixteen thousand kilometres** of line. Naila had said the comparison out loud on the plain, flat, the way she says true things: about three times the width of the continental United States, laid end to end, drawn by foot, with no wheel and no instrument and no plan anyone has ever turned up. The patterned ground covers something on the order of **twenty-two and a half thousand square kilometres** — call it fifteen Nazcas — which makes it, very probably, the **largest single archaeological artwork on Earth**, and — this is the part Naila kept turning over like a stone with a wrong weight — **one of the least studied**. A single line can run **up to twenty kilometres, one to three metres wide**, and hold its bearing over hills and ravines the entire way.

And here is the column-one fact that the others all lean on, the one that is not a flourish: the lines have been **made and re-walked for more than three thousand years**. They were ancient when the Inca came up onto the plain. They are walked in Aymara ritual *today*. Nazca fell silent. Sajama never did. The line stays bright because feet keep scraping it. Stop walking, and the dark surface creeps back, and the largest drawing on Earth begins, quietly, to close its own eyes.

The names that brought it to the outside world go in column one too, with respect and no decoration. **Tony Morrison** — the British explorer and filmmaker, not the novelist, and Bashir writes the disambiguation in because someone always asks — brought the lines to wider attention in the **1970s**. The University of Pennsylvania's **Tierra Sajama** project surveyed them. The published record, drawing on that work, says the thing plainly, and Bashir copies it out word for word because paraphrase is a way of taking: *neither the purpose nor how the makers achieved such precision is completely understood*.

"That's the whole book, isn't it," Hecklefish says, reading upside down, which he claims he can do. "They wrote your wink for you and put it in a survey. Lazy."

“They wrote a fact,” Bashir says. “We’re borrowing it.”

There is a credit before any of it, and it goes at the *top*, not the back. Bashir is firm on this and Mara backs him and that settles it.

The lines belong to the Aymara communities of the Sajama district. The walking is theirs. The reading of the walking is theirs. Nothing in the gazetteer was gathered without leave, and the one thing that mattered most — the words said while walking, the saying that holds the bearing — is not in the gazetteer at all, because the *yatiri* did not give it, and a thing withheld is not a thing you go and fetch from elsewhere and slide in through the side door. Niamh had read that distinction off the woman’s face before any of them, the way she reads every room: the difference between *doesn’t know* and *won’t say*. She’d put two fingers flat on the table. *Won’t say*. Leave it.

So the gazetteer thanks the community, by the protocol they asked for, and stops where they asked it to stop. That stopping is the most honest line in the chapter. Bashir knows it. He writes it small and means it large.

DEBATED.

Then the column that earns its keep: the potato. What the crew *tried*, and what failed, written down without flinching, because the failures are the most useful thing they own.

Attempt one: the eye in the sky. They flew the drone the first afternoon, before they knew better. They pulled the satellite tiles. They had the god’s-eye view that “solved” Nazca for the postcard racks — the whole web from above, radiating off the *wak’as* and the *chullpas* and the white chapels like cracks in old glaze. And it explained nothing. It was the most powerful tool any of them had ever carried up a mountain and it was a dead end that *looked* like progress, because — and Naila said this last, after a long quiet — **the makers never had it**. No one who scraped a metre of that line ever saw the line whole. The view that flatters the outsider is the one view three thousand years of walkers were denied. *Failed: the map is not the made thing. The made thing is the walking.*

Attempt two: the straight line, by daylight, with everything. This is the potato proper and Bashir gives it room. The adversary's mapping team — clean-handed, well-funded, not villains, just certain — had set up to lay a survey-grade line over a low ridge, to demonstrate, they said, how achievable the precision was. They had a total station. They had GPS. They had a vantage, a plan, daylight, and a man whose entire job was straightness. And they made a potato. The line wandered at the ridge crest where the slope stole the sightline; it had to be back-corrected; it took a morning and a crew and a battery they kept swapping, and at the end of it they had a few hundred metres of decent-but-not-arrow line and a lot of opinions about wind.

The makers had no instrument. No vantage. No one in command. They built it piecemeal across millennia, different hands, different lifetimes, no king to enforce a standard — and held it dead-straight for twenty kilometres for three thousand years.

"So the rich guys with the laser lost to dead people with no shoes," Hecklefish says, delighted, vicious, exactly right.

"The rich guys with the laser," Bashir says, "had a vantage and a plan and they wandered at the ridge. That's the column. Write it cold."

He writes it cold. *Failed: precision is not the hard part with instruments. It is the hard part without them. The gap between the planned daylight attempt and the flawless hand-and-foot result is the thing — not a wonder reached past, a wonder measured.*

Attempt three: Naila's model. She had wanted, for two days, to derive it — to find the trick, the back-sight cairn, the fire-by-night, the sighting-rod chain, the human method that produced the line, and to prove it was *neither* trivial footpath *nor* impossible woo but achievable, human, and stranger than both. She got partway. A radial system, sightlines node to node, the logic of a *ceque* scaled across a district — the Cusco shrines were organised on radial lines out from a centre, and Sajama reads like that idea grown to mountain size. It is a real and grounded frame. It accounts for the *radiating*. It does not, on its own, account for the *holding* — the refusal to bend for the ridge, kept by separate hands over three thousand years with no one to enforce it.

Naila had stood on the plain at the end and not finished the model. She'd said, in her flat way, that she was at peace not finishing it,

and Bashir had watched her decide that was true and then make it true, which is harder than it sounds and is not the same as giving up. *Failed, and the failure is the finding: the pattern is real, measurable, humanly achieved — and not closed. Leave it open. Do not reach.*

INVENTED.

And now the small fenced paddock at the back, the one that exists so the wall stays visible: the fringe, labelled as fringe, never the narrator's anything.

There isn't much. That is itself the point and Bashir writes it down: unlike Nazca, with its spacecraft runway and its hummingbird for the believers, Sajama has been spared a developed woo tradition, because the world has barely looked at it. Obscurity was its armour. The honest open question here is internal to archaeology — *how, by hand, by foot* — not a claim about builders from elsewhere. That is exactly what makes the hole strong. It has nowhere fashionable to go.

What little reaching there was on this trip, Bashir attributes to the human who did the reaching, because a flaw belongs to a person, not to the page. One of the adversary's surveyors — frustrated at the ridge, watching his corrected line and the ancient uncorrected one run parallel and the old one straighter — had said, low, half to himself, that you could lay a grid like that off a sightline from *above*, that the geometry was too clean for ground-level work, that maybe someone, somehow, had surveyed it from the sky.

Bashir writes the man's over-reach down and labels it *his*. An Earth-energy grid, a ley-line lattice, a line sighted from space — these are things a tired, certain man reaches for at the foot of a ridge that just beat his laser. They are not findings. The narrator does not hold them. They go in the *Invented* column with a name attached and a note: *over-reach, dramatised, the flaw of a fallible man, never the book's verdict.*

"You're being awfully nice to the guy who tried to steal it," Hecklefish observes.

"He didn't steal it," Bashir says. "He got out-read and he stepped back. The locals said no, and we said no with them, and his project's

paused. That's in column one." He looks up. "He's clean-handed. He's just wrong about the sky."

"That's the nicest thing you've ever said about anyone."

"It's the truest. They're not the same, but here they overlap."

The road touches asphalt. The washboard stops, and the silence changes register, and Bashir feels the specific relief he never says out loud — the one that comes when the noise of a hard problem resolves into something with clean grammar, the way a crowded room resolves into one language he can finally rest inside. The gazetteer has that grammar now. Real, fenced from debated, fenced from invented. The wall holds.

He gets to the endnote, the last thing, and he sits with it longer than the rest combined.

Because the temptation is to *finish*. To put the wink in his own mouth and answer it, to be the clever outsider who cracked it, and he can feel exactly how good that would feel and exactly why it would be a theft. The *yatiri* out-read every one of them on the thing that mattered. She walked the line with the words that held it and gave them the walking and kept the saying, and when Jakobus — last of all, off his home ground as always, deferring as always — had asked her the only question the crew were ever really built to ask, *what is it for*, she had given him the only answer that was hers to give, and given it to *him*, not to the page, and let it land in his weathered hands where he went quiet and handed the moment straight back to her.

It is for walking.

Bashir does not put that in column one as a solution, because it isn't one. He puts the walking itself in column one — ongoing, alive, theirs — and he leaves the rest where it belongs.

So the endnote, when he finally writes it, is short. The lines are still being walked. The practice did not pause when the cameras came and will not pause when they go; the cameras are not load-bearing and never were. The hole stays open because it is honest, not because anyone failed to close it. The map never told it. The instruments never held it. And the question the survey itself left lying in plain

sight — the one no debunk shut and no believer earned —

he writes it down, exactly, and does not answer it:

No king commissioned this, and no one alive ever saw it whole. So what told three thousand years of separate walkers — different hands, different lifetimes, nobody in command — to keep every line arrow-straight over the hills?

Then he closes the notebook, snaps the slack rubber band back over the cracked spine, and watches the white cone shrink in the wing mirror, still presiding, still the thing the whole plain orients by, still being walked.

“You didn’t answer it,” Hecklefish says, almost gentle, for him.

“No,” Bashir says. “It wasn’t mine to answer.”

The cone drops below the ridgeline. The line is still up there, bright, because somewhere behind them feet are keeping it that way.



Klaus

Custos, non Conditor